What Lingers in the Shadows

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/40168731.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
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Additional Tags:
Superhero Au!, Superhero Adora, aka ms overachiever, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Grief/Mourning, But also not really at all, Friends to Lovers, complicated childhood friends to lovers!, secretive government agenda, y'know the works, Motorcycle Catra, yeehaw, Mutual Pining, Idiots in Love, Self-Worth Issues, also burnout in your twenties, bc holy fuck man what the fuck, Anxious Adora (She-Ra), but is there really any other flavor of Adora, Cat!Melog, Dog!Swift Wind

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What Lingers in the Shadows

by stingingscorpion

Summary

She-Ra is the biggest hero in all of Bright Moon. She's a household name, an inspiration, a celebrity, a face no soul can't recognize. Yet, they know nothing about her. Day and night she operates, underneath carefully coordinated government plans. She runs from one end of the city to the next in a blink, performing miracles left and right. She's there for every danger, every threat opposed to the modern man. She takes the punches, puffs her chest out against danger. Other than She-Ra's secretive identity, thousands ask the question: how does she do it? Isn't she tired? When will she reach her breaking point?

How much longer will she be able to protect the city like this?

Bright Moon's Brightest Star, Part One: A Hero's Winning Smile

Chapter Notes

> So technically this story was the first ever SPOP story I had ever outlined, with the idea of Adora being an overworked hero because 1. she's Adora and 2. I feel like burnout and excessive working is an extremely relatable thing for almost everyone these days.
> The reason some chapters will have "part __" in the title is primarily for a more comic book feel, like everything is being released in "issues". I did this a long time ago and accidentally created this feeling and wanted to bring it back for this story. Otherwise I'm a huge believer of giant chapter releases haha.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Vertically the road splits in two, cracking within itself beyond its own control. Asphalt flies in every direction from the force, furthering the destruction into car windows, street lights, and the feet of innocent bystanders. It isn't the fact the culprit is moving so fast. She's not worried about the speed; she'll catch him. It's the inconvenience of stopping and saving every soul in the street before they can be knocked on the head with debris.

From her forearm flies her shield, a golden, shimmering solid metal piece which manages to save a few skulls from concussions. Adora throws the weapon down the street, saving another bystander, and by the time she can propel herself to them, she's in the perfect spot to protect the next person. She has backup here, sure, but none of them are as quick as her. They're on the block behind her, looking after those stunned in the streets, those with anxiety paralyzing their own legs. There's no need to worry. It'll all be dealt with soon.

Things begin to drag on, and she decides this person is getting away with far too much for far too long. She takes a running start, launching herself into the air. Adora gains some leverage over the target, transforming her weapon into a rope and yanking their leg out from underneath them. The rocks they bend to their will explode violently with the sudden stoppage, further launching this person forward. They manage to pivot to their feet, throwing a large boulder from the wreckage with their mind. Adora swaps back to her shield, swiping it diagonally and breaking the solid rock with such a simplicity it throws her opponent for a spin. It's the perfect window for her to toss the shield, colliding against their shins, and forcing it into their face. The weapon turns into a sword, pointed sharply against the tip of their nose. Their eyes as brown as the earth they command, the pebbles they levitate in the background falling to the ground in defeat.Their pant legs are ripped to shreds from the motion of everything going on, and their beige shirt is soaked with sweat from their extended efforts.

Adora has managed to take another into her custody, and around her the people cheer her on as her backup catches up onto the scene. They'll make the formal arrest, dragging yet another rogue powered individual away for further inspection. If they hadn't ripped up all the roads to shreds, perhaps they would've been left alone. Adora stares at them as they're taken away, watching everyone's backs with careful eyes. They won't try anything; it's all a loss.

"Is everyone okay?" She has to ask the question. Generally no one really answers. Right on cue the crowd rushes over, orbiting her no different from planets and the sun. Pushing pens and random objects to sign. Taking photos. She'll humor a few of them before duty calls her in the next direction. In one photo she smiles simply, a wide and friendly grin; another she'll wink like she's the most charming person on this earth. The autographs represent a person who isn't real, not legally, but a figurehead for the public. This person she's meant to be is a symbol of something too far above her understanding to take liberty of.

In a matter of moments Adora is taken to the complete opposite part of town, keeping herself high in the skies. The earpiece lodged into her ear canal tells her to watch the streets for another chase job. She finds it's a simple takedown, doing nothing other than landing on the hood of the car and scaring the life out of the driver. Authorities arrive quickly and take them in. Search their giant van. The voice in Adora's ear beckons her to the next location, and with barely half a thought she's off to the biggest building in town. The voice is loud and clear, breaking through the buzzing in her ear she's come to tune out from time to time. She felt the buzzing in the chase, but the target was far more important.

Bright Moon castle, the capital building in the Continent's largest town, occupied by a number of people like Adora, stands taller than anything ever created across the land. Etheria has no shortage of architectural marvels, no shortage of miracles and magic and eye candy, leaving the castle's level of uniqueness an impressive feat. Government officials shuffle in and out of the building, never bothered to rush themselves. Eventually they'll get to where they're needed.

Not Adora. When she takes her time, someone loses their final minutes.

She enters through her own private entrance on the roof, landing easily with the help of her powers. One leg buckles uneasily when she returns to the ground, and she ignores it. There's no time to worry about it right now. Instead she'll pass through the halls, reporting to the one voice constantly ringing in her head. Shadow Weaver waits alone in her office, a wide space with quiet, dim lighting and dozens of magical orbs flaring up like a light show. Shadow Weaver hovers over the usual orb in the middle of the room, observing the city in a cloudy fog. She tells Adora she's two minutes late.

"You were injured." Shadow Weaver doesn't bother looking up at her, though Adora can't decide if the effort is worth it. The woman's face remains forever concealed behind a sturdy mask,

always keeping her emotions a secret. Overall she chooses to be a mystery, Adora decides, and overall she should be left alone. It's probably best for everyone's sanity. "Do you see where you went wrong?"

Without a second to waste, the playback is already prepared for Adora to watch. No healers will arrive into the office; her powers will repair her body within the hour without assistance. If the healers and doctors were to arrive, Shadow Weaver's tone would be more aggressive.

So Adora watches the footage with appreciation to the silence, letting Shadow Weaver's hidden eyeballs soak into the side of her head as she studies what wisdom the orb has to offer. Her earth-churning target from an hour ago, kicking up debris behind their feet as they tore through the road. Burying deep into the earth, their feet rip everything apart as they make way down the streets. Pedestrians are dragged onto the scene. The first wave of them startles Adora, and she takes a chunk of asphalt to her knee. It's a direct hit which maintains a tingling numbing feeling, even now, an hour later. Another hour and it should be over with. Nothing like the sound in her own ears.

It's the same thing throughout the remainder of the chase: panicked responses to people she's not anticipating. As her opponent runs, things become more and more unpredictable, and some part of it all makes her burn with anxiety. Even now, in the replay, Shadow Weaver has to tell her she's eyeballing the citizens instead of making a decision.

"They're counting on you, Adora," she tells her longtime pupil. "Do not let them down. That includes keeping yourself in pristine shape. You're the biggest asset we have to this town. Go do one last sweep for the night. Maintenance training tomorrow. Do not forget this lesson."

Then she's off, out of the office without so much as a nod of the head. Adora's one step out of the castle when Shadow Weaver gives her a new job, new directions. Break-in. Another powered

individual using their abilities for all the wrong things—a tale as old as time. Adora wastes no time on the scene. She jumps into the building in question, a family-owned antique store, taking a bullet right to the chest. It bounces off her gold-and-pale armor, though the metal itself is useless. Her outfit is entirely made for show, something for everyone to look up into the sky for. Another bullet is shot into the metal for good measure, bending it into her skin. Then she rushes forward, taking her turn, ending things in a single punch which sends the robber flying backwards. He's a massive guy, probably worked years and years into building and maintaining his frame. Now he sits in the middle of the road, authorities gathering from nowhere to wrangle him up.

Hours pass. Adora should've turned in a while ago, maybe two hours ago, but she finds herself as restless as usual. Shadow Weaver says this entire town is looking to her for guidance, for protection, for light. She would be a god in their eyes, always swooping down and always saving the day. As such, she can't rest.

It's more than a few rogue people with powers and bold personalities. She knows about the gangs and their wars. The importance of turf in an ever-growing city so massive it needs other people like Adora patrolling their own routes every hour of the day just to ensure everything doesn't collapse in on itself. She gets the trouble off the streets. The pencil-pushers Shadow Weaver spends all day dealing with decide how to sort them all. Sometimes they exit the courts, throwing rancid looks Adora's way. How dare she give them so much work! How dare she keep them safe!

In her head, she's starting to map out the trouble spots, the worst parts of town with the highest amount of activity. Places in town she spends so much time in, she practically lives here. She could be a tour guide in her free time, if Shadow Weaver would ever let her willingly leave the castle to do such a silly thing. That's if tour guides waltzed around in shiny golden armor and a pale white suit anyone can spot from miles away.

I can see you stalking all of us up there.

There's no need to look around. No one else in the world has a way to contact Adora directly, not unless they're her superior. And even then it's all panicked phone calls and emergency jobs. It's late. She's off the clock, after all . . .

She can't just stop in this part of town and not stop by the apartment. It would be rude, and she's never been a mean date.

Catra greets Adora with the same pointed look, her arms crossed in the doorway of her bottom-floor apartment, her cat crawling somewhere in the background carrying the same expression. It takes Adora longer than usual to get here. She has to find the perfect crevice of the alleyway around the corner to protect her greatest secret of all. Shadow Weaver would murder her if anyone ever saw her transform. Anyone other than Catra. Catra was always different from everyone else.

A broken street lamp is the biggest savior of all, hiding everything Adora stresses about with little effort. She's her normal self, human-sized and unable to crush a car's engine block with nothing other than her bare hands. Her famous gold and pale color scheme disappears and she's left with her normal red boots and her normal red jacket, whose pockets she stuffs her regular-sized hands into. Catra's piercings gleam against the flashing street lamp, all five stuck in her left ear, one ring stuck in her eyebrow. Her long ears try not to reveal her hidden joy at Adora's presence, rising despite herself. Then, when Adora appears at her doorstep, she flashes her sharp vampire teeth and greets,

"Hey, Adora."

It's a charm of its own, a secret language between them with multiple dozens of different meanings and memories and connotations. It starts everything they've ever had together, and every time the two words hit the air Adora has no choice but to smile like she's never smiled before, so wide her cheeks start to bother her in protest. "You're under arrest."

“I’m not doing the cop porno act with you ever again. Why aren’t you back in your big castle, hero?”

“Can’t sleep.”

“Want some help with that?”

Adora grins again, one side of her lips doing the motion alone. “Yes, please.”

Everything ends as quickly as it starts, and before Adora can hope to imagine to catch up to her own brain and collect herself, she’s reaching onto the ground for her green jeans. Her belt flops miserably around as she grabs the garment, a motion she somehow finds comedic. She looks back on Catra, who stares at her without shame on the edge of her bed.

The apartment was never giant, medium, or even a fair size. This part of town seems too popular to afford bigger homes and extensive land. Adora rarely spends time in the parts of town with the wide spaces and the open air. Catra once said the biggest issue on that side of the pond is which person in the neighborhood has the coolest house with the coolest cars. Everyone in Catra’s part of town, Catra included, is meant to be the biggest criminal known to man. Adora finds she hates mindless bureaucrats most of all. Somewhere, Catra’s neighbor lingers, the kindest woman Adora’s ever met, and her roommate. Her successful inventor roommate who aids people in the community. Yes, oh so bad for the rest of the community.

“Hey, nice ass.”

“Shut up.” Adora laughs, turning herself around. Catra’s only roommate, her spooky black cat, hangs around somewhere in the corner, staring at them both with evil in his unnatural purple eyes. “I do think that helped though, thank you.”

“Oh you know me,” Catra says, resting her upper body on the weight of her elbows, “I’m so kind-hearted and brave and heroic. Wait no, that’s you.”

“Hey, it’s never too late for you to join up.”

The statement in itself brings Catra to a gut-wrenching laughter, hunching her over and erupting a loud sound that mixes half-scream, half-laugh. The cat, Melog, walks away from the scene completely. “I almost want to say yes just to give that old hag a heart attack. How is she, anyway? Don’t answer that, I know for a fact she’s still awful.”

All Adora can offer in response is a shrug. Shadow Weaver never was the easiest person to work with. Or the nicest.

“She’d rather stick with the more desirable people like you, let’s be honest here. Anyway, what’s she having you do these days? Are you still looking for that guy?”

Technically she’s not supposed to relay this information. To anyone. Especially someone like Catra, who ought to be chased down the street by someone like Adora. Catra was never foolish, and thus Catra never ended up in prison the way Adora did. Certainly never ended up being converted into the city’s biggest hero as a community service effort turned massive career move. Though Adora’s not really sure what she’d be up to otherwise at this point in her life. She was never great at anything else.

Sighing, she tells Catra, “We lost him, and now I’m not on that project anymore. Right now she wants me on city cleanup.”

“Doghouse.”

“Doghouse,” Adora nods. “I made one mistake and now I’m doing all the boring jobs, getting over-assessed for them. I want to get a move on those gangs again, but she won’t talk to me about them. And now she wants me to do some stupid publicity interview tomorrow. More of the smile and wave and be a celebrity type of stuff.”

Catra hums, disagreeing with all of it with her eyes alone. All of it, useless. One mistake and Adora’s useless now. So much for being

Shadow Weaver's star student. So much for all the pressure on her needing to be beyond perfect.

"Speaking of which, I need to head out. I'm expected early tomorrow. And then I have to train."

"Is it really Weaver's fault you decided to stay out so late? Gosh, Adora, someone should demote you again!"

Again Catra manages to make her laugh with so little effort, and the feeling in her stomach is enough to make Adora want to stay the night. If she could, she would. Instead she drags her feet out the door, transforming in the same alleyway and rushing home before anyone can be the wiser.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you so much for reading! I plan to release these chapters weekly, as the entire thing is already 100% complete.

Bright Moon's Biggest Star, Part Two: Backstage Affairs

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Watch it again and tell me what went wrong."

A bony hand reaches across the way, crossing half the table and slapping a heavy keyboard's wide spacebar with a *thunk* . Adora stares at the device for a moment, contemplating the purchase completely. The keys are larger than any regular setup she's ever seen. Shadow Weaver's never been a big person. What, is she sentencing Adora to desk time now? Is she meant to sit around with She-Ra's comically large frame? How is an eight foot tall person meant to sit around in boardroom meetings all day?

On the wall to her side, empty save for the giant flat screen TV catching the room's attention, Adora finds several chips in the wall. Bright Moon castle is old, but it's also the most important building in the Continent's most important city. She'll happily paint the place for them rather than sit through another evaluation of her mistakes!

TV screen reveals the interview Adora just completed this morning. Live, early. Probably the first story of the day. She can't imagine how many people actually woke themselves up this early to see the program, but according to Shadow Weaver a significant amount of eyes were on her. As usual. It's the middle of the video her mentor has elected to start at, with quite a bit of time left in the video. But Adora knows this part; she remembers it being somewhere towards the end. She remembers the feeling of being excited to leave and suddenly feels her emotions wrecked with the ghost of it.

The interviewer says: "One more question, She-Ra, and it's the biggest question on the town's mind, every second of every day."

The man was taller, handsome. He had piercing green eyes which perfectly resembled emeralds, glowing under the stage lights. Had to be contacts. Between the layers and layers of hair gel and the white-tinted teeth—had to be contacts. “Now, every hero on the Continent is a name every household knows. Every household knows them, and every household knows their name. Except for you, She-Ra. What’s up with you and your secret identity?”

In the moment, the question pierced her nerves, a sharp pin surgically splicing into her chest with fine precision. It was the Big Unspeakable Secret, one she was never ever allowed to mutter to the world. Only two people knew the difference between She-Ra and Adora Grayskull, and only two people would ever know. It took everything in her to lean forward, faking secrecy and faking her ability to give that information out. In the interviewer’s ear she had whispered, “It’s a secret, man.”

And he bellowed with laughter into his microphone, frustration seeping underneath his skin to be revealed in private to some unfortunate intern later once the cameras stopped recording. The only thing natural about this guy was his charm. He was made for a job like this, whereas Adora has to try and try and try. Every Princess as they’re known, super-powered individuals forever contracted with the government, protecting their designated sectors and cities with public lives and public details. Everyone loves them. But they love She-Ra and her secrets most of all. It always made Adora laugh, thinking about the silly desperateness of it all. There is nothing special or unique about her and they don’t even know it.

Shadow Weaver doesn’t flinch in her seat. Her cold eyes remain on the screen, hidden behind the same mask as always. It’s more her face than her actual face; Adora can’t actually remember what that looks like. Nothing other than a head of mangled horror movie scars.

“How about I tell everyone once I retire?”

Shadow Weaver flinches. But it isn't the reason she's playing all this back. She'll make the reason known when it appears, and when it does appear Adora won't be able to hear after getting her head lectured into oblivion. At least it'll be a noise other than consistent ringing and buzzing.

"Well, secret or not, She-Ra, everyone adores you." He doesn't even realize he's told a pun and it killed Adora to hold in the laughter. "I have no idea how you do it; you're incredible. Incredible! What's it like, flying through the air, tossing trucks over your shoulders like they're nothing?"

"When I'm in the moment I don't really notice those sorts of things." It's the honest truth, but it's not what Shadow Weaver was bothered by. "Mostly, it's all adrenaline. I reach out, I pick up a truck and save whoever's about to be crushed by it. There's not much thought behind it, it's just a motion. Flying will always be cool, though. The growing pains? Oh, those aren't fun, not at all."

Immediately the video pauses. There it is. Shadow Weaver's hand rests against the keyboard, her gloved thumb landing thickly against the spacebar as she sits in silent staring.

"Growing pains?" she finally asks. Shadow Weaver doesn't move from her chair. She remains at her desk, a visual staple of authority over the kid in the principal's office. Her mask helps her eyes focus their glare into Adora's soul, ready to reach into her chest and destroy her at an instant. "Why would you mention that?"

"I didn't think it would be a problem?"

Mistake. It was the worst answer ever. Shadow Weaver exits her chair now, her long red robes dragging behind her as she paces the open space behind her desk. Magical orbs less used are back here, the main star of the show resting behind Adora on its own pedestal. The woman does two laps back and forth before returning to the desk, glaring down at her student. "You don't

understand the danger of this statement? No? Oh, Adora, that's even worse."

Great, she's about to be murdered and turned into another glass globe of magic for the room's aesthetic.

"Growing pains. You've practically revealed yourself. You've given the public sensitive information: the fact you transform. Everything we've worked hard for, Adora, it's on the horizon to fall apart."

Then, so foolishly, Adora decides to ask the dumbest question of her mortal life: "Why does it have to be a secret at all?"

Shadow Weaver could do a million things here. Rip Adora apart with her shadow magic. Make her do two thousand push-ups. Throw her in a dungeon for five million years. Slap her right across the face. Instead, she decides to make Adora feels stupid. A speech about the important role she plays in the city's very survival. If not for her, everything would fall apart in a blink. By keeping her identity a secret, she keeps herself safe, and thus keeps the entire city safe. It leads Adora to question the importance of her supposed powered associates, but the words never leave her mouth, and she manages to live to see another day.

Things are topped off with the question: "Do you care about the safety of your citizens? Those who would line down the block just to see you in the window of an interview? People who would never meet or know you, yet would spend hours of their time thinking of you highly and going so far as to praise you?"

Translation: these people see you as a god and you need to be smarter about defending yourself from the many evils of Bright Moon's streets. Duh.

"That is all. You're dismissed." So simple, like they're having casual conversation.

“Can I talk to you about the gangs around town? It’s a pressing matter.”

“It’s being handled. Go train. You have two hours before you’re summoned out into the field again.”

And for two hours Adora trains, putting the weights away just in time to exit the castle and jump onto her street patrols.

-

“What did you mean about being ‘desirable’?” Eyes locked in on the ceiling, Adora doesn’t bother with turning over and paying her full attention to Catra. Looking at her directly would almost make this conversation a million times harder. Behind her rough exterior, Catra has honest eyes Adora isn’t prepared for just now.

“What?” She feels Catra turn and address her attention on Adora, but Adora won’t return it back. Not yet.

She continues, her fingers rubbing against one another endlessly, “You said it the other day. I’m desirable. What does that mean?”

Loud scoffing erupts from Catra’s lips, and she flips back on her back. She’s done with this silly conversation, but Adora wants to press onward. “You have a lot to learn if you’re asking questions like that, Grayskull.”

“Come on.”

“Adora, it’s like four in the morning.” Catra turns again for good measure, presenting her back in Adora’s face.

“Humor me.”

A good few moments pass before Catra turns again, defeated, sighing when she meets Adora’s gaze in the moonlight. “What are you doing tomorrow? Meet me by our old spot. After I get some sleep and decide not to murder you.”

“That s—” Phone goes off. It’s a simple reach for the device, forgotten in the pockets of Adora’s discarded pants on the floor beneath her. A simple text about a complicated break-in. It’s a classic bank robbery with a super-powered twist. Hostages involved. Not one thought crosses Adora’s mind as she forces herself away from Catra’s side, her feet meeting the ground and grabbing the jeans quickly off the floor.

“You’re not seriously getting that at this hour.” Catra leans herself on one shoulder now, staring into Adora’s eyes and trying to find reason. “Adora, it’s four in the fucking morning.”

“You just got back from a call.” The jeans make their way past her knees, the loose belt flopping against her kneecaps. “I didn’t say anything about that.”

“That’s so much different and you know it. Come on, there are other powered people patrolling the streets. There are a million of those squads. Go to bed.”

Pants all the way up. Belt secured. Already, Adora begins to think of the fastest route to the bank’s part of town. Best way to approach without getting caught and blowing the entire rescue mission. “I can’t just leave it. Meet you later?”

“Sure, I guess.” The statement starts with a ginormous sigh, and ends with Catra turning her back on Adora once again. There’s no time to dwell on it. Adora rushes herself out the door, transforming in the alleyway corner she’s decided to make good friends with.

Eight feet tall, Adora launches herself into the air and lands on the other side of town, stopping about one or two blocks away from the bank. She connects with the local officer in charge thanks to her work cell phone, starting the game plan before the guy can let two words out of his mouth. Keep the culprit distracted. She’ll sneak in through the ceiling.

From what she can tell, it's been a standoff for hours now. Why she got the text only now is a mystery. Perhaps they were trying to handle it themselves and failed. The building is in the shape of a giant rectangle, the rooftop a flat plane of rusted nothingness. A couple rats scurry as Adora makes her way to the stair access, where she waits in the hall. Listening. One voice speaks on the inside, loud even for someone without heightened senses. She rambles and cusses and screams about what's fair and what's unfair. It's her right to take all this money! The government owes her family her debts back! It's not her fault any of this happened! No one should have to live like this!

It's hard not to feel sorry for her. Not everyone in town has the luxury of living in the giant castle, the most protected and famous staple of Bright Moon's history.

Descending the stairs, Adora can find the scene and chart it all with ease. Three security guards, doing their jobs to the extremes with their very lives. The criminal leading everything here is a solo woman with two giant guns in her hands. The barrels aren't too big on either of the identical weapons, however the chamber itself is almost as wide as Adora's fist. Not She-Ra's, but a regular human. Sometimes Adora wonders if there really even is a difference between her and She-Ra; if pointing out the separation between both entities is even worthwhile.

Then she snaps out of it and gets back to work.

A few bags are lined up with cash. Regular hiking bags, not too suspicious other than the two giant guns, the lateness of this endeavor, and the whole hostage situation with the overnight staff. Adora takes another peek around the place. Each security guard is spread apart fairly evenly. One guy is placed to stand in front of the door for all the cops outside to see. Another guy unloads the cash vaults, and the final guy sits in the middle of the floor listening to all the crazy ranting. All she needs to do is get around those guns; her target is completely distracted otherwise. Unfortunately speed was never on her side, not any part of her eight foot tall body.

She'll have to get creative.

Adora contacts the police lead outside, some nightshift cop who never really sees the crazy action this late at night. She tells him to make a loud but innocent noise outside. Something that can get her into the actual bank, closer to the person of everyone's interest. In the following moments Adora's ear picks up the sound of a car engine revving aggressively, a perfect sound which shuts up the criminal and even gets her to look outside. Adora goes running onto the bank floor, forcing herself into a low slide until she's completely hidden behind one of the desks in the closed-off offices. From here she can military crawl a little closer. She won't bother with alerting the hostages, not yet. It's too early for one of them to accidentally expose her presence.

"Oh of course the lawmen are getting antsy out there," Adora's target says. She rolls her eyes before returning to the center of the floor, right next to the poor guy whose head she's decided to talk off tonight. "Heavens forbid they do any real work in their boring lives! Just the rest of us, work, work, work!"

With difficulty, Adora has to force herself to ignore the conversation before she runs out and starts a debate. Worst yet, the fact she might find agreement. She takes her signature weapon from her hand, a sword photographed dozens and dozens of times, plastered all over downtown's giant TVs and government posters, and transforms it into a marble. Snapping her wrist, she rolls the golden ball out onto the floor, stopping the ranting and raving with a curious gaze. The criminal stops in her tracks, stopping the rolling ball with the tip of her shoe. Before she can even hope to ask what it is or where it came from, Adora turns it into a two-pronged spear and blasts the guns out of her target's hands. Then she makes the fastest arrest of her life.

Police rush in and inspect every detail of the scene, asking all the questions in the world. Then, when Adora tries her best to leave this place, she's bombarded by the news. Online journalists, bloggers, any old fool with a camera, a microphone, and a recorder of some kind. The cameras poke into her face, the flash

photography burning her retinas this late at night. Everyone asking how she did it. Why the police couldn't do it. Where they'd all be without her! She thinks to give a sassy answer, some kind of pun including the word "desirable" for Catra to laugh at later, but the words don't find her. The only thoughts in Adora's mind are the ones she screwed up in the interview Shadow Weaver made her watch and review over and over.

"I was born special." Then she's off into the night, quickly advancing onto the next job.

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Comfortably Catra sits this high in the air, going so far as to let her bare feet dangle over the edge of the tower. Behind them both is a giant bell three times the size of She-Ra, perfect for Adora to use as cover when she transforms back into her normal self. She can't imagine what her life would be like if she were actually eight feet tall all the time. Maybe she'd be less of the favorite in Shadow Weaver's eyes, also forced to live in the part of town with the rest of those not as "desirable" as her.

Hybrids. Plenty of children in the foster home were hybrids, half humanoid, half animal. There was Rogelio, who was essentially a giant lizard. Scorpia, with pincers strong enough to break a door right off its hinges, though she'd never have the heart to do so without good reason. Catra, with her fangs, her self-pierced ears, and her heightened senses. Her impressive intelligence has nothing to do with her species, all of her own talent, yet Shadow Weaver never truly cared for it.

All she really cared for and ever wanted was Adora's power. And now she has it, and now Adora's the most famed hero in all of Bright Moon, to keep every living soul protected until her dying breath. She sits next to Catra, feeling exhausted and out of her own skin, wondering how long that might be for. Then she corrects herself. It's for the people. There's no time for luxury.

“Hey, remember that time Rogelio was chasing Lonnie around and she pushed him down that hill?” Catra’s laughter starts slow, quickly building up into something lively. “He tumbled forever! I thought he was going to die!” Adora sits and listens, enjoying the sound before it expires in the moment.

“How are they, anyway? Everyone? Things are getting worse in this area.”

“Fine. They’re fine.” Short answer, like Catra wants to avoid the subject in its entirety. Adora waits for the rest of the delayed answer, for the long rant about how much prejudice this town so freely and openly carries, but there’s nothing. Odd. Catra just stares ahead, her eyes tracing some family playing in the park as a shady looking man watches them in the distance. Either he’s jealous or they’re stepping on his turf.

“I stopped a big robbery last night.” It gets Catra to turn her head, an evil expression on her face as she flashes a grin at Adora. “No, I did not sneak you any cash!”

Sighing, Catra returns her attention to the park. “You’re no fun. Not at all. I guess we should talk about the reason I dragged you out here before you bite your nails off to stubs.”

“I’m not impatient. I can hang out for a minute.” The words sound so ridiculous in the air, Adora can’t possibly be offended when Catra starts cracking up with laughter again.

“It’s been tearing you apart all day, and the idea of that satisfies me.” Yet Catra straightens herself out, ready to present her point for the class. The class in question sits on the edge of her seat, inches from falling right off this tower and exposing herself to the world when she transforms in panic to keep from smashing against the concrete. “Maybe we should keep it going?”

“You’re literally the worst.”

“I know, isn’t that awesome?” She grins at Adora, before flopping backwards on her back, her red checkered shirt falling against the

brick roof. Adora's eyes catch Catra's thin frame, tightly hugging the red tank top underneath the shirt. Then she shifts her attention to the mismatched eyes and the crazy, wild curly hair inviting her to lay back as well. For now she decides to sit, feeling uneasy for reasons she can't pinpoint. "But I'll be honest: I have no idea what I'm supposed to be explaining to you here. You're desirable. They don't plaster the face of a loser up all over town."

"You're not a loser, Catra."

"I never said I was. Lonnie's the loser. She almost wrecked my bike the other day, did you know that? Drive much?"

Adora feels her lips separating from one another, teeth flashing at Catra as she laughs. Catra thinks nothing of it, too hateful of Lonnie's irresponsibility. She always did like driving those big trucks. Never meant she was good at it.

"I'm fine with my life here. I get my jobs done, I get paid, and no one ever bothers me. No interviews. No weird government shit for me to worry about. The most dealings I have with the gangs are staying as far away from them as possible. You, Adora? They look at you like you're a god. And maybe you are. They want to look at you. They want to know you're around. No shit Shadow Weaver's so uptight about locking you down and making sure you can keep selling the stories. You keep her seat in that castle occupied."

"I think I keep a lot of seats occupied." Adora then feels a sigh leave her lips, finally resting against the brick with Catra. "Sometimes I wonder if the effort is even worth it. I stop one guy, the guy next to him starts something in another corner. Am I actually helping at all?"

"That's the balance, Adora: you keep doing good so long as there's evil. Otherwise there's no good to do. Otherwise, you're just a weirdo who can grow eight feet tall and throw tanks over her head like they're children's toys."

Adora's eye clamp shut when she thinks of the question, "Did you see the interview? I practically gave myself away."

"Not necessarily. All someone needs to do is start a rumor. 'Can She-Ra grow beyond eight feet?' 'Is She-Ra actually a shapeshifter?' The stories write themselves. People are too dumb to figure shit out; you'll be fine."

She turns her head and stares at Catra, because Catra has no idea what the words mean. Shadow Weaver's lecture, haunting Adora all day. All day, thinking about the possibility she's blown her cover one hundred percent and will be sent away or dismissed forever. Catra's eyes stare back, a consistent incomplete match of colors; the left a bright yellow, the right a bold blue. They're Adora's favorite thing, in every corner of Bright Moon she's traveled, to look at.

"Hey, when are we going on a date? A real date? Somewhere on the not-shitty part of town?"

Adora is silent, unsure how to respond. The notion in itself is the most wonderful idea she's ever heard. It's the fact she is who she is, with everything going on in her life. It's the fact she'll never get those eyes forever, selfishly for herself every moment of every day.

"You know, we go out and have some nice pasta *before* we jump to the part where I take your pants off?"

"I—" Phone. Catra looks at it with a death wish in her eyes.

"There are other powered people under her watch. Just take a break."

"She's asking for me personally. I have to go."

Adora returns after twenty minutes, finding no trace of anyone on the tower. It's as if no one were ever here in the first place, a lonely clock ticking for an empty crowd, a bell yet to be rung for the evening.

Then her phone goes off and she finds herself in another part of town, forgetting the event in its entirety.

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Other than being the biggest building in the city, possibly the entire Continent, Bright Moon's staple has one identifying factor: the color scheme. The flashy pink and the tame purple pattern, painted not only on the outer walls but patterned all about the inside as well. As downtown is known for its neon lights and inability to let any square inch of space go without light, giant colored lights are flashed upon the castle as well. All it takes is Adora accidentally crossing into one of the spotlights to draw a massive crowd within seconds. Everyone knows she lives in the castle. Most of the protected government squad leaders like her are known to, not that Adora's ever seen or met any of them. She waves at the crowd chanting her name before slipping inside, shuffling down the halls.

Waxed tile greets her white boots, light bouncing off the checkered pink and purple squares. She transforms her signature sword into a bracelet, slipping it tightly onto her left arm for safekeeping. No weapons allowed in here. Not even from Bright Moon's biggest name.

It's business offices forever and ever as she makes her way down the halls, trying to waste some time. Adora lives on the highest level of the building, a direct entrance from the roof available for her to access. She's feeling jumpy today, like she can't stop moving, and if she does stop moving she'll explode. The elevator presents about a dozen floors, a tempting opportunity for her to visit each one and run up and down the halls until she loses her energy. Instead she'll head all the way up, ignoring her curious urge to explore the halls and *accidentally* bump into one of her associates she's never met. Of course only one of them is allowed to occupy the castle at a time, but she can dream.

The giant penthouse Adora occupies and has called home for years greets her, and with a flip of a switch she's opening dozens

of tinted windows, surveying the city as she returns to her human self. Her forearm greatly reduces and she has to change the size of her sword-bracelet before it falls uselessly against the carpet floor with a quiet *thunk.* Rows and rows of books occupy her wall, bookshelves engraved within the walls themselves. Adora throws herself on one of the couches scattered about her living space, throwing her neck back and feeling the muscles spasm as they force themselves to relax with the motion. Adora needs a massage, but only She-Ra is allowed to be seen by any eyes other than Catra or Shadow Weaver. She-Ra is fine; Adora needs the damn massage. If only she were allowed to go get one in secret.

Knocking at the door. She's been here all of two minutes before she's yanking her neck back into its compressed state, kicking her feet against the carpet as she drags herself to the locked entryway. Long red robes and a soulless metal mask stare back at her, an unmistakable face from an unmistakable person.

"I received an alert you had entered the premises." Shadow Weaver invites herself in, pushing past Adora's weak human shoulder and beginning another meeting about another thing Adora is too tired to process right now. "I need to discuss something with you before you take your break."

No motion to sit anywhere, to get comfortable, to feel a little more relaxed with the business talk. But these are peoples' lives, and again Adora has to remind herself of it. No complaining. It's all too important.

"I have a gang case for you. Do you think you can handle such a task? It's important. A one-person job for a fast self-healer."

"I can handle it." Suddenly she's important again, and the idea of it all makes Adora's spine straighten out. So many strategies fly through her head, she can't control herself. "Actually, Shadow Weaver, while you're here I have a few ideas for the gangs surrounding—"

“No need. I have those handled; I have set my own plans in motion. It just so happens this particular one involves you at the center. We will begin sometime later in the week. I will brief you then. Good day.”

She slinks her way for the door, a ghastly entity dragging her mortal robes behind as she moves along. In the hallway Shadow Weaver stops. She thinks about something, before turning around and entering the room once more. She has no expression on her face, because she has no face to display.

“The whole city is counting on you. Support them the way they support you.”

Professionally, Adora offers a nod. Personally, alone in her giant apartment, she jumps up and down and screams. Her hands reach for the cell phone she’s attached at the hip with, her fingers typing out the longest message she’s typed in weeks. Real conversation is hatched in the words, something more complicated than **hey r u home 2nite?**

Hours pass before Catra so much as opens the text. Not a problem. She’s probably off doing something much cooler, anyhow, and her first response would be to tell Adora to go to sleep. So Adora turns over, feeling her body buzz in a different way than earlier before.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for reading!

Bright Moon's Biggest Star, Part Three: Unconventional Means

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra finds herself in the most boring situation known to man. She repeatedly looks up to the heavens, ready to question it all, and before the words can leave her mouth the job finally gets moving. Finally. After an hour of standing around no different from a sad street sign. At least the street sign has purpose and understanding!

She's never been fond of the security jobs, the ones where she's meant to loiter around and make sure absolutely nothing happens. But it's the job assigned to her by the government official she's not ever allowed to name, chirping in on her work phone. A phone she really needs to install Tetris or something on. Catra never met the actual client, the owner of the cargo she's going out of her way to protect. It makes her more impatient, and it makes her eyes scan the busy streets the other size of the alley in a frantic haze. If the owner isn't here, this package is a target. If she was asked to stand around and make everything look casual, this package is a target. No wonder her contact was more of a pain in the ass than usual today.

Text message. Blocked number. **FLEE THE SCENE. LEAVE THE CARGO.** Catra doesn't hesitate. She pushes herself off the wall she leans, stuffing her hands into her ripped jeans and leaving the way behind her. Her pace remains calm at first, eyes darting everywhere. A couple homeless guys on the street, passed out against their loaded up shopping carts. She eyes the one on the left, the one wearing a questionable amount of scarves around his neck. He doesn't move when she passes, but she picks up the pace anyhow. She gets that familiar feeling down her spine, the very one that's managed to keep her going this long, and she

begins to feel the need to choke down her nerves. Everything will be fine. Just get off the street and back to the neighborhood.

When the gunshots open behind her, decimating the alley she formerly occupied, Catra begins to run. She takes off at full speed, finding her bike against the random curb she'd left it, taking off into the distance. Ears open. Eyes on the rear view mirrors. No one follows her, but she weaves through traffic in the streets anyhow. She's right to get hit by a car door or a van switching lanes, but luck remains on her side. She lives to see her annoying neighbor, Scorpia, who also happens to be the one person in her life. Catra doesn't show it on her face. She never does. Somehow Scorpia knows everything and starts doing all the panicking for her.

"It's fine. I got a warning before things went south." Catra talks quickly, stopping Scorpia from uttering more than a few words. "And no, I don't know if I'll still get paid. Might do that transport job with you later, if it's still open."

"Oooh, about that." Two red pincers the size of Catra's head each press against one another, two fine points poking into the other. Catra's eyes meet the woman towering over her, and her first thought is how bad Scorpia needs a haircut. She never lets the sides of her hair get too long.

"It's fine. Hey, how many jobs have you been taking recently?"

Pincers don't move. Scorpia somehow goes even redder in the face than before, her embarrassment morphing into something else and answering the question without words. "Maybe slightly more than usual? It's been busy."

"Don't feel obligated to. You're doing fine, there's no need to overwork yourself." Scorpia nods, ready to repeat the same obligations in about another month or so. "Is everyone in the Fright Zone today? I need to make my rounds."

"As far as I know, everyone is. Lonnie and Kyle might be out on a job, but I'm sure that won't bother you."

Catra laughs.

She and her massive shadow make their way further into the neighborhood, crossing through the apartment complex. In the next block awaits untouched buildings destroyed by one of the government squads decades ago. The property wasn't deemed important enough to restore. No one's trying their best to live out here, anyway. Catra follows a familiar path along the sidewalks, passing trees poorly tended to and a variety of decorative, fake plants outside of empty apartments for sale. Desperately the owner is trying to get more people in here. Unfortunately, the place is *here,* and *here* is the worst place in town; the place the nobodies live and those living to forget dwell. Catra still can't place herself in either category confidently.

Things halt when Scorpia stops to talk to the dead-inside landlord, staying in his good graces. If she weren't such a good person, Catra might understand why Scorpia's rent is so much lower than everyone else: ass kissing. Apparently being a good person has the same effect on bills.

Things halt again when the pair arrive at the gates to the compound, a manmade secretive market occupying the useless land. "Gates", meaning a sad pair of planks which sit miserably against some of the crushed debris, turning the place both secure and shady at the same time. Catra's been here enough for the guy to let her through without a second thought. Just a tired nod of the head. Immediately, one of the most undesirable people in the Continent snakes their lizard body in front of her, appearing from nowhere with a grin so sharp it makes her fall on the defensive at the blink of an eye.

"Haven't seen you around here much, *kitten,* " they say, digging underneath Catra's skin. But she'll never show it. The most she'll do is flash Double Trouble a dead expression, never willing to give them the satisfaction of anything. Scorpia, on the other hand,

waves at them with the same friendly nature she gives everyone. "What's the matter, you don't like any of us anymore?"

"Just you," Catra tosses back. She tries pushing her way through Double Trouble's thin stick-like frame, but they follow her around no different than a dog would if she had a giant steak in her hands. "Generally I can't stand people who abandon jobs when they get too difficult and leave me to finish things. I didn't get paid, by the way!"

"Oh come on, you've made plenty of money since then. What's the sense in a grudge?"

"I'm a creature of spite. Shouldn't you be crawling along somewhere? Or have you ruined your work life after that little stint?"

"Nonsense. Business is booming for me. The same way it is for everyone around here. Bright Moon is a mess, Catra. That's what makes it the greatest city in the world!"

It makes Catra think of someone extremely specific, before she aborts said figure from her mind.

"Anyway, it's dealer's choice right now. Pick something fun! Might as well have a laugh on the clock, hmm?" Then they're off, as swiftly as they forced themselves onto the scene. Catra exhales, everything beyond pleased. Maybe she should be somewhat grateful; now no one can trick her into the less popular jobs. Like security jobs where the package ends up getting blown up anyway.

Then Scorpia says something awful Catra can't forgive her for, "I really appreciate having Double Trouble around, you know? They're always so full of information!"

That's not all they're full of.

Faster Catra moves, ready to get her chores over with before turning in for the night. Maybe she'll have a drink, too. Maybe

she'll see Adora again. First things first, she prays she'll get a better job. Her eyes scan the bounty board plastered with posters, Scorpia towering over her. Just looking, Catra hopes. She's happy to find Scorpia doesn't so much as flinch the entire time, even when Catra leaves her side to gather a handful of courier and transportation jobs. They'll always be her favorite—less people to deal with, less chances to fail the whole thing. Typically, these jobs are a one man show. Even better.

Crossing deeper into the ruins, passing more and more shops set up on common fold-up tables and loud voices selling wares no one here truly needs, the atmosphere changes. To the left is an apartment toppled on its side, a giant diagonal waste of brick and wood looted and graffitied to all oblivion. On the right begins passageway into the real shops. The real players in the game around here. Catra passes the knife guy and his giant display, eyeing a few for herself as she walks past rather slowly. Rare, enchanted animals, no different from the cat in her apartment. Quite a few stands with handguns and unconventional ammunition for unconventional weapons. A few pre-casted spells built into kiddie wands to cast horrors on one's greatest enemy. Catra thinks of the time Kyle bought a telekinetic spell and accidentally cast it on himself, flinging his weak body several feet in the air. His long blond hair flapped in the wind like a miserable bird.

Deeper into the ruins, passing more and more delinquents and degenerates, Catra finds herself at home. There's no need to keep her eyes open, save for when vendors greet her familiarly. Some other associates nod to her as well, a few of them grinning happily at her. There's really only one person she's here for, and the person attached to her hip without reason.

Entrapta's repair shop, the house of many horrors far worse than the magic shop, stands brightest of the rest of the shops. It's the most popular, the most visited, and the most appreciated. Met importantly: Entrapa is Scorpia's roommate and Scorpia is Catra's foot in the door.

Catra bumps shoulders with some guy who just got his drone outfitted with a new turret, and she makes a mental note to keep her eyes to the sky for the next few days, before the guy inevitably shoots himself in the foot by mistake. One more person moves from her direct path, freeing her to make eye contact with her least favorite person to ever live.

"Hey, Hordak," she tells him. "Good to see you're still dead inside. I was worried you might've found an innocent soul to latch onto!"

He stands tall, no different from a soldier at attention, blocking the only entrance to the one-room shop with his massive body. His tall body, more like—he's essentially a giant toothpick with angry red eyes. The man is more machine than man, and Catra wonders what happens when he malfunctions and starts greeting people with a bright smile and wishes them a blessed day as they shuffle out.

All Hordak does is snarl and tell Catra, "Twenty bucks." It makes her laugh. He thinks he's the authoritative type? He actually thinks he's scary?

"No. You owe me. I'm cashing it in. Give me my damn radio."

It isn't without drama, but he does step out of the way and wave an arm into the doorway, as if the door resting directly inside his asshole were so difficult to find. Catra crosses inside, finding her repaired tech with ease on a table filled with dozens of other completed junk. The inventor herself, Entrapta, runs around the shop with glee. She's the ray of sunshine to Hordak's stormy, vampire-ish demeanor, going back and forth with the widest grin on her face. She's so lost in the moment, she doesn't notice Catra walk in and take her giant radio. She won't bother Entrapta. Bothering Hordak is much more fun. Besides, Entrapta's actually useful around here.

"Why do you even need a police scanner?" He immediately asks the question when Catra steps outside, initiating round two. Wonderful. How delightful.

“Why do you need to ask questions? Don’t pretend you’re friendly.”

“Just making conversation.” It’s even worse, Catra has a million ways to capitalize on it.

Instead, her eyes fall on the next shop, another one-room hut shoved in the corner between Entrapta’s shop and someone’s closed down gun store. Not like anyone’s missing the presence around here. The building isn’t a shop, per se, at least not in the sense Catra thinks of shops. The man on the inside is a glorified tarot reader, a scammer who “reads” peoples’ minds and chooses a path for them. Looks into their lives, their potentials, and makes up some destiny for them. Because everyone around here loves being told what to do. Lonely sits the man with the Fright Zone’s greatest mind. He’s the most valuable person here, the most important, the most impressive, and the one with the most wisdom. Catra has no idea what his voice sounds like. Not many people do. He doesn’t really speak with his mouth, whatever that means.

“Hordak, do I have your blessing to talk to your brother-at-arms, or shall I submit a request?”

Snarl. It’s all Catra wants. She leaves the scene, her radio secured in her hands, planning what ways she’ll mess with Hordak the next time she decides to stop by.

Lonely sits Catra in her apartment, another somebody among the masses of the Fright Zone, police scanner blaring all sorts of information from her dresser. Melog, her cat, makes himself known. Mostly he hates the noise. But he can leave at any time. Two powered individuals begin the next call, starting a fight in the street not too far from Catra’s apartment. They’re fighting over food, tossing projectiles at one another with low skill and high ambition. The officers sit back and watch. Enjoy the show. Laugh about it. Then She-Ra swoops onto the scene and suddenly they’re sitting at full attention.

They were too scared to intervene, is the story, and She-Ra leaves the scene for the next call without a second thought. One of the officers curses her for ruining the entertainment, returning to his patrol.

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Not good. Adora feels the ache She-Ra was clumsy enough to obtain, her side burning angrily. She moves to punch the next guy, a mini-group of henchmen for the biggest dude she's ever seen in her life, second only to her, and the upper portion of her side unkindly demands she go sit somewhere and think about what she's done here. So her opponent has super strength. Great information to know.

It follows her hours after the street fight, dozens of calls later, dozens of fans calling her name and flashing their photographic phones in her eyeballs. She saves a young girl from a building on fire, stuck in a precarious place, and the feeling of the ten-year-old's little hands against her side almost makes her let go. It's never this bad for this long. Usually she gets her ass kicked, can't breathe for a few minutes, then she's off to the next job good as new. As if nothing happened.

Another brawl breaks out and she remains hidden behind her shield, a rookie who's never fought before, a rookie who only ever sees combat in those training simulations. For once in her life she has to hang back on the defense, waiting for her opponents to tire themselves out before smashing her solid gold weapon against the sides of their heads.

Good thing the big gang job Shadow Weaver set her up with got postponed. Her chance to get back into things, get back into the real source of all these problems, the real beast, and she's injured. She's injured for the first time in her entire life. Go figure. Even luckier, she wakes the next morning with two new problems: her rib still feels like it's gone completely, struggling to breathe. Her arms keep knocking into her side on occasion all throughout

the morning, renewing the soreness all over again. Secondly, it's time for her weekly physical.

Nothing changes when Adora transforms into her more wanted self. In fact, things feel worse as the muscles stretch and readjust themselves with her new physicality. An added bonus: the occasional joint pain decides to join in as well.

Shadow Weaver is present, as usual, and Adora has to prepare herself for whatever lecture is about to come when the doctor presses on that spot. She's trying her best to hold her posture, but she's failing miserably. The man in the room notes it immediately. She can see him making his chart notes before he can even talk with her. Shadow Weaver's too busy congratulating her on securing a warehouse of magical goods last night. Adora doesn't even remember. She knows she blacked out somewhere before retreating to the castle and blissfully passing out in her bed. But hey, if it wins her the points she's about to lose, she'll take the credit!

As soon as the doctor presses his stethoscope to her back, she spasms out. From underneath the mask, Adora can tell a massive frown is breaking out on Shadow Weaver's face. She makes things worse when the doctor starts poking around, causing her to yelp uncontrollably. Shadow Weaver gets out her tablet and starts scrolling through the reports. Easily, she'll find the fight with the super strength guy, and within the few minutes following she'll pull up whatever footage exists from whatever officer was on the scene. Soon she'll strap Adora all up with those ridiculous cameras and break down every second of her day.

The other doctor enters the room in moments, though Adora barely notices the woman. Younger, probably a prodigy if she's in a place like this so early in her career. She hears the scene being replayed over and over as the woman stretches her leg out, doing some sort of reflex test before she repositions herself. One fisted hand goes underneath Adora's back, popping everything back into place with the slightest of effort. Her neck, next. Then she's

expected to lay around with an ice pack while Shadow Weaver starts the lecture.

All in all it sounds like she's an awful brawler. Just terrible. All these years of experience, wasted. She's ordered to perform a series of refresher courses on one-on-one combat, then she'll take a retest. Then she'll practice group combat, retesting on that as well. Fifteen minutes pass and Adora finds her side still aches the same.

"You will not be entering the field today. This job coming up is far too important." Shadow Weaver stands, not bothering to move the chair she's pulled closer to the table where she found it. She's an important government official, after all. "I have my contact working in the area frequently this week. She's going to secure everything. I need you for something far too specific and I need you in the best shape. Retire to your room, Adora. No training. Rest only. We'll speak again tomorrow."

And again, tomorrow, they speak. Shadow Weaver at the door first thing in the morning. Adora's side feels good as new, as if nothing ever happened. It felt that way about two hours after her treatment yesterday, and all day yesterday she spent blankly staring into a book, zoning out for hours at a time. She wasted the entire day when she could've been cleared for the field.

Immediately, things turn into a mission brief. Shadow Weaver doesn't so much ask if Adora's feeling better as much as she assumes. This job must be important if she's not bothering her star student a million times over the way she usually does. Adora will need to secure the entire block surrounding this particular warehouse. Use her super hearing to make sure a soul does not dwell outside the building itself.

The part after is the tricky part of the plan. Adora feels the ghost of her rib begin to ache when the words hit the air.

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Secrecy and discretion: neither were Scorpia's strongest suits. But Scorpia herself is strong, a resilient person able to push through anything. She looks tough, a terrifying humanoid scorpion with massive pincers and a taming glare, all of which so easily disappear when she opens her mouth. She's perfect for the job, perfect despite all the flawed things which shouldn't work in this situation. Most of all, Catra can't trust anyone else but her. Scorpia's her oldest friend, and the least likely to screw things up or stab her in the back last minute.

It's the biggest job Catra's gotten in a while, and her phone's been blowing up about it all week. The fact the heist was postponed so many times in advance only proves the point further: this is going to be difficult.

She's told the area is secure. Then she and Scorpia are left to wait. Wait for the black vans to pull up—the backup. Wait for them to park so she can jump the drivers and knock them out, securing this place for good. Police will snag them later. Everything should happen quietly, whether or not the area is clear. Quick and painless, and everything will go as smoothly as needed. Good thing she's a professional. Not to mention it'll be one of the biggest payouts on a job she's ever seen in her life.

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Adora looks around the inside of the warehouse with great detail, using her powers to bring a glowing aura to her person. Crates everywhere. Probably those pre-loaded spell wands she's seen around town. Each crate is marked with something different, different spells each wand is capable of performing. No matter the user, the explosions will be the same power. If only actual magic were so easy to understand and control. She would've been in this career years sooner if that were the case.

There isn't a soul who lingers. A few guys are chatting in the next room over, but Adora won't bother with them. She's meant to sit around here. *Let yourself be caught,* Shadow Weaver had told her earlier. She put on the most convincing show possible. Let them

get a few good hits before she took the final dive. *No matter what they do to you, remain in the warehouse.* There is a field of goods in here. Whoever runs this place won't see the sun ever again. It might be for the best.

Apparently they're aware of this, entering the room with masked partners and gloves. As if Adora didn't hear them all address one another by name in the next room. They approach slowly, lead pipes and other makeshift low budget weapons in hand. She-Ra's arms are secure where they're tied to this wall, and she can snap those binds with a small flex of her arm. She could so easily break out of here, bend those pipes in half, and flick them all into unconsciousness.

But she can't. All she can do is sit here and take it as the pipe collides with her jaw. The lot of them, taking the greatest joy of their lives in making Bright Moon's face, a god amongst man, look so weak. They've got the most powerful person on the Continent in their hands, and she's been ordered to sit around and let a dagger plunge at full speed into her shoulder.

It's not soon enough when the warehouse doors slide open. They're opened so fast and with such force one side bounces back and nearly closes again on itself. Gunshots break out. Adora snaps her tethers, returning herself as a God, grabbing the heads of the two guys in front of her and smashing them together. Instantly, they both fall to the ground. The rest of the group has scattered in a flash, trying to find ground against the invaders as well as the newly freed prisoner they've so foolishly kept.

Adora's vision threatens to start swimming, and the best she can do is shake it off. A gunshot makes its way into her chest, bouncing pathetically onto the ground after colliding with her armor. She has enough time to take her sword-bracelet and transform it into an actual sword before she can catch on to the only real problem against someone like her. The guy in charge, the one making the big bucks, cracks one of the crates open. Dust flies off from the quiet box as a wand presents itself to the world. Gunfire heads in their direction, tagging their shoulder. Doesn't

matter. The spell is released from the wand anyhow, and the burst of pre-packaged magic blasts into Adora's chest, and in return she knocks into the brick wall behind her. Back of her head collides first, then she feels the side of her forehead kiss the ground next. Then, she feels nothing at all as everything turns black.

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Adora jumps awake. She beckons her sword to her side, transforming it off her hand in an instant and waving it around. Then she feels the sweat from her brow, secondly. No one woke her today. No chirp from the phone. This isn't her room. It's far smaller, far darker, and the sheets are—

"Hey, hero. Slow down before you hurt yourself again."

Catra. This is Catra's apartment. Catra's bed. Adora realizes she has absolutely no shirt on and hurriedly pulls the sheets upward. Her eyes lock onto Catra's, her face scrunching up as she asks the silly question, "Did we—"

"Yeah, you wish." Catra makes sure to laugh, voicing her amusement. High pitched and joyous, in a way Adora tries not to be offended by. No, Adora's thrilled to be Catra's free source of entertainment. Absolutely honored. "You were out cold. And fucking heavy, let me tell you that. You really took a hit there."

Something about the statement makes the back of Adora's head ache. She touches the spot, slowly recalling the night before piece by piece.

"Your stuff's on the nightstand. Washed 'em, because they smelled like you got your ass kicked and then blown up."

"I have to go."

Catra's following question halts Adora's frantic shuffling in place, the moment the words hit the air. "Want to tell me why you were letting them beat the crap out of you like that?"

Adora doesn't have a proper answer to offer. Not because it's technically all government information. Because a huge part of her doesn't want to admit it.

"As far as I'm concerned," Catra continues, "you could've flipped them all on their asses with your pinky. And as far as I know, She-Ra, you're not much into bondage."

"Very funny." Adora still doesn't bother to move. She's locked eyes with Catra from the bed, trying to figure her out. Catra just sits around on the couch, leaning comfortably backwards with her cat in her lap. Why sit here and lecture her at all? She already hates everything about Adora's job—why dig into it? Why put in the effort? "I'm just following orders, Catra. Making sure the job gets done."

"Right. Me too." She watches Adora reach over, sticking her hand out from under the sheets for her folded shirt and jacket. "From Shadow Weaver."

Adora pauses again.

"It's usually Shadow Weaver. I've never really talked to anyone else from the big castle." Catra stands now. Stepping closer. Adora lets her, staring dumbly. "She left you as bait while I was hired to move cargo to her. Awfully shady. I took out the warehouse's assigned emergency backup. That's after someone took out all their people standing outside. Outside patrols never reported in. We made the warehouse bare, ripe for the reaping."

Adora's expression never changes, never smartens up. She remains in her blank stare, not wanting to look anywhere else. She's not sure what Catra wants from her here, not sure what she's supposed to say or do about any of this.

So Catra keeps going. Maybe that's the intention. "I've never really seen your back before. You never let me. Those are a lot of scars, Adora."

“I’m a fast healer. It fixes as soon as it happens.” She sounds guilty and defensive, all the more proving Catra’s point.

“Then why’d you take a day off the other day?”

She doesn’t have an answer for that. Mostly she’s debating just transforming into She-Ra and busting out of here. Running home like a coward.

“This isn’t the first time, is it?”

Finally the words force Adora up, and she pushes Catra from the way by her side of the lonely bed. She feels Catra’s hand on her back, rubbing over rough, raised skin, and she pauses again.

“You can’t just keep healing forever, you know.” She whispers in Adora’s ear now, and if Adora weren’t so damn frustrated she might take the soft tone into a different direction. Instead she stands here, feeling Catra’s long nails touch each and every individual scar she can manage. “People like her, Adora, they just take and take, never give. You can’t keep that up forever. It’s not healthy.”

She has no response to that, just more quiet, dumb staring. She wishes it was just because of how pretty Catra is.

“Want to talk about that cattle brand under your neck?”

Something tells Adora Catra’s offer for consent of the subject is fake. “Some of these scars are from you, too.”

“I knew when to stop though, hero.”

Forcefully, Adora throws her shirt on, shoving Catra’s warm hand away from her cold skin. Spinning around, she makes sure to keep eye contact with Catra. “It’s my job, Catra. It’s my duty—”

“Did you ever get a choice? Huh? Do you actually *like* any of this, Adora?”

There’s no answer.

“Do you even have a life outside of this? What do you actually like to do, Adora, other than anxiously flying around the city trying to save every living soul who so much as breathes air?”

She can’t answer that, no matter how badly she’d like to present something in the one-sided bombardment. There is no time to actually *like* to do anything. The city needs her.

“You aren’t the only powered person out there. Not the only hero. That’s the point—so the entire city doesn’t rest on your shoulders, Adora, no matter how strong you might be.”

Adora’s never even met the others.

“You can afford a break. But that’s not what this is about, is it?”

She eyes Catra, waiting for the answer.

“Shadow Weaver’s afraid of you, Adora. All of you. You haven’t even met the others, have you? Do you even know where they patrol? Their names?”

She’s in Adora’s head. She’s one of the few people in the world who can actually manage such a thing, and she knows it. Adora needs to leave now, before something she will regret forever happens. No matter how badly she wants to curse Catra and renounce her forever, there’s no way she has that sort of thing in her. Adora could never destroy the one thing she has.

“Don’t let her take advantage of you!” It’s the last thing Adora hears before she slams the door, her coat half on and her boots in her hands as she flees the scene.

Why hasn’t she met the other Princesses? That’s what they’re called, and it’s a name she forgets often. It’s proof she never has to bother with them at all. The Princess Alliance, as the public knows them. Alliance. With people she can’t even name.

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Nothing about the earful Shadow Weaver tosses Adora's way interests her. She pushes past the woman, who rushes for the doors once security reports Adora on site, and starts from here. Takes it to the elevator. Into Adora's penthouse. First lecture is about Adora going off grid. Adora explains she passed out. Then a lecture about phone usage. Adora explains her phone died, because she passed out somewhere. Shadow Weaver starts the debrief on the warehouse, and Adora decides she couldn't care less of the outcome.

In fact, for the first time in her memory, she interrupts Shadow Weaver. "The Princess Alliance. That's what we're called. But I've never met any of them. Why is that? Who even are they?"

The question throws Shadow Weaver for a spin. Eyes highlighted by a faceless mask blink once, then twice, then she's stammering the answer out. "That is confidential government information."

"Good thing we're both government employees." Adora hasn't changed back. She's still exhausted, and holding her She-Ra form is making her even more tired, but she doesn't want to change. Not yet. Adora is a weak human with no guts. She-Ra is a super-powered crime fighter who can take out rib-busting guys with super strength in a single punch. She towers over Shadow Weaver, finally demanding answers. She could crush the woman with minimal effort. "The Alliance was your creation, was it not? It's the whole reason you're here, Shadow Weaver; it's your project. There's no way you have to report to anyone. Why can't you just tell me?"

"Take a maintenance day, Adora. Clearly you're in need of instruction."

No different from a child throwing a tantrum, Shadow Weaver is gone from the room, not another word leaving her lips. A fleeting moment brings Adora's mind to the training room. Which times might be available. What she should work on. Luckily she stops

herself, finally smart enough to realize the problem here. She plugs the phone in, throwing her sore human body onto the massive bed in the middle of the penthouse.

She's tired of taking the punches.

Her phone chirps in the next few minutes, some battery life returning to the device. Adora can't remember the last time it actually died. Usually she uses the device all night long anyway. **I didn't mean to attack you. But it's worth questioning.**

A million responses fly into Adora's mind, starting with the fact Catra has never once in her life attempted to apologize for anything. Really, Adora wants to express her thanks. She's never taken the time to think it over before. The whole Continent revolves around the Princess Alliance. Photographs. Treating them no different from movie stars. Interviews. They're supposed to be a united front, yet Adora can't recall a single fact about any one of them. She doesn't even know what the others can do. The most she knows is there's another member in this castle, who stays here when Adora isn't here. They're never here at the same time, and Adora's not convinced it's for security reasons. She pulls her computer from where she's left it underneath her bed, getting to work.

I'm going to look into it. I want to meet up with them. Can you help me?

The reply comes within the next couple seconds. **Duh I'll help you.**

Chapter End Notes

> Look I could talk about how much Catra fascinates me for hours, but all I'll say for now is the fact she is just so damn smart and the fact nobody gives her credit for it drives me insane!!! She also has a giant heart but we will be here for hours if I get into that subject…

Cracks in the Mirror, Part One: Detective Work

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She ought to be offended. She could never get this expression out of Adora on a normal day, and a small part of Catra wonders if the sex is just meh. She can spice things up! She can work harder!

Adora stands in her doorway, grinning brightly and warmly. A backpack is crushed to her chest in a tight hug, its contents unknown to Catra. The door opens fully and she's flashing teeth now, practically buzzing with excitement. Like this is some treasure hunt or something. Well, at least she's happy.

Turns out Adora already got started on her part of the bargain, staying up late every night all week researching. For the most part Shadow Weaver blocks certain things on her devices, but a quick hand from Catra (and an even quicker visit to Entrapta) cleared that obstacle. It might even be a psychotic, sleep-deprived smile on her face. Either way, it brightens Catra's spirits.

When Adora enters the apartment, a whole word dump collapses from her lips. What she's found. Who this person is. Why this Princess is stationed here. The importance of her Bright Moon associate she's never once met in her life. She's managed to access secure government files as well, downloading information directly from Shadow Weaver's office when her superior was out of the castle for the day. This detail makes Adora start giggling uncontrollably, Bright Moon's goody two-shoes who's never imagined a life like this. Little does she know this sort of thing is Catra's everyday life. Still, fun to watch.

"Well go on, hero. Tell me all about it."

The bag is emptied within the next few seconds, and from the shadows of the small apartment Melog makes himself known. He walks over one of the photos Adora's managed to print, sniffing everything. None of Adora's frantic, crazed movements seem to bother him. She motions Catra to sit with her, so Catra sits with her and observes the playing field of knowledge she's put together. She'd make too much money down in the Fright Zone . . .

"Salineas. It's the most eastern-bound territory Etheria has under their name. Technically it isn't attached to the Continent at all, it's an island of its own. Within safe boating distance, though. People travel back and forth between the mainland and Salineas all the time. This includes Princess number one." Adora slaps down one of the photos, as far off to the right as the space of Catra's messy apartment floor allows. "Mermista."

Catra's presented with a photo of a girl in her twenties, not much older than either of them. Probably in her later twenties, carrying a couple more years of wisdom and experience. It's an action shot of sorts, her painted black nails on display as she flexes one hand outward, her other gripping a trident tightly as she swings it at an opponent. Into the camera she stares, her dark braided hair flowing freely in the air as she holds a stern, professional look. This is nothing to her; she's probably been doing this way longer than Adora.

"Her special abilities include manipulating water, typically flooding a controlled space. She handles her opponents pretty fast. She can telepathically communicate with sea life, and she's brought poaching in her hometown down to below one percent. Only the lucky ones get away from her, and even then she finds a way to get to them, even if it's too late. She carries a trident and can shift her legs from human legs to a mermaid's tail. Which, obviously, is awesome."

Catra laughs. She can't help it. Adora just grins, feeling a joy of her own as she slaps the next photo up high. North. Young kid with short cropped hair. A large fur jacket engulfs most of her

person, both her hands raised tight-fisted in the air as she brings down spikes of ice and cheers into the heavens.

"Frosta. The Kingdom of Snows. The place rarely ever sees sunlight, rarely ever sees a warm day. They mostly face wilderness threats, but a few illegal magic operations have sprouted out there in the middle of nowhere. Mostly she just hurls heavy, creatively-shaped hunks of ice at people. True fighter."

Next person is a thin woman, freckled all about her cheeks and littered with flowers in her hair. A tan complexion colors her face in a little bit, presenting her as the outdoor type. She almost looks sunburned, at the first glance. She wears nothing formal, nothing special beyond her simple pink dress.

"Perfuma. Botanokinesis. Anything with nature, she can handle. Plumeria is generally a peaceful town, so she's not a particularly busy person. All of our major prisons and rehabilitation facilities are out there. Perfuma primarily deals with the convicts in the prison and the few who manage to run away."

"Glorified therapist?"

"Glorified therapist. Next one!"

Down goes the next one. An older woman, much older than the rest of them. She's big and muscular, a ponytail flying around behind her no different from She-Ra. She's a human-sized She-Ra, and everything about it is weird. Briefly Catra thinks they've tried to clone Adora. Mostly because her complexion is an inhuman color.

"She's a mystery. No one knows where she is. Her name's Huntara, but that's all anyone really knows. She was sent in to do some undercover work in the Crimson Waste, the most corrupt town in Etheria. Never came back. There's no evidence she's dead. I think she quit and hides out there. But we can get more into those theories later—there are a lot on her—because I really

want to get into the next person. I want to contact her first, if we can't get everyone."

"Your Bright Moon affiliate?"

"That's the one." The photo hits the ground, in the center of everyone. A pink-haired younger woman, maybe a year or two younger than Adora. She has a baby face, but everything else about her screams twenties. Starting with the tired look in her eye. "Glimmer. Have you heard anything about her parents?"

"No. Were they any less sparkly?"

"I can't speak for that part. However, I *do* know that all records of Glimmer's parents are no longer publicly accessible. It's all blocked. All of it."

Catra regards her, taking in the strange information. First the oldest member of the alliance disappears, never to be heard from again. Then, this Glimmer's parents become private, confidential information.

Which means Adora wasn't the first person to revolt against the higher power.

"Glimmer's parents were the first ever members of any alliance put together by the government. Their lives were even more private, even more well-kept than my identity. Micah had erebokinetic powers; darkness. Angella, photokinetic; light. Dark and light, they worked all over Bright Moon. Micah could teleport and move at super speeds with the shadows from the buildings. Angella could do the same with all the neon lights, primarily. They were unstoppable. Until they disappeared, as well."

"Almost like they quit?"

Adora nods her head, grinning smartly to herself. She looks so proud of her own brain, it's nice to see her actually acknowledge something positive about herself. "Almost like they quit. Micah has a younger sister. She's a government official down in Mystacor.

But their child, Glimmer, she was kept in the castle forever. A real Rapunzel. Now she's the biggest star in town, whenever Shadow Weaver decided to go from total secrecy to celebrity superheroes. She has super speed, and she usually leaves a neon trail of light behind. It doesn't last long. Some part of me thinks she does it for show."

"Long enough for you to track her somewhere?"

"That's what I'm hoping for. I need to know if she's contacted the others. It can't just be me. Sure, I'm different from the rest of them, but there's no way. And I need your help. Again. If you want to."

The plan is everything Catra anticipates: start a big scene somewhere in Glimmer's part of town, on one of Glimmer's shifts. Set something on fire. Rob a bank. Beat a guy up—anything to get her cornered somewhere. Adora will handle the rest in the weirdest team meeting in the history of man. Everything about it is so silly, so unconventional, it brings Catra to laughter.

It's absolutely genius. She looks at Adora now, not considering something or learning something stored deep inside herself. She's always known how much she loves Adora, and the thought begins to fade her grin out over time.

"Never knew you were such a good strategist. Look how fast you threw all this together."

"Of course I'm a good strategist." Adora reaches forward, pulling all the photographs together. Catra can see she's made notes on the back sides of each page. "Remember when we were seven and we stole that cookie jar? Come on, rookie."

"Those were the best cookies of my life. Even if Shadow Weaver sent us to bed without dinner for a week."

"Oh no, it was so worth it."

“Is that the secret?” Catra grins at Adora now, catching her attention. She stares into her deep blue eyes, a perfect ocean to get lost in for days. Whether or not Catra hates water, she’s willing to take the dive headfirst. “Baked goods are the way into your heart, hero of Bright Moon?”

“Only if there’s romantic music playing. Put some on, let’s see where the night takes us.”

It’s not needed by either party, just a silly suggestion. But Catra decides to oblige anyway, connecting her phone to the speaker in the kitchen. Though in a studio apartment, what’s the difference between the kitchen and the bedroom? The soft jazz music plays throughout the space the same, causing Adora to feel the humor of appreciation. She leans in, kissing Catra. Photographs stuffed back in the bag, forgotten.

Things heat up quickly. Neither of them have ever seen a point in waiting, not after all this time. Adora hears the familiar rattle of her belt being undone, and it forces her to kiss Catra harder.

Then Catra goes for the shirt, and for some reason it feels different today. Usually Adora just swats her hands away and Catra listens, moving things along. Adora finds she can hide her scars another day. But now Catra knows.

She stops Catra anyway, grabbing both her hands. Their foreheads press, Adora panting into Catra’s mouth. “Wait. I’m sorry. I, um, I think—well I guess it doesn’t matter now, since you know about—um.”

Mismatched eyes peer into hers, staring beyond the person and finding the real Adora on the inside. Catra can’t find the hero. It’s a tough exterior. She sees the girl she grew up with, young and scared and expected to be everything but young and scared. She leaves Adora’s hands behind, reaching down to the waist. Slowly she drags the long sleeve shirt off, watching Adora breathe faster.

Adora stands in the middle of the apartment, exposed again for Catra, nervous in five million ways. Catra approaches her from behind, a field of injury and mistakes on display, and wraps her arms around Adora.

Slowly the kissing resumes again, raising the skin by Adora's neck. Then it picks up, dizzying them both in a blind rush.

It's the best sleep of Adora's life when Catra wraps her arms around her all night. In her life of high risk, it's addicting to feel secure. The intimacy of it all drives Adora mad when she's away, forcing her to stare into the nothingness all night. She never wants to return to the castle or her fancy penthouse. She wants to stay in this studio apartment forever, forever safe from harm.

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Pink eyes gleam in the aftermath of the neon light. Each eye is sparkly, neon in itself, brightly capturing Adora in its person's sights. She's as clear as day, an eight-foot-tall anomaly come to morph into the most popular person in Bright Moon. There's no mistaking who she is, there's no question or doubt, yet the person staring back at her is rattled. Though in her defense, nothing about tonight makes sense, probably.

First of all, Shadow Weaver sent her out on the job. Shadow Weaver never bothers to contact her, because it's her preference and a part of whatever deal Glimmer has with the government. How she managed to get a deal or a choice in anything at all is a mystery. How Adora can land the same clause is an even bigger mystery.

Secondly, Glimmer never deals with gang territories or dealings. Everything about Catra's scheme was shady. Just shady enough to get Glimmer to run to some alley, trapping herself in the perfect corner for Adora to swoop in and be strangely regarded. In the darkness of the night and the sketchiness of the entire endeavor as a whole, Adora smiles and waves.

“Hi!”

And then she transforms, making things infinitely worse.

“Shapeshifter,” Glimmer says. She raises not one but both her gloved hands, fingers poking out from the bright pale accessory, “I knew it. She-Ra doesn’t operate in this part of town. I knew someone hacked my phone!”

One hand after the other in a perfectly sloppy boxing form, messily executed with loose elbow movements. The power of the movement comes primarily from Glimmer’s shoulders, her arms flinging as the neon energy comes racing towards Adora. A simple transformation of her bracelet into a golden shield blocks both attacks in an instant, as fast as they soar towards her.

Doesn’t really change anything. Glimmer still looks at her like she’s insane, her short windswept hair bobbing about just above her shoulders as she stammers in confusion.

“I really am She-Ra.” Away goes the sword, back into an innocent bracelet on her left forearm. Adora takes a couple steps closer, placing her hands in the air. “I just want to talk. It’s extremely important.”

“Shadow Weaver wouldn’t want us interacting, never mind sitting around in the same place.” Then Glimmer grins, an electric pop of light forming behind her eyes. “Let’s talk. But first I need to find —”

“Glimmer! Hold still! I got her in my sights!”

“No, wait—!”

In a single pivot of her left ankle, Adora faces the shot. Two arrows, flying right for her. Her shield just barely comes to life in time for the weapons to collide together, sending her weaker-than-tall-superhero body off the ground a couple feet, landing roughly on her back. Another reason Adora needs the training over She-Ra. The shield goes flying in another direction, leaving

her defenseless as the soldier approaches her, arrow perched on bow, stern brown eyes staring down on her. The shade is the opposite of Glimmer's eyes, dark in color and pointed. Focused. There's mission behind those eyes, a mission Adora can relate to in full: protection.

The next flash of the eye brings Glimmer hovering above Adora now, arrow disappearing from the archer's expensive looking tool. Solid gold, neon light in a dark alleyway bouncing off the metal. It's a purple and pink scheme, perfectly matching Bright Moon's colors and perfectly matching Glimmer herself. His hand still pulls back the string, blasting absolutely nothing other than air into Adora's torso.

"Hey, I thought—"

"It's She-Ra, Bow! She-Ra!"

His head turns, from his ally to the person he blasted onto the ground. "Oh, wow!" Then the bow in his hands folds simply in half, collapsing and fitting into the quiver on his back. He's a muscular man, lending his hand for Adora. She takes it in good faith, though normally she'd scrape herself up and pretend nothing happened. Move onto the next thing. He's deceptively strong, firm against her hands. Strange, considering he has a baby face with attractive dimples that pop out of his face.

"She-Ra, this is Bow. He's my partner out here. You know, the guardian Shadow Weaver assigns."

"I don't, actua—Um," she touches her chest, regarding the both of them, "Adora. Don't worry about 'She-Ra'. Please. I would really like to talk with you. And the other Princesses in the Alliance. I guess that's my first question for you. Do you talk with them at all?"

"Yeah, all the time."

It's such a matter-of-fact statement, Glimmer doesn't have to put any thought into it, before or after. Nothing in her voice leads to

the words being some cruel, sarcastic joke, and Adora isn't sure it would be better if it were a joke of some sort. Adora's brow twists, the rest of her face following with it. Slowly the frown appears on Glimmer's face as well, fearful of the truth when she asks,

"You really haven't met the others? It's true?"

Adora just nods, too thrown back to say any smart-sounding words that aren't *oooohhhh uugghh fuuuuck . . .* "God damn shit." Eh, they'll have to work.

"So they weren't kidding then?" Bow matches Glimmer's expression now, practically twins with the effort. "No one thought it was possible. How come they haven't arranged for She-Ra to meet with the other Princesses?"

"We're an alliance," Adora says slowly, the words tasting awfully sour on her tongue. "I have no clue. I'm barely allowed to do anything without Shadow Weaver breathing down my neck. Maybe they're afraid everyone else will learn She-Ra isn't a real person? She's just a human who can get taller? I don't know. Don't you see? This is why I had to come find you. I had to know if it was just me."

"Did you know I have a contract with the government?" Glimmer asks, and Adora jokingly wants to tell her not to brag. "There's a reason for it."

All Adora can really do is shrug, waiting for more. The pointed ends of her padded red jacket bump against the back of her head, barely scratching the bottom of her ears. She traces Glimmer's eyes with hers, scanning the alleyway in the same fashion. It's a long time before Glimmer can declare this a safe space for government secrets, here in this random alleyway, and it's a long time before Adora can get started on the answers plaguing her brain.

"Micah and Angella. Have you ever heard of them?"

“Micah could control the shadows; Angella could control light. They were your parents, until they disappeared and you grew up in the castle. Micah’s sister is a highly respected government official in Mystacor.”

Bow starts to laugh, because Adora sounds like a robot repeating information. Even Glimmer’s energy seems to shift for a moment, before things become all serious again. She tells Adora, “Yes, I guess all those are true. Except for the disappearing part. What do you know about the Horde?”

“Gangs. They—”

“That’s a general statement. Doesn’t really describe them. My mom and dad didn’t disappear, Adora. My Aunt Casta is the reason I have a contract in the first place—it protects me. I can work whenever I want, for as long as I want, and I make my own rules. Unlike the others, I have some rights. She’s fighting for the others, but they don’t exactly have the same upper hand that I did, though their parents are powered people who work in the government, too.”

“What is that? Advantages, I mean, what advantages do you have?

Impossibly, things get even quieter between the lot of them. Glimmer motions Adora with a simple wave of her hand, and whether or not it’s all a trick Adora leans with her, squatting and then sitting against the earth. Bow doesn’t move a muscle. If anything, his eyes are on the environment around them. Keeping them safe. That, or he’s about to shoot Adora in the head and end the face of Bright Moon altogether, deeming her a crazy person sitting in an alley listening to stories in the middle of the night.

“Okay,” Glimmer says, and she crosses her legs now, resting her back entirely against a building’s dirty old wall, “there’s a lot to cover here so I’ll go over it as fast as possible. Personally, I don’t think Shadow Weaver ever included you because you weren’t a

part of it; you have no connection. You're a fresh set of eyes, with nothing to be afraid of."

Oh, great!

"Years ago, when I was a little kid, my parents worked for the government. The same way we do. The castle is technically theirs. My mom founded the organization we work for, the only reason powered people have any rights they have today in the Continent. No discrimination, education and training in schools, all of that. PIO—the Powered Individual's Organization—it was supposed to be perfect. It made all those normal people feel safe, and it helped powered people with no idea what they were doing get some idea of who they really were."

Adora thinks back when she was a kid. All the things she accidentally broke. That one time she shoved Rogelio when they were playing street hockey and accidentally dislocated his shoulder with nothing more than her hand. The first day the sword appeared to her she almost broke everything in the foster home with a single, accidental swing of the weapon. Not very heroic. She never knew her strength then, and sometimes she's not positive she knows it even now.

"Unfortunately, some of the lower district people were affected negatively. Too many government regulations for things like freelance street entertainment, magic shows, all the things people were relying on for extra money. No more super speed couriers. It took years for these regulations to deflate and make themselves more fair, but it wasn't fast enough. Even now there are stupid things powered people can get arrested for. Luckily there are enough trouble makers out there to erase the legality of it all. Now."

Glimmer tenses up. Adora watches her shoulders roll forward, and she can hear Glimmer's heartbeat elevate, her neon eyes swimming around the alley. Glimmer shoots a small bolt down the way, making absolutely sure there is no one around the area. No

one to hear her words, no one to spread the rumors, no one to make the tensions so much worse.

"A new guy showed up, and he made everything really bad, really quickly. He claimed to be a part of the Horde, but never really explained what it was. Not through words. He's a telepath, Adora; mind control. He took over half the city without anyone really knowing. At first. Then he started the chaos all at once. My parents were leading the strike. The alliance wasn't set yet, but they had some friends around the Continent. Government friends. In the end they weren't powerful enough. Enter Shadow Weaver. Stole my dad's idea. Recruited the others. Casta used what happened to my parents to set some boundaries, but she could only set them for me. Everyone else was on their own, but the Horde's a bigger threat in Bright Moon. That's when she introduced you."

"Me, being an absolute no one with no connections, no knowledge, no anything. A clean slate to clean up the town while everyone else does the real work? Have I ever actually helped out with anything regarding this guy? This is a big deal! If he's still out there, something needs to be done! What's the point of any of this if he's just waiting to attack again?"

In the darkness, the biggest smile pops on Glimmer's face, and Adora swears she sees Bow peek over just to see it for himself. "Exactly! Everything on him is so secretive, but I never gave up. Casta didn't, either. Never. Shadow Weaver's more interested in publicly putting out all the smaller fires, making the government and PIO look good again."

"She's trying to erase all the harm and overall incompetence being done on her part."

"Exactly. His name is Prime. I know that much. The underworld loves him, I know that too. Other than that—what he's been up to lately—I have no idea. I have a couple leads I'm trying to follow, but nothing I can prove or even solve. The other Princesses tell me what little they know, too."

“But in general, you need help.” Adora doesn’t even wait for the prompt. It’s everything she wants, anyway; the only reason she and Catra organized all of this. “Let me help. I have some underworld connections, too. Childhood friends. Good thing about being raised somewhat normal, I guess. Let’s just make sure we keep in touch. I really want to help you solve this. I really want to stop being that woman’s sheep, too—I want to do something useful.”

Looking her in the eye, her own welling up with tears, Glimmer tells Adora, “You are the fucking best, She-Ra.”

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After the first set, Catra chooses to let the noise go. It’s all noise, after all, and sometimes in this part of town the best course of action is to feign deafness and move on. The cat crosses over her legs as a reaction to the noise, plopping on down across both of her calves. Luckily he weighs almost nothing. Less on the side of luck, he hears noise and starts meowing about it. Catra just groans, kicking her feet until he gets annoyed and walks off again.

After the second round of knocking, Catra considers the possibility of throwing a grenade at her own door. Then someone knocks against the hardened wood again, a solid fist against a solid object, louder than before. Someone strong. Probably blonde, annoying, hot, and the last thing Catra wants to see after working all night. She throws the blankets off the bed to make a point, rushing over to the door and finding her least favorite person but also favorite person in the world staring back at her with all the brightness of morning sunshine and a whole garden of flowers in her smile alone. Gross.

“Gross.”

“It’s ten in the morning, dude.” Adora continues grinning at her, and Catra considers slamming the door right in her face with all that positivity.

“I just got home, dude.” She walks away from the door, inviting Adora in regardless. Whatever this is about, Catra plans on dumping herself onto that bed and having a moment of peace before life decides to happen for another twenty-four hours, yet again. She tells the ceiling, “You’re not the only one who works weird hours, you know.”

“Sorry. But I have an update.”

“Then update me, She-Ra.” Some shuffling goes on around Catra, though she doesn’t bother with getting up and figuring all of it out. A small lump appears in her bed, a heavy pin poking around the mattress. Two steps, a pause, then Melog crosses over into Catra’s lap again. He’s determined, she guesses. Then another lump, somewhere near the middle region of her body. Adora’s elbow or shoulder, she guesses again.

It’s a long, crazy story about the weird, quiet guy who happens to be related to Hordak. Weekly Catra goes into that market, and weekly she sees the guy. Prime. Sitting in his little booth, sometimes telepathically communicating with strangers. Never speaks to Hordak, and least not with words. How many times has Catra teased him? How many times has he heard her?

Then she wonders if Entrapta works there for real or if it’s another one of Prime’s schemes. A way to pay all his bills considering all he does is sit around all day, clamped-shut eyes and ghastly skin under the shadows. His long braided hair is about all the personality he carries. Other than that he wears the same white robe every time, a bright contrast to all the dark vampire colors his brother wears. Catra wonders which cave the both of them emerged from, and why they can’t return to it.

Should that be the next mission? Saving Entrapta? Finding out how many other people in the marketplace Prime has under his thumb? Does he really have any customers at all for his readings or does he play with peoples’ minds when he’s bored?

“You know, Glimmer has an associate, too; a partner. It sounds like I’m the only big city person who doesn’t have one. Why do you think that is?”

“I don’t think anything at all; it’s me.”

“Very funny. What, because you’re playing the sidekick game for me?”

White popcorn falls into Catra’s sights as she re-opens her burning tired eyes, not taking the effort to look at Adora. “No, because I *am* . And I would never play the sidekick, thanks. I’m more than that.”

“I know, sorry. I didn’t mean it like that. That was dumb.”

Regardless, Catra decides the best course of action is ignorance; feigning deafness. “I was talking more in the sense of Shadow Weaver. Sounds like we get a lot of similar jobs.”

“What do you mean?” The shoulder-slash-elbow on the edge of the bed shifts. The weight lightens, before the question settles in the air and the weight returns to normal again.

“I get one job one day, the next I’m getting reports about big busts or big schemes gone wrong.” Catra throws a hand in some direction in the apartment, hoping she’s pointing to the right thing. “Police scanner. I had my suspicions.”

“And as usual you were right?”

“Uh huh.”

“At least you’re consistent. Mind if I take a listen?”

“Uh huh.”

“Can I make you breakfast while you sleep?”

“Are you going to burn the eggs again?”

All the weight leaves Catra's side completely, two boots stomping strongly against the ground. "I'm sorry? Have *you* never burned food? I seem to remember—"

"Can't hear you, I'm sleeping."

Catra hears a small laugh, then nothing at all over her own heavy breaths.

When the world returns to her she notes the fact Melog is still in her lap. Probably another sleepless night thanks to her awful schedule. She resigns to playing dead on the mattress, squinting her eyes shut and pretending they don't burn. She counts the sheep, focuses on her own breath, and proceeds to fail at all the tricks. Time to call it for the night.

As luck would have it, a couple hours have gone by. The phone in her hand returns to the dresser, her mind beginning to wander in a tired haze, trying its best to wake itself up. Cautiously she calls out a remark about Prime, no words bothering to follow in return.

The food waits for her on the table. Covered, probably cold. There's a note scribbled in pretty handwriting on the cover, but Catra won't bother reading it. Doesn't take a genius to figure out where Adora's disappeared to in a hurry.

She finds herself in the market again. No texts from Shadow Weaver or any of her other contacts. Which means she has to be a beggar like everyone else, crowding the destroyed rubble and desperately clawing at that scratched up old bounty board. The wood's starting to rot. Old nails pop out from the sides and the bottom, and every time someone yanks an unsuspecting poster from the board it wobbles unsteadily. Catra sees Double Trouble among the masses, and unfortunately Double Trouble sees her back. She's way too tired to deal with all this today.

Without rush and without much hesitation the lizard struts over to her, each step even and calculated. Every step is perfect, and every step is a performance. It's Double Trouble's best feature,

putting on a performance. The perfect liar and the perfect con for any and every situation. Even when the situation requires neither. Doesn't matter much to them. They can get out of anything and walk away untouched with minimal effort.

"Good afternoon. Welcome to the living!" They flash their sharp teeth in Catra's direction, sending a negative chill down her spine that places her in the pre-steps of her fight or flight response.

"You're hilarious. Not in the mood today."

"Sorry to hear that."

"Yeah, you seem totally bummed out. Look, I just want an easy courier job, then I'm crawling back into bed for the next twelve hours."

"Heard you had another scrap with Tung Lashor's gang. What gives? Do I smell a new rivalry brewing in the Fright Zone? Free entertainment! How exciting!"

Double Trouble is a total seven right now, and Catra desperately prays they'll spontaneously turn into a three. Or a two. Or a nothing at all, going about their merry way down the street. "It's hard not to fight with that idiot; he's around every damned corner. He's like gum on the bottom of my shoe I can't seem to get rid of. You know, if I wore shoes."

"Mmm hmm. All I'm saying is you'd better look out for Huntara. It's her territory, after all, and it's her greatest wish to hang that guy herself. She might've been one of those Princesses, but she was never the tiara and smiles type."

Catra pauses dead in her step, going so far as to drop the bounty in her hand, littering in free daylight for everyone to witness. Double Trouble's snake eyes follow the sheet as it falls pathetically against the dirt, before returning their focus to her. Unimpressed, as usual. Arms crossed and a bored look on their face.

“Huntara. Hey, do you know where she operates? Her gang—anything?”

“I’m sorry if I put you under the impression I was a free information pipeline!”

“I’m sorry if you forgot you owe me one. Come on, DT, spill. It’s important. Call us even.”

“Call us seconds away from being the next rivalry around here. Fine, fine. Don’t make that face, honestly, it’s far from flattering.” Catra makes the face anyway, forcing Double Trouble to roll their eyes to the high heavens. “Huntara is a mystery and you know it. Imagine having the entire government on your back.”

“I can imagine pretty well. Tell me what you know. Come on, you’re a nosy asshole. You know everything about everyone for no reason at all.”

“What can I say? Life can be boring when you’re as successful as me. Check the east side of town. Her guys wear that ugly sand color. Some of them prefer jackets with a hideous symbol on the back. Two half circles surrounding something ugly in the center. Bright red. None of them look like pushovers, and none of them look smart enough to be talked to. So don’t try it. They’re pretty open and pretty loud if you want to stretch those freakish ears of yours. The super hearing part, that is, not the appearance. Your ears are actually quite lovely, in certain light.”

“Great, thanks.” Catra rushes home from here, ignoring whatever passive words fly out of Double Trouble’s mouth as she walks off. Poster forgotten. She can do more courier jobs tomorrow. Tonight she has other plans.

Chapter End Notes

Happily accepting treasure hunter AUs if anyone has them because research!Adora is the biggest jam, bop, and hit ever oh it's so good!!!!

Also! If anyone reading is a fan of The Locked Tomb series I am going to start posting another sci-fi story I've been working on for that fandom starting August 1!!

Cracks in the Mirror, Part Two: Dirty Work

The second She-Ra leaves her human body, her shoulder begins to ache miserably. Growing pains plus the fact she was rammed into the side of a solid brick building don't seem to be agreeing with her. How mysterious. It'll be another trip to the chiropractor who always gives her dirty looks and the weird injection specialist who operates like a robot. Fantastic.

Adora circles out of the alleyway, making direct eye contact with the local weird dude before jutting her eyeballs away somewhere else. Catra's neighbor waves a clawed hand at her, as friendly as always. Adora knows her, but they've never talked much. Scorpia is nice enough, but it's odd considering they were in the same foster home together for years. Then again small talk and conversation were never Adora's strong suits. So she resigns to silence, leaving Scorpia to water her plants while she knocks familiarly on Catra's door.

"I think I have something for you." Then Catra's returning inside the apartment, greeting a giant grid of information sprawled across her small kitchen table. Melog welcomes Adora with silence and squinted eyes when she passes him by, his tail swishing side to side. "Something neither of us thought about."

The confession is honest, some dread dripped within the syllables. As if Catra were anything but the smartest person in the world. If hybrids were capable of powers, Adora would be convinced she had a super-powered brain. It's all natural, and all the more impressive. "Planting a bug in Shadow Weaver's office?" Adora guesses, and mostly it's for comedy. Catra seems amused enough.

"Huntara. That Princess who isn't with anyone anymore. She didn't have any right to quit, right? It's a lifetime appointment. She basically snuck out when things got bad. But she didn't go back home, didn't go back to the Crimson Waste. I'm not convinced she left town for long, if she did. She's still in town, and she's in hiding."

“How do you know that?” Slowly Adora takes a seat, never breaking eye contact with Catra, who stands hunched over the table like a madwoman crushing away at piano keys in the middle of a concert. Melog makes his way over, front row to the show as Catra grins.

“She has a rival in town. A rival with territory.”

Adora nods, “Which means she has her own territory to guard. Huntara was never a hands-off kind of person; she’d never in a million years let anyone else handle that in her place. Not unless she’s dead and buried. Okay.” Adora feels herself grinning, the joy of forward momentum keeping her from doing anything else. “Okay, where do we start, then?”

“Working on that part with a contact. Shouldn’t take them too long. In the meantime, there’s another thing I want to show you. But it’s risky. And you need to have a lot of time. It’s not a place we can leave quickly, and it’s not a place that’ll be over with in a short time.”

“Is that your way of asking me on a date?”

“No.” Catra is the one grinning now as she backs off from the edge of the table, loosening her grip before removing her hands completely. “But I’m open to a nice lunch afterwards.”

Now Adora truly can’t stop grinning. She thinks there’s nothing in the world that can ruin this moment, until her phone loudly begins to ring with a familiar chime. It’s the exact job she’s betraying, right now. Go figure.

“I’m taking a maintenance day tomorrow.” The words are so defensive, they fall sour on Adora’s tongue. There’s no need to hide the truth from Catra. Catra knows how exhausted she really is. At least she truly believes Catra can grasp that mad, mad concept. “Let’s do it tomorrow.”

A blast of wind leaves her legs as quickly as she runs back out into the alleyway, eight feet worth of human taking off for the

skies. Adora rushes as far as possible to the other side of town, feeling embarrassed again. She'd thought she had more time on her hands, more time to hang around. Maybe make Catra some dinner next. Shadow Weaver kept her from breakfast the other day, and now she's managed to ruin dinner without even knowing.

All night Adora considers it. Bringing something to eat before this big trip tomorrow. Visit the local bakery, bring Catra something nice. Her birthday isn't too far around the corner. If this isn't all sorted by October, Adora thinks she'll have to find another way to get a giant maintenance day. Weekend, even.

She's so lost in her thoughts and so focused on the task at hand, she shows up as early as possible to the time Catra requested—empty-handed. She's knocked on the door already, finding herself a fool with air in her palms. Catra thinks nothing of it. Adora thinks everything of it.

It plagues her mind the entire stroll over, following just behind Catra with desperate thoughts of how to make today better. There's got to be something Adora can slap together. She's not sure why she's so desperate to. All she knows is she wants to do something for Catra before the world falls off her shoulders and she finally collapses, crushed from exhaustion. Then she gets a full view of the stop before her and pauses her pace to stare.

Fallen buildings toppled against one another, creating a new sort of world within the ruins. All sorts of people waltzing in and out, a community more integrated and more diverse than any old downtown event on the news happily sponsored by the people Shadow Weaver works with. A small wooden fence sits in the open space, leaving only one spot to enter and one spot to exit. A giant man with a bull head on his body stands by the door, eyeballing every living soul walking in and out. He has a stern look on his face, a killer's eyes who could destroy ten men with a simple swing of the axe sitting by his feet. He simply nods at Catra, waving even when she passes him by. Catra says he's the biggest softie on the planet and Adora has to hold back laughter in the fear the biggest softie in this place cracks her skull open.

Next into her vision falls another, giant wooden board. Paper posters plastered on every corner of the wood, a small crowd staring above. Some grab one, most grab two or more. Wanted posters, security work, couriers. Adora catches Catra's eyes wandering in the direction, even now. Then three people start walking over and suddenly the board doesn't exist at all. Catra's attention leaves it completely, trying to rush the both of them elsewhere. Only problem is Adora knows these people and dumbly waves over at them.

"Adora Grayskull. I don't know, Rogelio, maybe I really did get concussed last week."

"Lonnie," Catra says coldly. "We're here on business. We can all sit down for tea later."

The words bring a large frown to Lonnie's face, pointed directly at Adora, as if Catra never spoke in the first place. Some things never change. "Why is the government poking around in the marketplace? This is supposed to be a safe place. It's the only way any of us get around. Do they want to take this place away, too?"

Adora decides to put on that big, lousy smile she sees the government reps put on, trying her best to make it look like she doesn't have a thought in her brain. She can practically see the camera flashes in the background, her PR guy telling her to show more shiny teeth. "It's good to see you guys again. Thought I'd stop by and take up a courier job or two. Sounds like fun."

"Yeah, fun." Roll of the eyes. "We all have fun here while you're up in that castle getting free meals."

"Four times a day. Lucky me." Adora shrugs, watching the steam fly out of her old foster mate's ears. "Anything else? Something you'd like to bring up for our government to address?"

"Yes, actually. You're more than a tool, Adora. Don't let them use you like one. Starting with this place."

Classic Lonnie. Always mad, never able to direct it at Adora. Meanwhile her and Catra are perpetually at each other's throats for virtually no reason at all. Even now her tired eyes manage to make daggers at Catra, who mirrors the same expression. Then she grabs Adora's arm and they're both off, further into this place. Closer to the center of the smashed buildings responsible for this space.

"Is that where you get some of your jobs from? When Shadow Weaver isn't on the phone?" Subject change, though not the most drastic one. Anything to brighten Catra up a little and clear her mind. They are both on a job, after all.

"Pretty much. For the most part I can ignore the shitty jobs, but time to time they catch up to me." The pace slows down, returning to the relaxing stroll they had going on before. "Most importantly, it gives me most of my contacts. Some jobs pair you up with a random person, whoever else took on the contract. Sometimes it's someone the client hires directly. Hence my contact on the Huntara trail. Turns out I'm a useful marketing person. Who knew?"

"Oh come on, you have the mind for it. Oh wow, what is that?"

"Welcome to the marketplace, Adora. You've met dozens and dozens of the riff raff here before, I'm sure, trying to blast at you on the streets."

Easily, the first thing to swim into Adora's vision in this condensed place is the guns. Tons of guns, tons of vendors. Underneath the two crumbled buildings is a crammed space, every corner put to use. Most of it for weapons. Most of them guns, none of them pleasant-looking. Just looking at the weapons makes her chest ache from where a tricked-out shotgun bruised her sternum a few days ago. Everything Lonnie was upset about makes perfect sense: shutting this place down would make Adora's life so much easier. At least for a small while, before everyone relocates and starts up business again, angrier than they were before. Catra had

Adora leave her phone back at the apartment. No risk of being tracked. All makes sense now.

Her attention falls on the knife stand next, her body lingering as she takes in each of the weapons. Does she need a spare? Just in case something goes wrong with the sword? Just in case she needs it in a fight? She never has, but things are ever-changing, ever-evolving, a surprise around every corner . . . A stand full of animals takes Adora's mind off the vendor's tricky sales jargon, and from here Catra can finally move things along again.

"Melog's from that stand, you know. He has powers and everything, mostly invisibility. Could help us out later." Catra pulls Adora away from the next stand, saving her from a dumb gun purchase, a weapon she legitimately will never need in her lifetime. "Followed me home, broke into the apartment. I tried returning him, but he just came back. Sales guy said he chose me. I did not choose him. At all."

Adora looks back on the dog at the stand, a snow white dog who jumps a few feet in the air, hovering around before the vendor asks him to sit on the ground. The animal politely obliges, staring Adora down. Catra tells her no. She thinks to test out Melog's powers and sneak into this place for the dog.

"Alright, real talk." Catra points down the alley with a nod of her head, catching a long line erupting out of the smallest shack in this place. Another scary looking guy plays guard, dark red eyes penetrating the shadows with ferocity. He's a skinnier man, tall and towering most of the people who pass him by. He eyes them all hatefully, like he can't stand their guts. "This is why we're here. You can't freak out, either. The guy we're looking for, Prime, he's in here almost every day."

"Vendor or customer?" Adora can't imagine the concept of dealing with a mind controller absolutely armed to the teeth with every gun known to man. As well as every man known to man. She'd have to leave town and never come back.

Catra drags them both in line, stuffing her clawed hands into the pockets of her ripped black jeans. Her shirt has no sleeves and Adora can see the bones in her forearm moving as she settles her fingers in the crowded space, mostly thinking. Her voice is quiet as she continues, "Vendor. No one hears him speak out loud. Looks like he's doing a few readings today, so you can see for yourself. That big vampire over there is his brother. Younger brother. He's the bulldog for an inventor in here. I'm going to go in and tell her I need a part for the police scanner she just fixed. One person at a time; you stand out here and watch Prime for yourself."

"Well, there's no way he can recognize me, right?" Adora finds herself laughing nervously anyhow. This entire concept is terrifying to her. She's never really been the undercover type, more of the run around and punch people until the police show up type. Chasing people through the streets, taking photographs and signing random objects before running off to beat down the next guy. And everyone loves it. They cheer for her like it's an MMA match on TV.

It's not long before Catra's pushing past the guard, a guy called Hordak who isn't especially fond of her, more noticeably than usual. He doesn't really talk to Adora. Just stares her down. His way of telling her to stay. So she stays, trying her hardest not to cause any trouble.

From here, the real job starts. Her super secret spy mission even she didn't know about, because Catra has a ridiculous and, truthfully, silly amount of trust in her. She finds from the corner of her eye that Prime is a total hippie type. Shoes discarded somewhere in the corner of his little booth, a single mat the only decoration in his shack. He looks taller than Hordak, and his little building is most definitely too short for a normal person to stand up in. He places a hand on a young woman's forearm, connecting with her mentally behind closed eyes. In a moment she opens her own eyes, getting up with her partner and jumping up and down excitedly. They both throw him extra money for his trouble and scurry off, the next pair of people moving the line along.

The next pair sit. Greet him. Close their eyes. Sit there. But Prime doesn't follow them. He scans both of them with his own eyes, a pair of light green irises bright like Scorpia's outdoor plants. He looks directly upwards, catching Adora's eyes with his. He doesn't melt her mind or anything. Just sits there. Sits there and smiles.

Smiles are meant to be a welcoming concept, a pleasant expression to a person's face which should make any opposing party relax. Open up to them. Make them comfortable. Yet, despite all her powers and resources and smarts, Adora feels her brow start to sweat. This man's face is anything but kind. Anything but welcoming. He pierces his impression into her chest, deep within her bones, slicing through her muscle like flimsy paper, then he simply looks away. Focusing again on his client.

Adora rushes home, barely remembering to wait for Catra.

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Visions of Prime's creepy face follow Adora all throughout town. He's probably directly responsible given the ability of his powers, and such a concept begins to drive Adora mad. He's in her head. He's freaked her out with nothing more than a simple smile in a dirty wreckage, and she has no idea what to do about it. At least she's not freaking out about Catra anymore!

Catra contacts her with the blessed information she's managed to locate Huntara. Shady part of town, on the east side. Just as shady as the rest of the city after dark. Except that the east side is shady every hour of the day for no good reason at all. Adora makes herself no different from all those freelance delivery drivers in the city, slowly roaming closer and closer to this part of town throughout the day with every call. Finding an excuse to hang around here without looking suspicious. Then she sends a direct message to Shadow Weaver herself that isn't technically false—she sees a weird looking guy with a weird looking gun. As luck would have it, Shadow Weaver wants her to tail the guy and find out more information. She'll conjure up a fake report about it later.

Things aren't easily reciprocated when She-Ra lands in the middle of what must be either a large drug deal or an open door team meeting. All the guns point for her, poking out of hidden places, and out of good faith she throws her hands into the air. Doesn't make a difference otherwise, but it helps some of these leather-clad people calm down a bit. No different from the alien she is around here, Adora tells them, "Take me to your leader."

She ends up face against one of the dirty bricks of an alleyway across the street, giving some idiot the satisfaction of thinking he's actually managed to pin She-Ra somewhere. He laughs and laughs, and each second that ticks becomes more tempting to fling him into the distance with a simple flick of her forearm.

"Do you really think that's working?" Someone new enters the scene. Lively. Loud and proud, with more confidence anyone around here can hope to carry. Adora hears her boots stomping against the pavement, strong and deep like her voice. "Go ahead, She-Ra, put this guy in his place. Teach him some respect."

She doesn't really move at first. It's a pretty simple statement, but it's also the most confusing thing ever. Then Huntara repeats herself, apparently encouraging what Adora takes as a dare to test her and break all relations from this point onward, and every ounce of her voice actually wants this. So Adora shifts, barely taking an effort to slam the guy against the pavement, right next to a giant pair of untied boots. The guy runs off, red in the face, and Adora looks upward to find an extremely muscular woman as well as her mouth going completely dry.

The woman laughs, crossing her arms and causing several veins to pop right out of her skin. Adora wishes Catra were here to see this in person. "What these street urchins seem to keep forgetting is they're not on top of the world. We're no thugs, here. We're not honest, either, but that doesn't entitle big heads and swelled egos. Especially when you're just the help with a rifle you've never shot in your life. He's a new guy with a contagious personality, I think. A poisonous personality."

Adora just nods dumbly, pretending to understand the words.

"Huntara. You're She-Ra. This is my turf. Either you're looking for pre-loaded magic weapons—which I highly, highly doubt—or you're lost. These boys are very aggressive, you see, and I'd hate for them to have to—"

"Uh, not here for that." Go time, whether she knows which words to use or not against the city's biggest and most secretive crime boss. Huntara's essentially the underworld version of She-Ra. Clearly. "You can get the metal detectors out; I don't have a phone on me. No GPS. I ditched it."

Left it on the tallest rooftop she could find. Hopefully no bird hybrids decide to take it, or Shadow Weaver will murder her. Huntara considers the information, considers She-Ra, making the ultimate decision with a giant shrug. Either way, her boys keep their weapons pointed. Like it'll do much. Something tells Adora Huntara is aware of this, too. Big gamble here, on her part. So Adora just comes right out with the proposal.

"I want to recruit you for a private mission. Something secret. Something the government shouldn't know about, because it's about them."

"It's about the alliance, isn't it? Am I correct to guess you haven't met the others? They've been keeping you in the dark?"

Dumbly, Adora nods. Looks like Huntara might be the perfect informant after all, if she's able to guess this well.

Onward she continues, practically listing things off on her fingers now. "You haven't been seen in any of those group interviews. Everything about you, frankly, is a giant mystery. You're a closed book; they're an open sea of knowledge. Right down to what color that mermaid girl paints her nails with and why. Personally I think she should try a teal shade, but no one's asking me, am I right? I have another question for you, then. Do you know *why* you're kept in the shadows about everything?"

“Because I’m the help?” No better way to put it. Sure, she’s no idiot with a rifle, in this sense her powers, but Shadow Weaver sees her as nothing else. Not an associate, not any sort of commander, not even someone who could gain a rank. Just the person with the cell phone she sends out into the field; an over glorified freelancer with super powers.

“Because you’re a free agent. There’s no attachment to you. No parents who were in the Alliance already. Micah and Angella didn’t raise you, and you don’t have a high ranking aunt in Mystacor. No one stands up for you, so you’re the sheep in the field. The last sheep left before everything falls apart. And you want to know why, because you’re young and you’ve got vision. I had vision once, kid. Look where it brought me.”

Adora looks her dead in the eyes when she asks, “Why did you leave the alliance?”

“Probably for the same reason you’re here, asking questions. It’s all sketchy. It’s all a wonderful thing gone wrong. It’s nice to help people. Doesn’t mean it should be the only thing you do, and it doesn’t mean it’s the right way to help people, either. Do you know why I sell these weapons, She-Ra? It’s not for the fancy magic tricks. Not because I think they’re shiny, and not because I like to watch people blow shit up. Though I do. It’s because people need to be able to defend themselves. Take control of their lives. People should be able to make a stand. Not be a branded animal.”

The word makes Adora’s neck ache a bit. She bites the inside of her bottom lip, trying to decide what to say next.

“But yes, I will help you. But first you need to do *me* a favor.”

Nothing about the notion excites Adora. In fact, it’s the last thing she wanted to hear, no matter how much things were so obviously pointing in this direction. She supposes when someone gets taken advantage of once, everything afterwards becomes a trial and a test. “Sure. But I’m on a clock here.”

“It’s a simple transportation job. Just make sure everything goes smoothly, no one gets hurt. Cops are mostly what we’re looking out for here. We have a giant shipment going somewhere in town, watched a little more closely by prying eyes. Not everyone can make it out here, and not everyone can take the risk of getting caught. I like to get the packages right to the buyer’s door, if possible. But you won’t need to do that part. Just make sure the shipment gets into that part of town. Deal?”

“Deal, sure. But there’s one major problem with this. She-Ra can’t help you. That’s too much coverage. Too much face, you know? We’ll be caught instantly when they see me walking around. Unless I’m going to be the distraction, we’ll have to go about things a different way.”

“We’ll get you a mask, then.”

“Doesn’t hide the height. Look, I have someone. Someone I trust with my life, okay? I’ll have her do the job. We have the same training, the same everything. I’ll even give her the sword, if that makes you feel better.”

“I don’t want your friend.”

“Not a friend. She’s, uh, she’s my sister. What’s better than family, huh?”

And thus human Adora walks into the premises about an hour after She-Ra spends time bumming around, playing the worst acting game of her life. She’s no good at it. Totally over the top. Surely someone’s figured her out, figured out the best-kept secret in all of Bright Moon, but no one says anything. If anything, someone tells Adora she’s “almost as hot as She-Ra”. Ouch. For so many reasons.

After a minute of pretending she’s lost despite the fact she’s memorized this area out of paranoia, things get moving. Adora is introduced to the cargo and the car, a giant van which perfectly matches Huntara’s purple skin tone. Totally going to blend in with

everyone else, yep. Someone offers Adora a gun and she presents She-Ra's weapon, gaining a lot of wide, shiny eyeballs. She tells them some lie about how the weapon only responds to She-Ra's genetic code and her direct relatives, so stealing it is probably a bad idea. Probably not true, but no one here knows any of that.

Things start off smoothly. The roads in this part of town are far from rough, silky asphalt soft against the vehicle's tires. They cruise along, blending in traffic. The van isn't labeled with anything, trying its best to look as normal as possible. Yet it still manages to catch someone's attention. Someone who manages to freak the driver out enough to start speeding and swerving lanes.

Cars honk. Adora's heart rate spikes when the van just barely scrapes past a larger truck, avoiding blowing their bumper off and giving her a new injury she can't hope to explain. For now she'll get a mini-version of whiplash as the van chaotically makes its way off the highway, trying to lose whatever the driver's so spooked about in the nearest back street. An old sushi restaurant, empty and out of business now. The van is placed in park and everyone preps their guns, taking a stance at the ready. One guy keeps his hand on the rear door's handle, rifle in his free hand gripped tightly. The tip of the gun's barrel rests against the soft gray carpet of the van, waiting to be tipped upward and blast whatever's got everyone on edge.

Adora hears nothing outside. But then again she isn't She-Ra, who can hear a baby crying on the other side of town without an effort. The only windows on the car are the windshield, everything else paneled over and replaced with metal no different from a small prison. Everything surrounding this chase is shrouded in mystery, heightening everyone's nerves. Adora doesn't need She-Ra's hearing to know hearts are racing here.

Then the rear doors of the van are ripped off by an invisible force, thrown away to the side like trash. Adora sees a bright flash of neon, growing more and more complete in shade before the van is turned upside down and crunches to its side in a controlled whirlwind. Guns manage their automated streams of bullets, until

more neon circles the place and steals the weapons away. The color lingers, seeping into the air over time. It's not long before the pink neon strikes again, flooring everyone. Adora manages to find the attacker's eyes when she pauses, fist raised at a high angle, one hand gripping Adora's shirt collar tightly. Adora points to the left with her eyes, and Glimmer tosses her aside before running over. Adora throws her fists in the air, circling Glimmer in a fake stand-off.

"Hard times, Adora? I can help you pay your bills." Glimmer circles her in return, bouncing up and down impatiently in her purple boots as they spin and spin, dancing cautiously. Buying time.

"This is Huntara's crew." Adora keeps her voice down, and nods when she notes Glimmer's hesitation in her step. She keeps up her side of the ruse, continuing her useless circle. "Yes, *Huntara* . She's here in Bright Moon. Don't know if she ever went back to the Crimson Waste. I'm trying to get info out of her about Prime. But I need to help her deliver these stupid weapons first. Pre-loaded wands. I think they're sleep spells and fire spells. Make it look convincing? Help me out?"

"Follow my lead. Bow will see us and disappear."

Glimmer throws the first punch, way overcompensating to be real. Adora easily dodges to the left, pushing Glimmer's hand away as carefully as possible. Glimmer tells her to punch back; she heals as fast as she's hit. So Adora lands a gut punch, smashing her unprotected fist against Glimmer's unprotected stomach, her for-show cape folding in the wind. She whispers the rest of the directions for Adora as they fake spar, putting on a show for the audience they've captivated. Dodge left, then right. Throw a one-two punch combo as a counter, catch Glimmer off-guard; Adora thinks she does it for real when Glimmer waves her hands around.

They keep the act up for as long as possible, sparring as if longtime friends. Adora finds she's actually having fun. She's never really done this sort of thing with anyone else before. Nothing beyond trainers and simulations and whatever false

bodies Shadow Weaver conjures up for her to punch. She has the real fights out here in the field, and never has she done them as Adora. Never has she managed to have fun, either.

Things end when Glimmer winks before taking a huge dive. The crew works together to push the van back on its wheels, deeming it just okay enough to drive. Adora feels Bow's eyes on her as she loads everyone back inside, nodding back at Glimmer before the road finds her again. Smoothly the ride resumes, returning to smooth roads and calm skies.

By nightfall Adora is in Huntara's personal office somewhere not too far from the initial meeting place she'd run into Huntara. It's a small office just big enough for a thin desk—a plank of wood attached to two legs—and a dead office plant with crunchy brown leaves. Huntara sits behind the desk. Adora stands in front of her. Time for Huntara's part of the bargain, and nothing about her energy or attitude comes off as hesitant. She's honest in the deal they've made together, addressing Adora as a person when they start the discussion.

"Shall we wait for your tall friend? It's an awful lot of information for one normal girl to remember."

Adora's heart stops. Maybe she can fake a phone call. Maybe she can make up some ridiculous story about how they can't be in one place at the same time. Technically the statement isn't a lie in the slightest. She was never a big liar before, so why start now?

"Luckily you're not a normal girl. It's okay, kid, the door's closed. No one else is here. Take it as a compliment; I don't ever do anything in private. It means I trust you."

A giant sigh of air leaves Adora's lungs, exiting through her mouth rather loudly. Her surprise can't be masked. "How did you know?"

"You're an awful liar." Not a false statement. "A shape shifter is valuable. Don't ever forget that. Even if it's a limited form. It's one

of the most valuable powers ever. Do you know what that means for you?”

“That I shouldn’t ever quit my day job?”

“That there is no way in hell those people would let you walk away easily. You’re a built-in spy, for one. Secret ops jobs. No one in the world knows the difference between Adora and She-Ra. You could do anything, and government enemies would be none the wiser.”

Huntara stands, towering over Adora’s human form. She’s the god in this conversation, arms bigger than both Adora and She-Ra’s head, a lifetime of experiences and violence to outweigh every earthly thing Adora has had thrust upon her. In Huntara’s hands rests a thumb drive, rectangular in the shape of a cartoon TNT crate. Huntara says something about explosions back home, something about when crime was actually interesting, and sends Adora on her merry way.

“Everything you need to know is on that drive. If you feel anything is missing, or anything is too crazy to be true, you come find me. You know where I operate now, and you should know I am too old and frankly too unmotivated to switch locations so quickly.” Then, more seriously, more professionally, more sage-like and elderly and along the lines of a mentor, Huntara tells Adora, “Good luck, kid.”

She rushes out the door, taking off in plain sight for Catra’s apartment.

Cracks in the Mirror, Part Three: Heroic Impulse

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Five letters serve as the passcode into the apartment. Within a matter of minutes since this thumb drive riddled with information has met Adora's palms, it meets the single USB port of a ten-year-old laptop. Catra's wearing another one of her sleeveless shirts, sweatpants over her legs.

"No work today?" Adora asks. The USB port connects with the computer, presenting a waterfall of files to look through.

"Nope. Some people get actual days off, you know. Not because they got punched a little too hard, either." She throws a look in Adora's direction, before focusing on the computer again. Catra mentions there's food in the fridge as well, but Adora finds she can't think of food right now. She hasn't eaten all day, and she doesn't care. This is much too important.

First set of files is a list of witnesses. Government employees past and present, alive and dead. Which ones would be willing to testify in court, which ones would be useless to call to the stand or even invite to the trial altogether. Huntara is on the list of testimonials. She'd risk arrest. She'd be willing to come out of hiding and step into the courts.

This is beyond Prime. This is something else entirely.

Surveillance and official records on Prime fall into Catra and Adora's visions next, littering the screen with lines and lines of information. Everything jumbles together, resembling a dictionary. Less than half of it regards Prime's dealings; his powers and what he's chosen to do with them. The ability to bring an entire Salineas city to its knees, decades ago. One decade after this

incident, an entire district of Bright Moon. Around the time Glimmer would lose her parents, the government was chasing him once again. Images show him with his arms in the air no different from the puppeteer he is, laughing in the background as he forces Micah and Angella to kill each other and orphan their only child.

Everything else is the legal side of it all. The incompetence behind letting this man walk free for so long. Claims stating lack of evidence. Claims stating even one photograph wouldn't be enough to pursue someone like him. They bring in Shadow Weaver and her endless ideas, forming the Princess Alliance and holding them all to strict contracts. They will be public icons. They will erase the damage done to the common eye by Prime, restoring the power to the government. One member of the alliance will be unique, and this member will handle different dealings from everyone else. Everyone else will clean up Prime's mess. Everyone else will handle the actual problem. The unique member, the shape shifter, will handle relations which directly affect Shadow Weaver and her interests.

Emptying warehouses for the government to confiscate. Such items going missing on records. Police growing more and more cruel against common powered people on the streets. Crime going up. Prime disappearing completely. Bright Moon falling into chaos. No one bothering to bat an eye, because their pockets are secretly being lined thickly.

"Shadow Weaver sold you out for a fancy mansion on the nice part of town." Catra sits back in her chair, falling naturally against the wooden furniture. "How about that?"

"It's—so basically—Oh my god, my brain hurts." Adora pinches the bridge of her nose, finally taking a seat next to Catra. "She's letting Prime get away with his terrorism so she can collect a check? That's her big evil motive? A fucking check, Catra?"

Catra just sighs. "Well, she always thought she was royalty. Always thought everyone owed her something. Why not a big

fucking check, right? Asshole. She's burning this whole town to the ground making you all look stupid."

"Glimmer's been running circles around Prime for years. Shadow Weaver's probably sabotaging her search. Mermista's and Perfuma's searches, too, I bet. She's holding the whole town in her hands and she knows it. She's buying them with the celebrity nonsense, meanwhile we're basically doing nothing at all to help anyone. They're taking these photographs with a bunch of super-powered losers, and they love us for it."

"Isn't that something?" Catra turns, capturing Adora's face in her vision. Her fair skin is red in the face, her cheeks burning as if she'd been left to sun all afternoon. All this running around, all this time working her life away, for nothing. She's essentially been balancing the town out, just barely keeping it on the verge from collapse for Shadow Weaver's silly power trip. Catra reaches a hand over, finding Adora's numb hand resting against the table. "You know, I really can't ask a loser like you on a date. It would be embarrassing."

A smile erupts on Adora's face, and mostly she's happy to feel something other than world-shattering dread. They both know Shadow Weaver isn't a good person. Never was, starting with fostering a bunch of powered orphans for her own quest for profit and fame. But this is beyond anything Adora could have ever guessed of her. "Hey, Adora's a winner by this standard, isn't she? She-Ra's a slacker, according to these files."

Catra grins in response, squeezing Adora's forearm before retreating to her side of the table. "What do you think? Are you going to approach her?"

"I don't know. I don't really want to. I'm not interested in hearing some speech about why what she's doing is a creative action—or whatever phrase she'll use—against crime. This is so shady, Catra!"

“Yeah, but it’s so like Shadow Weaver. This is the woman who stuffed every powered kid and every hybrid kid she could find into one foster home and basically went crazy on us when she realized we weren’t put on this earth to make her famous.”

“Guess I didn’t get that memo,” Adora jokes.

“You didn’t get much of a choice.” Catra says the words so seriously, so defensively, it reminds Adora how much she needs to care about her own role in all this. Why it’s not up to her to be Bright Moon’s biggest hero. “So yes or no—are you going to confront the old hag?”

“I might have to. I mean, I’m not exactly a vigilante, right?” Adora raises one palm to the ceiling with anything but clarity, her thoughts cloudy now.

“You know, there’s a reason there’s so many of those comics out there. It’s what people want to see. Maybe it’s what they’re really craving. Maybe the real hero of Bright Moon would have to be a vigilante not tied to the system.”

Adora considers her, twisting and rubbing her own fingers together where she rests her hand lazily against the table. She leans with poor posture in her chair, not caring enough to compose herself. She finds she never really has to in this place, anyway. This is the one place in her world she thinks she truly has. It might be the only place after she confronts Shadow Weaver and Shadow Weaver declares her brainwashed or insane and sends the entire state after her.

Her honesty could bring up an entire witch hunt, expulsion, some kind of scary re-education scheme Shadow Weaver’s been sitting on for years. But it’s not worth hiding. This is the truth, and the truth needs to get out. Adora needs to do her job as a hero and protect the town and everyone in it.

“Wait,” she says, not really moving. “One last question. Don’t laugh.” Catra raises her brow in curiosity, and her effort in taking

things so serious almost forces Adora to pass the question away. “Am I hotter than She-Ra? Is She-Ra hotter than me?”

Then Catra stretches her face into the biggest frown Adora’s ever seen, and Adora half expects her to just walk away from the conversation. “Do you really want to know that? You’re literally both of those people.”

“How come you can’t answer, then?” She feels her eyes go wide, and the change in her expression causes Catra to look at her like she’s a crazy person.

“Because you are both those people and the question is insane?”

Forward and quickly Adora leans, colliding her chest with the edge of the table as she maintains eye contact. She’s a crazy person right now, but she’s fine with that. “Okay, but like, objectively?”

“Do I have to answer this?”

“Oh yes, now we’re deep in this pool.”

“You’re both ugly, how about that?”

“Okay, but who is less ugly?”

“You are. Adora is. Are we done?”

“You’re just saying that.”

“No, you are *literally* She-Ra! She’s just you with a different name and bigger muscles!”

Adora hums, thinking the answer over. She leans back in the seat, thoroughly annoying Catra further as she truly considers the response.

“Are we done here?”

“Probably not.”

“Are we done for now?”

That’s when Adora grins, looking into Catra’s eyes now without a second to waste. “Probably not. What are you doing tonight?”

“I have all night for you and your nonsense. Depending on how long you plan on talking for.”

Wider Adora’s grin grows, feeling the stretch in her cheeks. “Not much longer.”

Come morning Catra wonders if it’s all a dream, waking in an empty bed, silence clouding the apartment. Her vision finds the kitchen, and the only things in the kitchen are her closed laptop and Melog sleeping on top of the warm charger. No food, no breakfast, no person secretly trying to cook for her. Certainly no body in the bed next to her.

She rolls out of bed, starting the next day of her hectic life.

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She slumps in her seat, her day ruined with a simple sentence.

“This is nonsense.”

Shadow Weaver doesn’t bat an eye, and none of that is because of the fact she chooses to hide her face from the world. In more ways than physical. The mask shines darkly at Adora in the dim room, cold and uncaring. Adora and She-Ra have just accused Bright Moon’s official superhero coordinator of being a huge crook and the woman doesn’t so much as bother to move her attention from the glass orb in front of her robed body. In the orb is Glimmer, running around a warehouse as she confuses the gang she’s apprehending. Shadow Weaver makes a comment about her being too sloppy, but continues watching either way.

“You just said you know who Prime is.” Adora is in disbelief at this point. It’s almost like she’s said nothing, like the conversation is only now starting out. So she’ll repeat everything just to make

sure she’s not going insane. “He’s a problem, is he not? Don’t we stop problems? You said you don’t like management here either, so shouldn’t we try to improve that, too? Address the things that are wrong?”

“We can’t put the city on hold, Adora.”

“Fine, forget the way things are run around here, then. Let people whisper and do whatever they want, cool. But Prime? He doesn’t bother you? He’s out there and he doesn’t have to do anything to destroy everything in sight. That doesn't scare you?”

“Perhaps, have you considered, he would have done so already? Nothing is stopping him from destroying all of us, yes. That is correct. Congratulations in your detailed research of what’s already been documented. I have you do certain things for a reason, Adora. Prime is no concern to me. He’s made his point, and he’s failed. What should we care about a washed up villain from decades past?”

“Because he’s washed up, not defeated. We haven’t done anything about it.” She crosses the room, trying to make herself more important than that stupid orb and all the black eyes Glimmer is creating within a couple blinks of the eye. “We remove threats, not hope they sit on their couches and never come back.”

“We’re not speaking of this anymore, Adora. You are dismissed. Please return to your position in the field. Bright Moon needs you to focus on them, not silly side interests. Good day.”

The hallway greets Adora harshly again, with Shadow Weaver’s heavy door slamming behind her. She’s in a meeting now, she claims. A meeting that won’t concern Adora. Because apparently nothing concerns anyone but Shadow Weaver.

One, single word pops into Adora’s head and plagues her for the next few hours. It follows her to every scene, every incident, every photograph and every autograph. Every swirl of the pen,

engraving her fake name into some teen's dream journal, every time her fist collides with some smuggler's jaw.

Vigilante.

Nightfall greets her and she decides to observe the town, taking in the city lights and the laughter on the streets. Outdoor restaurants find her attention for a little while, families enjoying one another's company. Couples walking down the street. Light flashing on and off in different apartments in each of the big buildings this side of town. People leaving even bigger business offices, making their merry way home to the ones who matter most to them.

Every single one of these people needs her. Every single one of them knows her name, knows her duties and knows her loyalty. She owes them all these things. Not a half baked version of it.

So Adora jumps from the building, heading towards Catra's part of town. She remembers the market just down the street, the little shack barely human-sized in the corner of everything. Aside from all the shoppers and the lively vendors sits a single man in the shadow of his puppy-dog brother, much scarier than said brother could ever pretend to be with his bright red devil eyes.

Prime swims in Adora's vision, and he grins at her.

Chapter End Notes

> About more than halfway through this little number. Thank you so much for reading!

Primary Directive, Part One: Stormy Skies

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Everything begins in a blur; pinpointing the start of it all is impossible. One second Prime is smiling, a dirty grin behind crooked teeth and pointed green eyes, and the next second Prime is on his feet, running off. Adora thinks she's imagined him out of his usual spot, a plain mat on the ground she was convinced he was totally one hundred percent attached to, then a vital memory hits her: this man has mind control abilities.

Through the marketplace She-Ra goes, chasing after a ghost of a man who might not even be here at all. It could all be a trick, a vision, a dream he's conjured up for her while in reality she's face-down on the ground drooling into the dirt. Adora picks something off a vendor's stand and throws it down the alley, successfully managing to hit what she believes and prays to be Prime down the way. The item smacks against the bottom section of his calf, causing him to trip up. With her super strength, she hopes she's strained the muscle and won the chase for herself.

Regardless, things remain lively. Prime doesn't stop. He turns a few people against She-Ra as well, though she's not positive they actually need his explicit help with all the ruckus she's causing. She nudges a couple guys aside with her She-Ra strength, shoving them against tables not too hard to break anything. They don't get an ounce of her attention; her eyes never leave Prime's white jacket.

That dog from the other day—her first trip here with Catra, when things felt a little less chaotic and chase-y—reaches out from his booth and manages to bite Prime in his other calf, holding on tightly with his pointed fangs as Prime scrambles to free himself. He takes over the vendor's mind, but no real help comes of it until Adora's practically on his heels. She does take the time to look at

the white-furred animal, staring into his bright eyes as she tells him he's the best boy in the entire marketplace. Three times as she runs, she yells, "Good boy!"

Enclosed spaces leave them for the more open layout of the marketplace, the bounty board tall and proud as Adora shoves Prime against it in a single swat of her arm. Catra and Scorpia run onto the scene, and Adora decides to keep them in her peripheral vision instead of telling Prime all about her and Catra in a single glance. She keeps the man locked in her sights, a powerful force against someone as thin and small as him. He's tall, but compared to She-Ra he's a child throwing a tantrum in the store.

So he inhales, widening his eyes as he focuses all of his energy into Adora's mind. Fighting him at first is easy. She backs off, smacking him across the face for good measure beforehand. Green eyes around her start to lessen and lessen by the second as Prime recovers. He stands hunched over, staring at She-Ra's mighty form. Then, he forces his posture upward, breathing a huge breath in and squinting his eyes completely shut.

Adora's vision starts to swim in green, a single voice screaming in her head as the words are whispered: "Give in."

She won't. If anything, not with Catra here. Adora closes her own eyes, hearing her own heart thud between her ears as she breathes on her own.

Then she reaches upward, rips the bounty board off its hinges and throws it into the crowd. People scream, running quickly elsewhere. She doesn't know where; she can't see anything other than green.

"That's it, She-Ra," the voice booming in her head tells her. "Show them your true nature. All of you people in that woman's league—go ahead and show them what you're really capable of."

Something else enters her hand, and something else exits. Screaming follows again. Sounds like a couple people dive away

from the object before it makes contact with something heavy. Adora feels her legs turning around, facing the rest of the people in the market. Her sword comes to life in her hand, a familiar weight in her palms. The same, familiar shine doesn't enter her eyes, neither does the colorful rainbow of energy when the weapon charges up and blasts spacial magic across the way. She has no idea how far the spell reaches, only that it causes a handful of people to start screaming.

Adora feels something scratch violently against her back, piercing the skin and bleeding her uniform. She can feel the liquid dripping down her spine, pooling together down by her waist. She swats her weapon, before shooting a burst of energy again in an unknown direction for an unknown thing.

"Don't hold back! You weren't made to be a neutered government toy! Show them who you really are!"

The words together make sense to her. No, she wasn't made to be someone else's plaything, a tool for someone's schemes. She was made for greatness. These powers are hers, and hers alone. No one else's to judge, or control, or to even speak about. They're so lucky as to even bask in her presence, of the abilities she carries within an ounce of her body. Bright Moon is lucky to have her as their hero, and it's about time they see it this way.

It's about time Shadow Weaver sees what she's really messing with.

More and more Adora feels her limbs swinging all over the place, switching her weapon off and on and blasting energy bursts into the distance. Her skin burns more and more the longer this all manages to go on, feeling wet and heavy. Ringing erupts in her ears rather violently but she ignores it. The green flashes out here and there for black dots, but she remains strong. Because she is strong; she's a god among man, and man should understand this lesson.

Ultimately the god in Adora becomes overwhelmed. The voice starts screaming for her when her movements start to become sluggish, and no matter how desperately she tries to wield her weapon all she can feel is her heavy body slamming against the ground. The green finally disappears and Adora doesn't see much of anything. Nothing, except for the world dragging on past her as someone evacuates her from the grounds of the marketplace.

She wakes again with a start, and immediately after jumping out of her skin and then back in, a bright light starts flashing directly into her eyeballs. One, then the next.

"They're blue!"

The light leaves and Adora sees a giant red claw hop away from her radius, followed by the one person in this world she could never forget or fail to recognize. It should be a record, how little effort it takes for Catra to register in Adora's mind as Catra. She stands on the other end of the room, a massive shotgun in hand.

"I already told you I don't like gunplay." The words feel so wrong in Adora's own mouth; her tongue is heavy, though not swollen. Her throat is tight, though not bruised or inflamed. Her fingers and toes don't feel like her own, and the only thing she can recognize about herself is the soreness shooting down her spine and arms.

Adora lies dead on the mattress, staring at Catra like a drugged patient on a table. Catra's going to break into her brain, going to see all her secrets and all her lies. She's going to learn Adora better than anyone on this earth, better than herself, and there's nothing Adora can do about it.

Except this sort of thing already happened. It happened in the marketplace for the first time in decades, beginning a new panic and a new war she didn't intend to start. Adora relaxes into the bed, waiting to hear herself flatline.

“Tell me your least favorite food,” Catra says. She looks crazy just from her wide eyes alone, only for Adora’s vision to find that damned shotgun again. Adora tries to shift around, to sit up for this interrogation, but her body remains a flimsy corpse against her will.

“Turkey.”

“No, your *real* least favorite.”

Adora winces, catching sight of Scorpia as she answers, “Miso soup?”

And right then and there Scorpia gasps, “How do you not like miso soup? What’s wrong with you!”

“Mushrooms freak me out! They’re shaped weird and they’re soft when they should be crunchy!”

“That doesn’t even make sense! Oh, Adora, honestly, maybe we do need to get you checked.”

But Catra deems her good to go otherwise, setting the weapon against the wall. The shotgun faces upward, with no safety dared to be flipped on. Just in case; Catra was never the forgetful type. “No, she’s always been that fucking weird. Clinically fucking weird, I think.” She approaches Adora closer, passing the corner Scorpia hides in. “And still manages to be the scariest person in Bright Moon.”

“Second scariest,” Adora corrects. Again she tries to sit up, but Catra forces her downward with a hand to the shoulder. The extremely sore, sore shoulder. Both her rotator cuffs feel like they could snap with the smallest of movements. She adds, trying to forget her pain and failing, “Secondary to Prime.”

“We can work around a few mind tricks,” Catra assures. Her tone is defensive, quick with the words. Almost like she might not believe it herself. Adora tries to look at her, but turning isn’t agreeing with her, either. “For now, just rest. I’m sure Shadow

Weaver is crapping her pants, anyway. Your phone was blowing up before it finally died. Surprised she hasn't sent a whole platoon over here yet."

Again Scorpia's claws fly upward, pressing softly against her lips. "Oh, don't say that, please."

"I'm sure someone filmed footage of what happened and the whole government is on lockdown." Adora bends her knees upward, trying to flatten out her low back and relax. Her knees press tightly against the blankets, stretching everything in a good way. "Um, what did happen?"

"It looked like you were fighting him really hard," Catra starts, overall sugar coating the whole thing, "but eventually he got to you. He just stood there with his eyes all wide, didn't really say anything. I'm assuming he was saying a million and a half words to you."

"Then you ripped the bounty board off the wall," Scorpia finishes. Claws don't really move, though she lowers them slightly so as not to mumble. "It went flying towards some people, then you stopped for a while. Then everything started up again."

"Probably after he started saying more shit. But again," Catra leans against the opposite side of the bed, more interested in the underside of her nail than Adora, "all he really did was stand there with freakishly wide eyes. I thought they were going to fall out."

"It was disgusting," Scorpia agrees.

"He was definitely talking in there." Adora looks at Scorpia now, mostly because she's standing closer and easier to turn to. Though Adora does take a moment to notice Catra's reignited interest. "It felt like he was poking around in my head, if that makes sense. Like he was looking for something; trying to make me tick, maybe? Take over completely? I remember a few things. I remember being dragged away by both you guys, but everything else is in flashes. Like the bounty board."

Catra hums, considering everything with a raise of her brow. She looks over at Scorpia, shrugging. Deeming things here safe enough. She crosses through the apartment to the kitchen, leaving Catra and Adora alone together. Adora turns her attention to the ceiling.

"Did you stop me?" she asks. Her voice is quiet, between them, and Catra answers things with a simple nod of the head. "Did you or anyone else get hurt?"

"I mean, you got a few good hits in with me, but like I said, you were pretty resilient. The bounty board flew high in the air and shattered against a blocked-off building, for one. Mostly it just freaked people out. They got scared and dove, but you always overcompensated. Only reason you landed a hit on me was because I got the claws out; I was trying to get your attention."

"Are you hurt?"

"I think you were pulling punches. *You* are the one who got hurt. Stay in bed for a bit. Shadow Weaver can wait, and everyone in the city is cowering in their homes, anyway. Relax."

"I don't know what that word means and you know it," Adora laughs, which is a mistake that makes her chest hurt. "But I'll stay here. But only because those claws are so sharp."

"So knifeplay is in, then?"

"Maybe. Hey, I really appreciate you, you know. Half this town would be dead without you. Actually, *I* would be dead without you."

Catra tries to play things cool with a half shrug, one shoulder bouncing up into the air, but she can't hide that smile on her lips. "Don't pretend we were always on the same side. We were enemies, once upon a time."

"We could never be enemies, Catra."

“What, then?”

“Victims to circumstance?”

The three words manage to make Catra laugh, hard. “Get to sleep. I’m too tired to get philosophical with you.”

-

The city becomes a disaster. It doesn’t take a month. Not a steady, year-long plan with secret jobs and greasing a few palms here and there. It takes until the end of the week, a mere five days, for Prime to hold the entire city under his watch. Every corner Adora turns, someone is waiting for her with bright green eyes. He really decides to freak her out on day two, when he starts speaking through someone else’s mouth with his own voice. She’s not even sure how it’s possible, and in the moment sustained a lead pipe to the head while she was too busy focusing on the wrong thing.

Getting into the castle after spending a day at Catra’s was a disaster. Emergency teams and their dozens of guns, pointed at her face. Big turrets hidden behind cloaking spells in the castle, ones she’s no stranger to. Eyes followed her on the way in, as well as a whole squad to escort her. The examination took about an hour before they deemed her safe to interact with others and Shadow Weaver entered the room to psyche her out the way she always manages to with her sneaky wordplay. Mostly Adora was too tired to follow and just agreed to everything until Shadow Weaver was short on breath from lecturing.

Business as usual after that, as if Prime never happened. As if he wasn’t running around the city, turning people to his control, getting whatever he wants. He exposed himself at the marketplace. Whatever his plan was, his time in isolation has come to an end. Adora overhears the other Princesses reporting their own brainwash cases by the dozens every hour, and she can’t help but feel like the dumbest person in the world. She could’ve stopped him. She shouldn’t have cornered him in the

shop like that. The entire Continent is falling apart and it's all her fault.

Glimmer disagrees when they meet up, as does her associate Bow. Catra tells her she's an idiot. Scorpia just laughs and waves the concept of her being the time bomb who willed the city into whimpering in the corner off. Even Shadow Weaver refuses to comment. On the bright side, she allows Adora and Glimmer to meet in person in the castle now.

Most of everything becomes a giant PR show. She-Ra isn't the enemy! There is no threat! Prime's not scary at all! No, no, Prime's not that guy from all those years ago, how silly! Next question! Adora finds herself meeting a new photograph and autograph quota on the daily. She's the government's begging dog, desperately asking for forgiveness, and she deserves every minute of the groveling. She rushed into things too quickly with foolish impulse.

Things fall at a standstill. Either Prime is waiting for something in the shadows, putting a plan together, or he's messing with the government just to get them to trip over their own feet in the public eye. He hasn't been seen. Week two passes by and all he's done is petty crime through the placement and control of other people. It's his reminder he's out there, waiting and watching, and he's still yet to strike. He's resorting to blatant terrorism and Adora has no idea what to do about it other than tear the entire city apart looking for him.

All in all, she finds she doesn't need to be under Prime's influence to feel her skull being crushed by him. Out there, waiting and watching. She thinks to repeat the same event from the marketplace over and over until she wins and puts an end to all of this forever. Whatever his argument with the government and the Princesses, it has nothing to do with the innocent people of Etheria's vast cities. Yet here he is, using them all as toys simply because Adora made him angry.

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“It’s unfair and frankly, it’s evil. He’s a fucking asshole—and kind of a loser, to be honest—and he needs to be stopped. I don’t care what you have to say about it. Step aside and let me in, you giant, useless sack of rocks.”

Hordak stares down on Catra, his bright red mechanical eyes a perfect torch in the darkness of the space. Cloudy today, and parts of the building remains have been covered up by other merchants in the hopes of keeping their products and their own outfits dry. Something tells Catra Hordak wouldn’t care whether or not he was blasted with a hose at point-blank range. She could always run over and buy a preloaded wand and find out for herself.

“Are you even listening to me, or do I need to repeat the whole speech? One part of the speech? Keep insulting your weirdo brother until you reboot and learn to use words? Do I need to use pictures and crayons to—”

“Enough.” His voice is a deep register, powerful in tone and very capable of getting one’s attention with or without the anger in his eyes. Hordak doesn’t look away from Catra, like he’ll lose her in the dark day’s shadows. “I’m unsure how to inform you that I agree with you.”

“Just say you agree with me, maybe? Look, where the hell even is Prime? Maybe we can work something out. Maybe you could talk to him and send him on a cruise so he’ll stop throwing a gigantic tantrum.”

“I will convince Entrapta to start a blocker against his abilities. I already have one designed. I did it many, many years ago.”

“Wait, so you’ve never trusted him before? At all?”

“I’m aware of his capabilities. There are some things he did to the last alliance. Micah and Angella weren’t the only people he killed; he had them in the streets, beating each other; committing suicide; killing their own families in the most creative ways he

could think up; dragging out punishments long after the government attempted to speak with him. He doesn't listen. He won't negotiate; he wants what he wants and nothing else. Above all, he believes himself to be a teacher, one who leads with example."

Catra leans against the door of the shop, closed shut and dead for the day. Not because of the weather. Because everyone who walks past Prime's old shack starts shaking with nerves and leaves the marketplace as quickly as possible, praying under their breaths not to get murdered this day. "And what does Prime want, exactly? Why even wait this long? His powers have never changed. He could've done this years and years ago."

"True. He could have." Hordak remains completely still, a pencil with vampire features. His short Mohawk doesn't so much as twitch, a short bit of hair on the top of his head with plenty of nothing to do. Just like Hordak himself. "But he wanted to try a different approach. He did want to give this new Alliance a chance, once the legislation was set in motion. He truly believed a fresh perspective would move things in a different direction and see it through that your caretaker with big ideas was given the big position she always wanted. Besides, she knew some of the old Alliance members personally and is a talented sorcerer. Who else?"

"So Shadow Weaver was given the seat she has today because of a mind trick. Perfect. Makes sense, actually. It's really only something she would have done."

Hordak nods, though he expresses no interest in any of the words in Catra's mouth. "Things were working better, for a while. He liked helping people one-on-one here. Then things started to sit still. For too long. Bright Moon's crime rate started rising. But he sat here, in his booth, listening to everyone's problems, never sharing a word from their minds with a soul on this earth. Including me. Whether these were good things or not, I cannot tell you. I am certain he was educated on the current Princesses. On She-Ra."

“And then she proved everything wrong with the Alliance and Shadow Weaver by busting in here hot and heavy?”

Again Hordak nods, interested in her words. Mostly interested in her getting out of here and out of his face, probably. “I was waiting for the day his plan would set in motion. The city has failed. This government posse of superheroes failed, and the management behind it all was pathetic. Dishonest. Manipulative. Just as powered people have been treated for years in this place. He wanted everything to fall apart not to sweep in and be the hero, but to show everyone the error of their society. This is the conversation he would have with Shadow Weaver and any other ranking official: shut the government down and never reopen. As you can guess, such a thing would never willingly happen. Reform did not have success, either; my brother has achieved everything he wants. Now he can destroy the town within itself. He can irritate the government all he wants while their heroes, such as She-Ra, run around in circles looking silly, performing PR hacks to make themselves look better.”

“She has been extra smiley lately. Okay then, Hordak, what do you propose we do? I’m assuming you want to stop him at all. If you won’t, I’m going home and taking a nap after that long ass story.”

“Disruptors. I already have Entrapta working away at them. No one will be allowed to bother her. I’m sure this is why you’re here in the first place, anyhow. Return later in the week and we’ll get started.”

“In the meantime don’t get killed?”

That’s when Hordak does something awful with his face: he twists the corners of his lips upward, his jaw clamping shut as he has the audacity to smile at her with ugly, crooked, yellow teeth which all twist into one another and practically beg to be pulled out and replaced. He tells her, before sending her on her merry way, “Do try not to get killed, yes.”

Chapter End Notes

damn i want some fucken miso soup man

Primary Directive, Part Two: the Gauntlet

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

More and more days pass, and more and more photographs are taken. People are starting to point out the obvious scheme going on here, and Adora just has to smile and carry on like a brainless idiot too stupid to understand or grasp a strain of the big concept here. She's just a big dumb hero at this point, putting patches up all over the city hoping everything doesn't burst at once and explode into a million little pieces for the next Continent over to roast up and cook up as an afternoon snack.

Adora feels herself slowly beginning to go insane.

No one is doing anything about anything. Glimmer doesn't have any special secrets for her, meaning Glimmer is now off the trustworthy list or things are really so secret. Or, worst yet, there is absolutely no plan of action here. Against Prime. Against the mind controlling fiend who is making the city people tear one another apart like some sort of cruel prank. Adora finds one guy repeatedly slapping himself in the face, crying and begging for it to stop. She has to lasso his hand behind his back and bring him to an expert in the castle. Probably still hasn't been fixed; maybe he's the weeping she hears in the back of her head every morning.

So Adora starts searching. Talking with people. Gathering information. Prime is in town somewhere. He's a person, not a ghost; he didn't simply disappear off the face of the planet. She checks the marketplace one more time as Adora, mostly avoiding staring at the finer details of all the things she managed to break. No Prime. Just his scary brother guarding that genius inventor's door with his life. Adora wonders how great she would be as a Princess. Probably a superstar, the way people around here rely on her so much.

None of Shadow Weaver's words mean anything to her ears. Her voice is almost worse than the constant ringing between them. The woman tells her to go left, she'll go right. Nothing here is adding up, even more than usual, and the woman refuses to offer any honesty. She's still interested in gangs more than anything else. Emptying out warehouses and having police patrols confiscate the supplies. Mysteriously the supplies end up in government storehouses instead. Sometimes in usage. Definitely a coincidence. Not shady at all. She's totally not picking and choosing which gangs and which people to beat up, either!

Adora spends an entire day at Catra's some time, mostly bothering her all day. Catra's one day off, and Adora begs her to do some boring normal people stuff together. Go shopping. Pay bills. Look at taxes. Fix up the motorcycle. They walk to the market together, sampling pre-loaded magical items until the vendor gets annoyed and kicks them both out. She spends a lot of time hanging out with that pale dog as well, thanking him again for his help with Prime.

In the middle of the afternoon, Hordak shoots Catra some sort of look and suddenly she's rushing Adora off the premises, telling her to be ready for something she describes as, simply, "everything". So Adora climbs up to the highest building possible, listening to everyday average people with her not-everyday average hearing. Concerns about living in Bright Moon longer. Concerns about Prime. How much they hate powered people. How fake She-Ra is —their tax dollars are paying for her to fly around and act like a teenager?

She tries to take less pictures with people, then the people are concerned she doesn't like them anymore. And, of course, an entire meeting with Shadow Weaver about who is in charge and who should be giving the orders. So Adora continues her pointless tasks, flying around town taking pictures and doing nothing much of anything else. Everything is going perfectly smooth, until she loses control of herself and crash-lands into the asphalt.

Paralyzed on the ground, Adora can see the rest of the people repeating the same uselessness. Powered or normal, She-Ra or not, they're all stuck with their heads tilted to the sky. Prime projects himself high into the clouds, a giant green hologram which doesn't really exist pouring out of the night. He tells them to give up. He tells them they're all pathetic and weak, and that their government still hasn't come through for them. There is no plan for the city. There is no plan for someone like him—and if they can't take care of a single man, how helpful are they really?

He asks, his tone as calm and victorious and smug as ever, "How can you possibly feel safe in a place like this?"

Bragging comes next. How achieved he is. How much experience he has against the Alliance, the hold he has over the entire Continent. His reach extends to the shores of Salineas, to the deserts of the Crimson Waste. He knows no limits. He knows no better man and no equal.

Most importantly, clear in everyone's minds and directly created into their image, he makes an ultimatum. He will meet with one person and one person only in this world. There is one soul he's willing to speak to and reason with, and it's the person who's managed to remove him from retirement:

"She-Ra. Don't be shy. And don't be late."

-

Rubble crunches beneath her golden boots when she lands. It's a loud entrance, far from shy, far from scared. Prime stands still as ever, surveying the land below him; the busy street, cars jammed in traffic with bike couriers weaving through lanes, their deliveries snugly tucked away; different levels of apartments lit up with lights, one of which fully displays a father dancing happily with his son; people sitting outside family-owned restaurants, chatting and enjoying a meal. He bothers to take the time to soak it all in. Adora can watch later. Something more important is in her sights right now.

“You have interesting priorities.” Damn mind reader. Adora thinks she should start thinking of boobs to make him uncomfortable. “Won’t you join me? Won’t you take a moment to enjoy the town you spend so much of your time protecting?”

“Maybe later. Right now someone’s threatening it.”

“Not someone.” He turns finally, his long white hair shrugging over his shoulders. Each of the braids tackles one another, pushing and shoving one strand out of the way in favor of the next. “An institution. An institution who would take people such as you and I and rank them. But we’re not so different, are we really? We wake up every day. Consume meals. Go about our business. Sleep every night. There is no difference between powered people, Adora. Only those who are deemed more desirable than the others.”

“There’s a world of difference. We all *choose.* Some people would choose to run around and abuse their powers. Others dedicate their lives to snuffing that out.”

“How can one abuse a power which belongs to them and them only? Those people in that castle, Adora. Those are the abusers. Who are they to categorize us? Who are they to give us orders? We are gods among them. We have been blessed. Who do they think they are?”

“It’s about keeping order. It doesn’t have anything to do with power trips.”

“Really?” He chuckles, stepping closer. “Then explain Shadow Weaver.”

She finds she can’t, and it only entertains Prime further.

“You’re missing the big picture, She-Ra. It’s always been about order; the balance of life is order. By picking and choosing her favorites, Shadow Weaver is disrupting the natural balance of order. This town will never survive. It needs help, you see, to find that order.”

Then something switches in him. He stands different now, changing his stance from one favored leg to the other. One is in front of the next, a pointed stance a fencer might take. But Prime has no weapons on him. It's probably the worst detail about him in the first place: a scary man armed with absolutely nothing. His faux welcoming attitude disappears into a massive frown, the sides of his lips becoming dimples with the motion.

"If you and your band of friends should stand in my way, I have no choice but to consider you an act against order; an act against this town. It puts you on my list."

Sword bared in both hands, Adora stares Prime dead in his eyes when she tells him, "Fuck your list, man."

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"Oh great, she's chosen the rooftop to duke it out on. What a good fucking choice." Catra stands in the distance, sitting on her motorcycle. She waits patiently as Scorpia ties down another one of Prime's zombies to a light post, apologizing profusely as she backs away.

"Hey," she asks, "do we know the status on Entrapta's device? This is starting to get scary, Catra."

"I know. She's working on helmets for each of the Princesses to have extra protection against mind fucking, but I don't think she can produce many right now. Not without a whole factory. There aren't enough disruptors as it is—we'll still miss parts of town. That's *if* she actually managed to complete working units of these things. She did this really fast."

"Is there at least one helmet? If the disruptors fail?"

"I hope so. They just have to keep moving. Stay off of Prime's radar. *Damn,* that was a hit!"

Scorpia's eyes trace up to the building, just in time for Prime to dodge one of Adora's attacks and land his fist against the side of

her jaw. She just shakes it off and keeps going. “This is not going to end well for him up there.”

“I hope not. Let’s get these disruptors going. Entrapta is almost done with those, maybe two units left. I don’t—” Adora takes another set of hits up on that rooftops, looking back and forth. But Prime isn’t moving at all. She turns completely around, swinging her sword at something that isn’t there.

They need to hurry.

The clunky piece of technology is lifted from the rickety second hand wagon attached to the back of the bike, too heavy even for someone like Scorpia. Someone made of muscles. Catra does her best to help, and after placing just one of these things on the ground she feels her arms ready to go full noodle. She was never weak, but then again she was never a bodybuilder, either. This is going to take all sorts of time they don’t have. The fact Prime’s zombies are rushing all throughout town isn’t helping, either. Back and forth they become obstacles, Scorpia punching them out as a last resort.

By the time Catra and Scorpia return the bike and start plotting the next route for the next device, things up above aren’t looking well. Adora continues swinging at nothing, with her fists now. No idea where the sword went. There’s no time to dwell on it. Every second wasted leaves Adora further in the dirt.

In the rear view mirror, Catra sees Adora freeze up. She’s hunched over, staring at the ground infinitely. Catra revs the engine, speeding through the streets, Entrapta’s inventions cluttering dangerously in the back.

Then she swerves the bike, hitting a curb and throwing everything attached to the vehicle flying in the air. Scorpia lands somewhere next to where Catra skids against the earth. The devices from Entrapta are too heavy to go anywhere; luckily enough they just tilt the cart when the bike lands on its side. Nothing hurts. Nothing but her head as an intruder forces himself inside, making

her skull feel as if it's collapsing in on itself. Scorpia, next to her, is pressing her pincers against her skull as well. Words Catra isn't hearing at all enter her mind, and her first reaction is to get back on the bike. She detaches the cart for now. Scorpia tells her to go, go as fast as possible.

Mostly, thankfully, Catra can manage to ignore Prime's speech about everything wrong in the city. It's the same thing she hears from everyone on her part of town, anyway. He's really not that special! The words mean nothing. The words don't affect her at all. It's the fact she can see Adora from here that stops her bike in the middle of the road.

The strongest person in Bright Moon, the hero of the weaker man, everyone's idol, the face plastered all around every possible empty wall of every building, has been defeated. Hordak's loser brother holds her over the edge of that giant bank's rooftop, dangling her by the neck as he makes his speech about order and where to place one's hope. Some stupid news helicopter buys into the propaganda, hovering nearby and catching the whole show on footage. It's everything Prime's always wanted: a show.

"Look at your hero, Bright Moon! She could not save you! Your government cannot save you! You cannot even save yourselves, if you tried! *I* am the answer, whether you can accept it or not."

Catra can't look at the next part. She flings her feet back onto the bike, taking off at full speed. The back wheel protests, swerving angrily, but she ignores it all. She can't bear to look as Prime lets go, allowing Adora to plummet to the earth below.

On the other side of Catra's route, blocks and blocks away, a blast of pink and purple flash through the streets. Glimmer lands her feet anywhere possible for her feet to press against and keeps the momentum going, from sidewalks to the sides of buildings to right smack in the middle of busy traffic. Cars swerve out of the way. Cusses fly her way. She doesn't stop. Not until she finds herself skidding to a halt, nearly falling over her own feet, at the base of

a small coffee shop. The impact of the human inside the rubble is clear, but she can't easily spot any signs of said human.

"Bow!"

"I'm on my way!"

In that case, Glimmer gets to work. Bricks are broken and scattered everywhere, kicking up dust as she tosses them all aside, one by one. Glimmer moves a huge piece of debris—she assumes it's part of what used to be the roof—and finally finds Adora's head. Human. Normal sized. Definitely not She-Ra right now. Unconscious. Glimmer yells, but Adora doesn't respond; she's out cold.

Bow and Catra are on the scene in an instant, the roar of Catra's motorcycle far from shy. Rubble starts to fly everywhere now, until they finally manage to unearth Adora and lay her on the ground, far from harm. The crowds start piling in, and there's no way to hide it anymore. Bright Moon's greatest hero, defeated and her secret exposed. All this effort from Adora, all those lectures from Shadow Weaver, gone. The flashes from cell phones and news vultures begin to flash without hesitation. Catra hears several different voices talking over one another, mostly addressing their audiences on whatever platform they've decided to livestream on. Seriously, fuck people.

"She has a pulse," Bow exhales. Catra feels like she's going to pass out. Somewhere in the back of her mind she hopes Scorpia's alright.

There is no second to waste now. Glimmer lifts Adora in a fireman's carry, rushing her off for Bright Moon's giant castle. Home. Infirmary. Catra hops on her bike, revving her engine loudly for Bow to catch on. She'll have to pick up Scorpia later. She and Bow don't stray too far from Glimmer's trail, who eventually starts pushing herself beyond her limits, faster and faster for the castle. She enters far earlier than they do. Adora is safe, inside, and Catra starts to breathe a little easier.

Until they stop her at the door.

“She’s with me.” Bow argues with the guards for a solid four minutes. Shadow Weaver’s orders. No outsiders. They’re on lockdown. He’s barely allowed to enter.

Screw this. Catra can break in later. “Go.”

Bow stops, confused at the notion of Catra blatantly giving up. They’ve never talked, never interacted beyond what they know about one another via Adora. “No, I can—”

“She needs you, man, just go. I can figure it out. Go! Make sure she’s okay! Don’t let her be alone in there!”

His mouth opens and closes several times, until Catra’s stubbornness finally gets to him. Bow promises he’ll find a way, before rushing himself inside. Catra just stands out here, blocked by the guards, watching helplessly.

Chapter End Notes

> Sometimes the hero loses and it’s epic and awful and dreadful and really shows who they are as a person. The fact Adora is such an epic hero in her own right is a bonus ;)

A Hero's Lament

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She can’t follow the blinding light, because it brings a burning ache straight to her brain. Her entire body aches the same, a burning feeling she’s never felt before in her life. Shadow Weaver has them administer all sorts of injections. Four into her neck. Almost every one of her ribs. Four more into the low back, and one longer needle into her knee. She’s so tired, so exhausted, she can barely make it back to her apartment.

Shadow Weaver watches her enter. Makes sure she doesn’t pass out in the hallway or something. Temporary leave. She’ll keep Adora updated. No part of Shadow Weaver even sounds sad any of this happened, and Adora doesn’t know why she’s so surprised. Adora doesn’t say anything. Barely looks at Shadow Weaver. She enters the room, a straight path for the bed, her feet dragging, and collapses for the night.

When she wakes again she’s expected in the medical facilities. It’s impossible to move anything, and the most they can offer her is a heaping pile of ice packs. She tells them she’d rather take an ice bath and tries to retire for the day. But two visitors wait in front of her door, ruining her plans. Sympathy is painted all across their faces, and something about it makes her feel betrayed by her only two real allies in this place. She’ll be everyone’s perfect hero again when this is all over. They don’t need to be sharing those faces with her.

Except she won’t be. She’ll never be the perfect hero of Bright Moon ever again, and she’s not convinced she ever was. It’s pretty bad, isn’t it, if they need to offer their sympathy at her door? Everything is lost because of her failure. She never should have bothered with Prime. The most she’s done is destroy the town. Nothing will ever be the same. She’s pierced fear into those who

would chant her name, photograph her, love her. She-Ra is now one of those demons they hate; a powered person taking advantage of them all. Yet, in the destruction of it all, in the destruction of Adora's very person, there's only one real concern on her mind. Only one she can focus on. Not the people. The buildings. Certainly not her reputation.

She eyeballs both Bow and Glimmer, leaning into the wall with all her weight. "Where is Catra?"

Neither can conjure up an answer right away, and it's everything she needs to know. She doesn't want the thought-up version. She wants the first answer, the raw truth, and it can't be offered in words. Bow says something about finding her way in here, but Adora doesn't want to hear it. She knows what she did. What she saw.

Adora pushes her way into the room, telling them both they won't be needed around here. Leave her be. They obey, and she's unsure if it's because they're afraid of She-Ra's wrath or because they're afraid of Adora's.

What does she care? She killed Catra. Watched the life leave her eyes up there on that rooftop. Nothing else will ever matter.

-

Temporary leave. She didn't think it existed! She could start a hobby. Read a book. See if there's anything in this world she actually likes.

There is one thing she likes, and it makes her sick to her stomach.

On the first day of her extended break she decides to watch something. It's so fresh in her mind, so fresh an event her body is still healing from it. The footage is all over the news, whether or not the cameras wanted to capture the story in the first place. She remembers the pre-showdown conversation with Prime, the big talk before the big fight. Just like the movies. His energy throughout the fight is so calm, so poised and proper. She decides

she doesn’t want to watch it at all and turns over on her side. Then the speech starts. She doesn’t remember this part at all.

It was never normal, seeing herself on TV. She always felt alien, like someone else was staring back at her. She-Ra, an entire entity of her own, the greatest hero this town would ever see, a face in photographs and T-shirts and banners and painted in street art all over the town. She never considered She-Ra. She was always Adora.

But this person on the TV is someone she’s never seen before. It scares her. This person with the busted up eye, blood pouring out from between her teeth, barely able to catch her breath—she doesn’t know that person. No one in the world knows that person. Prime created her. He put on his show. Pushed her beyond herself, and she can’t decide if it’s for better or worse. Adora always loved pushing herself. But this feels extreme.

-

Adora spends the next few days on her bed, refusing to move. She’s finally learned to stay here, completely still, and sleeps the day away for the first time in her life. It was never her strong suit, yet here she is, a reborn person, completely changed forever, sleeping. There’s nothing. Sleep. Wake up, turn over, sleep. Often she hears knocking at the door, but she can’t offer a proper response. Sleep. She’s so tired, she could sleep her life away.

Forever passes. Or maybe it’s really only been twenty minutes, she’s unsure. There’s no time in here. Just her, the bed, the sheets, and sleep.

Someone’s presence appears in the room, and she doesn’t bother turning over to face them. She doesn’t ever want to leave this place.

“Your leave is over, Adora. Report for inspection.”

She doesn’t move. Maybe if she’s still, so completely still, Shadow Weaver will forget her.

Not likely. Adora has no choice but to submit, standing on heavy legs, dragging them through the halls. She makes the doctors mad with her ignorance of them, but she can't be bothered. She's simply too tired. One of them suggests a psych evaluation, but Shadow Weaver isn't interested. Adora's not dead and not in the ground, so she must be perfectly fine!

"The agent may resume. No residuals to physical health. Mental, however—"

"It's perfect." Shadow Weaver turns to her, but she doesn't turn to Shadow Weaver. "You may summon She-Ra. Bright Moon is experiencing riots. Do not interact with civilians. We need your presence to keep the peace. Go. Stand tall, no more of that slouching."

Not like she's still sore or anything. Maybe if Adora skipped those ice baths, she would've bought herself a couple more days. She remains on the table, warming the leather. She's never noticed the tiles on the ground before. Emerald? Since when is emerald a Bright Moon color scheme?

"Adora, I gave you an order."

Her legs get up, a practiced pattern. She can't register the sword in her hand, always stuck to her like a chip in a dog's head, or how the tiles become so much further away from her eyes. She's a zombie, dragging her feet brainlessly out of the room. Perhaps this feature isn't really new at all. Perhaps it's who she really was all along, foolish enough to let this happen to herself.

Somewhere along the line she ends up on the streets again. People call out to her, those few who can still stand her. They shout her name, reach out to her, but it's different. Adora's never heard She-Ra's name in this tone before. It's the other half she's never heard, the quiet minority making themselves known, and she hears them louder than anyone else. They hate her. She doesn't blame them. She watches them, trying to break through police lines. Throwing things. Screaming, cursing her name.

People like her, the idols of this city, the heroes, they killed their sons. Daughters. Fathers. Mothers, aunts, uncles, greatest loves.

Adora stands here, taking it all. She's not sure who this is meant to be helping, but an order's an order. Such is the code of her life, never to be broken.

Sirens go off as the riots increase in intensity. Family store down the street is being broken into. It's what the police tell her. Shadow Weaver repeats, right in her buzzing ear, but she doesn't move. She can't; she's frozen here, forever. All these people—it's for the best. All she does is destroy.

"She-Ra! I gave you an order!"

Adora remains still. Silent. If she's lucky, she can turn into stone forever.

"She-Ra!"

The people remain the same, staring at her with bright eyes. The whole world is staring at her, in this moment, and for all moments forever after. She's too destructive not to. And whatever other phrases left Prime's mouth in his big speech.

"Arrest She-Ra!"

From the moment she's slammed against the pavement, Adora watches them. Some anger fizzles out. Confusion. Joy.

Justice.

-

"Your trial is set for next week. Some people wait years. Anything for She-Ra, right?"

The guard slides the tray under the door, scoffing when she doesn't respond. Every day for two weeks, it's the same. Adora never moves from that corner. It's hers, now. Now and forever.

She’s told she has visitors. She doesn’t care much for them. Or talking. She'd rather sit here, wasting away for what she’s done.

She doesn’t move, doesn’t talk, doesn’t exist, until the trial. Bright Moon provides an attorney, a nervous young man, but she doesn’t care for him. Nor the cameras in her face as she ascends those perfect morning marble stairs, the faces that burn into her as she passes through the halls. There is no hate, no anger, only shock. This is Adora, in her truest form, without the glamor or the magic. Three feet shorter, much more human, she enters the courtroom. No news reports. No cell phone photographs with crappy angles and crappy lighting. Everyone can see her now. Everyone knows their hero is a normal human woman now, and there’s no conspiracy against the fact, because the fact is plain as day.

They ask her how she, the defendant, pleads. Adora can’t answer. Her eyes are too heavy to lift. Too weighted to look that judge in the face. She’s dedicated to turning into stone. She hears the attorney trying to defend her. They try to make her flesh again, but she won’t have it.

The defendant used her powers to destroy the town she’s sworn to protect, in the poorest district of Bright Moon.

But she was possessed! Toyed with!

She refused a direct order from her superior. Post-possession.

Shadow Weaver doesn’t do much to help. She’s as silent as Adora, observing it all. After all, there are other powered people out there. Her reach extends to all of Etheria; she’ll find some other wide-eyed gullible fool, no problem. She’s finally called to the stand for her side of Adora’s sudden disobedience, and Adora opens her ears again to hear the betrayal.

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It’s such a pitiful town. Breaking into places is hardly a challenge at all. No wonder everyone here is so jumpy at every shadow that passes; Catra guesses this is why all the buildings are so damn

big. You can get in, sure, but you can't find anything! This is why she never took those break-in jobs!

The courtroom is somewhat easy to spot. Big line of people all the way down the street. The doors are open, probably in the hopes they'll all shut up about not getting to hear the public trial for themselves. Despite all the TV screens broadcasting all this nonsense live downtown. Guards here are easily distracted; she gets in like she belongs in.

(It's Adora, of course she belongs in this stupid room.)

"Well, if the defendant will not present her case, I think we can approach the final verdict."

Catra starts full on sprinting, collecting gasps from random people and curses from the security guards she pushes past and dodges. They finally manage to grab her, but Shadow Weaver tells them to let her in. Let her talk. She's a harmless nobody hybrid, after all.

"This is all a load of bullshit!"

Catra glances over, watching as Adora untangles herself from her pity. Sitting up, slowly. Listening.

She doesn't look up, not fully, but she's more awake than she looked walking in this place. Another detail the entire town is commenting on, calling her tiredness fake and practiced. She can transform, therefore it makes her the greatest liar and actor known to man. Double Trouble would murder the first person to say that.

"You're really going to take Shadow Weaver's side? Because she has a big, fancy badge? She's from the Fright Zone, did you know that? That big scary place you all hate and want to burn?"

"What does geography and classism have to do in regards to She-Ra?" Shadow Weaver asks. She wears that stupid mask, a coward hiding from the world. She's so obviously a liar, it makes Catra

want to pull her own hair out and go insane right before everyone's eyes.

"Classism has everything to do with *everything* , you old hag."

The judge raises her hand. Time for this to end. Time for Catra to start talking faster.

"Shadow Weaver's reach extends everywhere. *Classism* is her favorite tool. She controls gangs out in the Fright Zone—including contracting people like me—to get her dirt. Half the big busts this town gets is because of people like me. And before you start—It's all elaborate. All secret. Of course you don't believe me!"

The judge starts waving Catra and her crazy rants off, to Shadow Weaver's extreme satisfaction. Catra gets a glance of Adora, who is fully staring at her now. Fully connected. She looks exhausted.

That's fine. It's Catra's turn.

Catra breaks from their unwelcome grip, leaping over the bar to where Adora sits and stands directly behind her. Right behind the town's greatest star, the town's greatest overachiever who can't seem to find herself off the TV screen. Adora slumps again, stuck inside herself. It's kind of perfect, actually. Catra unsheathes her claws, happy to freak everyone out, and rips the back of Adora's orange jumpsuit open, revealing her brand from Shadow Weaver to the world. The brand, and dozens and dozens of scars.

"How is Shadow Weaver not the villain over Prime? This is how she treats your 'heroes'—see for yourself!"

Adora remains completely still, a perfect canvas for everyone to gawk at. The room goes silent as everyone throws their nosy eyes to Bright Moon's favorite hero. Photographers and other cameras hone in the canvas, breaking every possible privacy law in town.

"A brand," Catra says, "like property. Powered people are *property* to you? Pawns? Haven't you told the public dozens of times these

heroes are free individuals? How many other lies are you keeping under that stupid mask?”

Catra catches Glimmer’s eye. She nods, before rushing to Catra’s side. Boots off. Two brands, right on her feet. Burned on, forever. The other Princesses rush over, pushing past every obstacle, every guard holding them from the truth, showing off all theirs off as well. Every single one of them, branded like property. Everyone is here in one place for the first time, and it’s nothing like any of them imagined. But it’s everything they were made to do: bring truth and justice.

“Frosta is eleven years old,” Glimmer adds, helping this case tremendously. “Who brands a child?”

“Shadow Weaver is afraid of these people,” Catra says. “She branded them, abused them, and tricked them with fancy rooms and fancy service. A fake life of false luxury and false freedom. She-Ra is constantly patrolling the town, no matter the hour. How is that the life of a free individual? How can we trust Shadow Weaver to be the judge on good versus bad? How, when she’s no better than Prime? When she buries away undesirable powered people and chains down the useful ones?”

Shadow Weaver finally takes a stand, rising tall to her grounded feet. Strong. Solid. She’s never lost, and she doesn’t plan on starting now.

“This is insubordination!” she yells. Catra grasps Adora’s shoulders —tabling the way she jumps, for now—presenting the scars all over again.

“And this is abuse!”

“It’s no wonder She-Ra ignored you!” Bow yells from the crowd.

Glimmer adds, “Because you’re a monster!”

The courtroom explodes into a madhouse. Wrong versus right. Right versus wrong. Evidence. Facts. Bad. Good. Evil. Hero. Anger.

It’s everywhere. It’s complete chaos. The people versus a stuttering government.

From within the madness, someone yells, “It’s no wonder the powered people are uprising!” It’s no wonder Prime exists. It’s no wonder it’s impossible to live a normal life in a city that needs superheroes to keep things from falling apart. Shadow Weaver says they’d all be destroyed without her government leadership. It makes the crowd angrier, desperate for the truth. Desperate for the right. The wrong. Good. Bad. Hero.

They need a hero.

Catra feels it. The heavy breaths. The long exhale. She sees Adora’s hands, fidgeting anxiously, underneath her handcuffs. Then the metal links burst, destroyed, nothing before her, as Bright Moon’s favorite hero rises in her true form. Stealing everyone’s breath. She’s a giant among them, a god, and they all watch in awe.

“Enough!” Adora yells. It silences all protests left in the room. She has them. She has them all. She has the greatest power of them all. Catra watches in person, watching with her own eyes what Adora plans to do with it. “While we’re all in here, arguing with ourselves, he’s out there. And he’s—”

Adora stops, terror not shy to expose itself across her face. Her breaths are uneasy, heavy like she’s freshly out of a marathon.

“Shadow Weaver is a bad person. She controls people. But that doesn’t mean we should let Prime take the chance to control her. Nobody here deserves that. No—nobody should ever go through that. Ever. We need to get to work. Now. We can’t sit here and fight! Go! Get up! He’s not waiting! He’s not shy! He’s not her—he’s bold! Aggressive!”

Adora pauses, eyes searching around the crowd.

“He’s—he’s terrifying.”

There’s not much argument to follow. Even Shadow Weaver shuts her mouth. Adora’s two friends take the chance to get her out of here, walking freely as everyone here stammers, unsure of what just happened and what exactly they should do about it.

Catra hangs back, but for a moment. She wants to see the look in Shadow Weaver’s eyes for herself. Finally, the world might know the truth about her. But that’s a project for later.

By the time Catra makes it outside, she watches Adora take off without a word. Her friends vow to give her some space. Not Catra. Adora’s had her space. It’s time to be pushy. Catra Isn't really her friend, anyway. She heads for her motorcycle, mapping out the quickest way to Adora’s hiding spots.

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There is no way she climbed all this way, Catra notes. Humans are much too lazy. Especially humans with flying powers. Adora’s friends could get up here, too. The fast one can run alongside the building. The normie, he can use a grappling hook or something equally movie-like. Catra prefers this. All that seems too easy; she’d get bored with climbing considering all the weird places she’s climbed.

A certain satisfaction comes with arriving at the top, and she loves the feeling every time. Today’s a little different. Today’s satisfaction is in her locating Adora. The orange jumpsuit is gone, thankfully. Back in that ugly red jacket.

“I would make fun of you for the wardrobe change, but I’m the one who destroyed your clothes in the first place.”

Adora jumps at her voice, startled. They’re in the safe confines of an old sniper’s nest, high above the city, observing the land before Bright Moon. But the public knows it better as a clocktower, and the pair of them know it best as their mutual quiet spot. It’s all a little too much for Catra tonight. Right now, it’s easy to tune out,

as she observes the way Adora stares at her. Confused. Oh come on, she can have a little more faith in Catra's empathy, can't she?

"You touched me," Adora says. She's quiet, but Catra's no deaf old bat.

"Relax. It was above the belt."

No reaction. Adora just stares, and at this point it's starting to freak Catra out. She's never been great with these sorts of things. She takes the first step, sitting closer to Adora. Adora said something about touch, so Catra grabs her hand. Probably too forcefully. It's unsure at first, until Adora accepts it, gently wrapping her fingers around Catra's like she'll break her if she's not too careful.

"You're . . ." Adora trails off, lost and unsure. It's so strange, so unlike her, Catra doesn't know what to do about it. She doesn't even make eye contact, doesn't really lead the way she always does.

After a pause, Adora picks up again, restarting. "He made me see things. A lot of things. I felt like I was trapped in my own head. Like I could claw all my skin off, and I still wouldn't be free."

"Kind of like Shadow Weaver's tricks growing up?"

"No, those are tricks. This was *control.* "

Catra wants to ask what she's seen, but such a question feels foolish. *Hey, while we're here, let's dig through your traumatic experience!* She decides to be patient. Maybe Adora is leading this conversation after all.

"He was in there, like a ghost. Digging around. At first it felt like he was crushing my skull. Then there was nothing. Then, everything, like he was trying to figure me out. I think I understand what it all was, now."

"But in the moment, you were confused."

Adora finally looks up at her, all the exhaustion from these past weeks in her eyes. It's no wonder she hunches over; the weight is too heavy, even for her. Her eyes are the same blue, that bright diamond shade Adora's always had, but Catra hardly recognizes them. The person behind them has changed, as they confide in her: "I was terrified, Catra."

All those times she's run head-on into danger, laughing at bullets. Shrugging at scars. It's hard to believe. But those eyes don't lie; Catra isn't sure they can right now.

"I thought—I-I thought—"

Adora stammers, the words choking her as the fear returns to her bones. She starts breathing heavy, like she's going to collapse with a panic attack any minute now.

"Catra, I saw—I-I thought—I thought I killed you. I-I swear, that's what I saw."

That's when it happens. Bright Moon's favorite hero, their charming, shining knight, breaks. Her hand flies over her mouth as the sob escapes her, embarrassed. She's embarrassed, and Catra wants to call her an idiot.

She doesn't. She pulls Adora in close, supporting the good that holds this city together.

"It's okay."

"Can we please go to your apartment? I haven't slept in two weeks."

Of course. Obviously. Catra climbs down on her own preference, meanwhile Adora simply jumps off the tower. It's her first time on Catra's bike, and Catra feels her nerves bouncing all around. She's imagined this moment in time, a million different ways. Only in her head they were going somewhere quiet and romantic, somewhere far, far away from everything. Adora would eye the bike with awe and talk about how awesome it is. In real life, she

does not. She just gets on, boneless as she places her arms around Catra and rests her head against Catra's shoulders. She's sluggish and clingy, no different from a hard-worked dog about to be put down. Catra wouldn't let that happen. She'll stay by Adora's side all night. After all this time, she's more than relieved to do so.

It's a strange feeling, walking Adora into the apartment. It's a normal circumstance, and it's even weirder when they both just head to bed. Almost naturally feels the motion, but most of all it weirds Catra out this isn't a hookup. Not a hookup, not a business thing. Just sleep. Sleeping together, relaxing together, forgetting the world together. What a feeling to get drunk on.

Adora doesn't really have a spot in the apartment. Catra wants to change that. She takes the discarded jacket and boots when Adora isn't looking, hanging them up next to her leather jacket. Boots on the ground underneath the hook, because Catra's never really worn shoes in her life before. Melog inspects them, regarding the garment strangely. As if Adora was a stranger.

Said not-stranger is already dead to the world on the bed, deep breaths and snapped-shut eyes. Thankfully she's turned her head one way, because if she'd noticed Catra making Adora feel a little more like home Catra would have to murder her. She tells Adora's passed out body, "You so owe me that first date."

"Deal." And the body smiles, happy to have caught Catra so off-guard, peeking over to catch a glimpse of the redness in her face. "But I *will* be getting tipsy and I *will* be getting handsy."

"Yeah right. Your metabolism's too fast. Handsy, though? Go ahead."

Adora grins, amused, and it's a small expression, but Catra savors it with everything she can. "I broke my phone in the fight, too. Guess you'll have to take me home. Show me a nice time."

“I’m a fun time.” Catra steps closer, placing one knee on the bed before bothering to settle herself in. When she does, Adora gravitates to her like a planet’s moon, never to be separated. “I’m good at starting riots and uprisings, you know.”

“That was pretty great work.”

“It’s what she gets for putting you on trial like that. Things around Etheria were getting nasty in the headlines about powered people. So she throws you on the stand. Tries to make you the sacrifice for everyone else’s crimes. Hold you accountable in place of people like Prime. Asshole.”

Adora hums, in ignorance, in exhaustion, in agreement. Catra’s not really sure. Then, after a long time, “Can’t we go somewhere far? Forget all this? Retire some place?”

“We could,” Catra tells her. Her voice is a whisper, terrified of waking Adora up despite the fact neither of them can seem to fall asleep. “But would you actually like that?”

“No.” The answer makes Catra want to laugh. “But it’s nice to dream, isn’t it?”

“I guess it is.”

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Morning brings a sight Catra hasn’t had the satisfaction of holding in her eyes for years: Adora Grayskull, sharing the same space as her. It’s a feeling with ever-changing views over the years. When they were children, it meant comfort. Her friend was by her side. Her greatest friend who could never be separated from her, no matter the circumstance. As teenagers, it was the girl that made her heart go so fast she had to force her eyes away and tell herself Adora was the dumbest person on the planet. Mostly because she is. Adults, it was the empty bed Catra forever regretted. Then they started hooking up. But Adora never stayed. Adora was always gone afterwards, back to her castle and back to her career and destiny as the designated God of Bright Moon.

Gods never had time for people, yet Catra would sit, staring out the window with foolish anguish.

Now she stares again. The god is in her bed, resting for an inhuman amount of time, nearly a decade of exhaustion seeping into her bones. Adora never rests. Never stops. It’s all catching up to her now, and the most Catra can do is sit here and enjoy the silence. Not such a bad thing.

Then, when Adora rises, content from her only request after all this time, Catra pretends they’re both normal. They make breakfast together. Adora pours Melog’s food for Catra, a helpful housemate who’s always here to do so. They watch stupid videos on social media and laugh for hours on the couch. It’s so much it makes Catra’s torso ache.

Reality seeps back in. Prime is still out there, a man who also never sleeps. Just in time for sundown, Catra asks the question.

“Are you ready, Adora?”

“I’m ready.” The bracelet on her left forearm begins to glow in response, begging to be used for its truest purpose: justice. “Let’s go get him.”

Chapter End Notes

> So I wrote this chapter months and months and months ago, long before I was even working on this story yet. I wasn't sure what it was meant to be yet, but I knew it was worth keeping around. Definitely my favorite chapter in this one!

The Princess Alliance, Part One: Injustice

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"So I know we haven't had the most traditional or normal meeting before. Or interactions, really. Most of you guys probably didn't even know She-Ra was a fake person . . ."

Adora stops. She's way too tired to be playing the leader role right now. And way too uninformed about the others here. She's never met the Princesses, and she never imagined her first meeting with them in person would be because Shadow Weaver threw her into court hoping to save her own ass. On the bright side, they've already bonded over their mutual trauma in the court of law on official record with witnesses!

"Um," she winces at her own words, "I guess we can go over all those details later. Right now we need to focus on Prime."

The man's name snaps Adora back to reality. Her spine straightens out at the thought of her greatest line of responsibility pouring back into her veins, excited to get back in the field and restore this city back to the way it was before. Though, she considers, nothing will ever be the same after these events.

"Glimmer already reached out to me about it. Me and my associate talked about it further. We need all hands on deck. There is a device out there we've had made. A disruptor. It will send wavelengths out that block Prime's powers from entering peoples' minds. If anything, our inventor is making up some backup tools to help us. If there's even time. Either way, we're going to make it as difficult as possible for Prime to get the drop on us ever again. If you'll help us."

Three strange faces stare back at Adora. The other partial shapeshifter from Salineas, the water-based Princess named Mermista. Then there's Perfuma, who can take botany to the most

extreme levels. Finally there's Frosta, a young, young child shrouded in a full winter coat which swallows her up. She's much too young to even have to worry about this sort of thing, yet she's standing at the ready, taking on much more responsibility than any adult in this town's loyal government could ever hope to. She's more mature than Shadow Weaver, that's for sure.

Until she starts talking about how badly she desires to pound Prime's face into the ground. Still, the notion stands.

"What do you need from us?" Mermista asks. Her arms are crossed and she looks all around unimpressed, carrying the same energy Adora feels in ending all of this as quickly as possible. "Because Frosta's right; punching him out sounds like the best thing ever."

The third of the Princesses looks like she disagrees, but smiles regardless. Behind Adora, Glimmer is baring her fists at the ready. Meanwhile this is the most confident Adora's felt in weeks.

"It's simple," she tells them. "We need to keep the city busy. If we run around and bust all his activities while they happen, he'll be focused on creating more and more chaos. Mostly he's trying to prove a point, to make our superiors mad with their inability to stop him. The city's on fire and they can't put it out, sort of thing. Bust people. Make more chaos, if you have to. Just keep him distracted."

"While we're going around ruining his night," Glimmer says, "Adora will go in and deliver the final blow. Feel free to join at this point and punch him in the face, if you're in the area."

There's no hesitation as everyone gets going. Mermista mentions she has an associate back home known for starting fires, and she'll bring him in if necessary. Mostly he's perfect for annoying people and could make Prime just surrender right then and there. Bow picks out some places in town best to start with, spreading all the Princesses around town evenly. He and Glimmer plan on

taking the farthest post, but Glimmer makes sure to remind Adora she's quick and can be on the scene at an instant.

Adora's not worried about back up tonight. Tonight, she feels confident. If she loses again, she loses again. When she breaks, she fixes herself, again and again until she's new. Prime can break her all he wants. It will never mean he's won.

Quickly Adora crosses into a familiar part of town, knocking on a memorized apartment door at a memorized address. Catra answers, already equipped with her motorcycle keys in hand. Inside her apartment sits a woman with long purple hair, humming away as she fuses two pieces of metal together with a loud blowtorch. Hordak stands in the middle of the room, watching and trying his best to be a half decent assistant.

"She might have some more blockers for you if things get rough with Prime." Catra shuts the door halfway, securing some privacy between them both. "I will be in the area. If anything happens, I'll take care of it. Just focus on Prime and how badly his ass deserves to be kicked into the ground. Melog is going with you, too. He'll keep you hidden. Just trust him; he trusts you."

"Okay." Adora looks into Catra's eyes, feeling some sort of phantom ghost of boxing gloves on her hands; Catra, always in her corner, cheering her on no matter what. All odds are against them and here Catra is, helping Adora against a senseless cause. "I love you, Catra."

"That better not be a goodbye. Because I love you too and that would be beyond fucking cruel."

Adora shrugs, feeling herself start to grin. "Call it motivation, then. See you on the other side."

"Don't die up there, Grayskull."

All Adora can do before she takes off is wink, pushing her knees into the ground before launching up, up, up, placing herself amongst the heavens. One hand holds Catra's magical animal to

her chest, the cat himself not taking up much room at all. She looks into his bright eyes and he blinks up at her twice before shrouding her into her environment. She's never really dealt with an invisibility spell before. It's a shame she can't have some fun with it before rushing into the end goal, here. Maybe next time. She has a good feeling Glimmer is the perfect person to prank.

If Catra had Melog growing up, the foster home would have been a catastrophe. They all pranked one another enough—primarily Catra and Adora—and if Melog were in the picture things would've gotten too crazy too fast. Adora considers she and Catra might've even used the animal to run away somewhere better, forgetting their old lives completely and starting something new. Something much different than what they're about to do tonight.

Prime is near the top of a Bright Moon relic, an artistic piece done by Micah himself. A giant neon crescent moon, standing tall in the middle of a downtown area. Mostly office buildings and a giant mall around. Most of the buildings drown out the metal structure, but Adora has always believed it shouldn't be admired from afar. One should walk near it, see it with their own eyes. Now Prime stands on the short building behind it, observing his kingdom as everything burns and falls apart. Seems to be his favorite hobby.

That, or he's waiting for She-Ra to show up for round two.

She waits underneath the building in the fire escape, Melog clutched to her chest. She stares at her blank phone screen, waiting for the go-ahead from Catra. Just as they discussed: Adora will get a sixty second warning before heading up to Prime. They can chat. He can give his big speech for the second round. Once that minute is up, the disruptors go off and he falls to his knees, defeated.

Unless the machines are faulty given the short timeframe they've stuck Entrapta with.

She can see another news helicopter in the area, bearing down cameras at Prime. Perfect. They're handing him the infamy he's

been begging for all this time. It's wonderfully irritating in the sort of way that makes Adora want to rip a stair off this escape and chuck it at the cameras. They're waiting for her the same way Prime is. This is the second round, the final showdown, the all-or-nothing battle. The stakes are higher than before. So Adora waits, staring at her phone screen like a coward. If Prime wants to play games, she'll have to play games too.

Her screen blinks to life. Catra's name is the contact. **60 seconds. Go kick his ass.**

Adora stands, jumping onto the roof of the building, watching the brightness of the moon statue brighten and then lessen as Prime turns around to face the sound of her boots. He sees nothing, staring curiously at the spot. Adora steps as close as possible to him, nudging Melog to turn the powers off. The cat jumps from her hands, and she's met face-to-face with Prime, who laughs his head off like she's told the best joke ever in history.

"Impressive trick! Oh, you really duped me, Adora Grayskull."

"It's over, Prime. This is your last chance to come quietly." She stands tall, towering over the frail man with his thin frame and his sickly looking hair. His hands are bony, bones jutting out of cracked skin when he points at her.

"That is where you are mistaken," he says. "I have won, Adora. I have won years and years ago, from the moment I made myself known. The moment this Princess taskforce was spawned in retaliation, achieving nothing for almost a decade. I won the moment I dropped you from that building, and I won the moment Shadow Weaver threw together that trial to save her own hide. Imagine that. I know you saw it coming. She never was a good woman. Such a shame. I really thought she could make a difference; she's willing to do anything to get the job done. Including selling you out for PR."

"I saw it coming from a mile away. You're not pointing out any surprises here."

“Do you know why I have done what I have done? Because of things like that.” He points another bony finger out into the distance, framing the helicopter in his vision, next. “The idea of who we really are: above human. We’re better than those people who cower in fear. Who sit behind the courtroom desks and use the law as their greatest power. The law means nothing to us. We are gods! Who are they to separate the greats from the nothings! They put us in the dirt. You see where your beloved lives. She lives in the dirt! In a meaningless studio apartment! You and her are no different; she is a hybrid capable of many things. You and that feline there—you are no different. Myself and that cat—we are the same. Do you understand?”

“We’re gods and we should scare people into submission?”

“No. No, Adora. We’re gods, yes, and we should lead the way into the future. We are the true answer to truth and justice; to equality. If our government cannot be trusted with this power, we should grasp it within our own hands and rule. Scare people into submission, yes, sure! But it’s for the greater good. People are foolish, Adora. They need guidance.”

“People do need guidance. That’s true. They can be rash, and they can be tiresome to deal with. But scaring the life out of them and controlling their every action isn’t something that interests me.” She can hear something clicking in the distance, a sound which instantly catches her attention. “It’s time for you to go.”

Instantly Prime falls to his knees, and instantly Adora can hear the shift in the city. People asking where they are. Others gasping and sighing in relief when another drops whatever foolish thing it was they were doing. On the streets below Adora sees two people stop fighting, look at their hands, staring at one another for a long time before swallowing each other in a long and tight embrace. Prime kneels before her, groaning and feeling at the sides of his temples. She taps him on the shoulder with her sword, waiting for him to look up at her.

Both green eyes are littered with redness. His eyes begin to bleed as he holds the side of his head, and a demonic snicker falls across his lips. He stares up at her, and she stares down at him. Finally, the two are somewhat equals now. In the realization, Prime starts laughing hysterically. So Adora picks him up, yanking him by the collar of his long robes, one hand holding him high up in the air. A drop from here would make his knees buckle on impact, throwing him into the dirt. But all he does is laugh, letting his hands fall limply to the side as Adora keeps him hoisted high in the air for that chopper to catch live on the air. She hears the newscaster speaking loudly into his mic, pretending he knows what's really going on here.

Prime just looks into Adora's eyes and asks, "But I got everyone's attention, didn't I?"

She can't let him get away with that. "You are correct, in the end. We should be challenging all these things. But not like this. You're an awful, awful man, Prime, and I'm going to make sure no one ever sees you ever again. Despite everything, I wish you peace."

Then She-Ra raises her fist for the first time in the night, knocking Prime unconscious.

Chapter End Notes

> Just one more chapter left in this one! Thanks for reading, it seriously means a lot to me!!

The Princess Alliance, Part Two: Aftermath

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Yes, Adora Grayskull is my full legal name. There is no She-Ra in existence; she is me."

It would only make sense for Adora to take the stand last. It's what everyone is here for. She is their biggest and most famous hero, after all, and no one would watch the rest of this trial without waiting for her with baited breath. Every single one of them wanted this trial. A public and formal dragging of the people around them who would push them beyond the limits of what's fair and acceptable. Most importantly: everyone wants to see Shadow Weaver broken down for what she truly is, in front of thousands and thousands of witnesses. Truth and justice and all that.

Frosta took the stand alongside her parents first, and although she's so young she wasn't a small well of information. If anything, Frosta was the most important person on this stand, out of all of them. Eleven years old. Expected to perform the way someone in their adulthood might.

Perfuma was second on the stand, detailing how her forest town of Plumeria was nothing much for crime. Mostly people were happy out in the country, minding their own business. Many of Perfuma's important jobs were out of town, and the others with more importance somehow appeared on random properties. Big drug busts from people she'd never seen before, driving huge trucks hard to miss in the open roads. How fast the cameras were on the scene and how fast the articles hit the internet. There was nothing ever really wrong with Plumeria. Nothing that wasn't staged.

Mermista tells of the pirates plaguing her hometown, mostly stealing from big cargo ships and robbing docks of their supplies. Mermista has the poverty and homelessness rate of Salineas listed. It's the highest record ever recorded in the modern era, with little to no government aid, support, or acknowledgement. Just her, going after pirates from small towns who barely know how to wield weapons. None of them were nutritionally sound. None of them could stand a single hit from her—they were too weak and starved to do much of anything. Someone asks why they simply couldn't fish for themselves, and Mermista begins telling a horrifying tale of impossible-to-get fishing licenses and corporate companies blocking off fishing areas for their own personal lounging purposes. If someone so much as drops their line in the water, the next thing they know an officer is sailing to them with a massive fine they're expected to pay with money they don't have. She asks how any of this is fair, and no one seems to have the magic answer to the question.

The next trial Adora watches live. Glimmer and Bow, testifying on the stand together. They grew up together. Glimmer's tales of her parents prompts a giant outbreak of protests and all around chaos, strengthening her case to infinity. When she mentions her personal working contract it takes things to another level. Adora had a few other people pulled for the case, people she knew wouldn't mind speaking out against Shadow Weaver. Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio, Scorpia, and Catra. It turns into the Shadow Weaver hate club and Adora swears she sees Catra grinning the entire time she's on the stand, no matter how hard she tries to fight it.

Catra's gotten dressed up for the event, probably the best event she's ever attended in her life. This is the best day of Catra's life, and Adora can't help but laugh when she watches the live feed from her penthouse in the castle. It makes her forget just how nervous she is for her turn. So far the childhood stories are all lining up perfectly together, an air tight retelling of the absolute truth their opposition will find difficult to dispute. Catra gives more information on the jobs Shadow Weaver would call her up for, including all the strange hours she was expected to do half of them. She points out how many of these line up with similar jobs

She-Ra takes in and closes out around the same time frame. Then she finishes her part in all this, telling everyone they can ask She-Ra herself.

People want Adora's autograph as she enters the courthouse. Adora's. Not She-Ra. These people are actually talking to Adora, the real person behind the eight foot tall icon of the city, and everything about it is so strange. She's just a person, not a god, and they're looking at her like she's carrying the future in her hands. Maybe she is. But again, maybe she's just some girl who happens to have powers.

When she enters the courtroom, the feelings inside her chest are massively different from last time. First of all, she actually wants to be here. She doesn't feel totally dead inside, and Catra being here in the stands makes her feel confident as opposed to blowing her mind out of the water and making her feel stupid about her weeks of false grief. Adora's eyes meet Shadow Weaver's, and she feels a renewed sense of purpose.

Things begin right where Catra left off. The first thing she has to do is clarify she had no clue Catra was involved with any of these things, or involved with Shadow Weaver at all; she believed those two were done interacting when the foster home fell apart. Come to find out Prime was the one who helped Shadow Weaver get to the place she is now, swaying peoples' opinions and promoting her quickly. She tells everyone about the warehouse job Catra had to pull her from, and names this as her turning point; her final straw; her real hero moment. She explains she never met any of the other Princesses, people she was meant to be allied with, until she made it happen herself, in secret. Even then she would only meet Glimmer until recent events.

Questions by the numbers about her day-to-day life. About her job, and her expectations and role within the city's needs. She doesn't need to go too far into these details, as everyone else has done the work for her. One thing hits her completely by surprise, practically flooring her in the courtroom for everyone to see. Might

as well. Last time she was here she showed everyone her bare back.

"Next we will move on to the mental well-being of Adora Grayskull."

She's expected to undergo what really only feels like a public therapy session, explaining the feelings she carried behind her job. Her burnout, her lack of breaks, her strange work hours, her reaction to answering calls into the dead of night with no consistency. But she's not passionate about any of these answers. Any working person can experience the heavy workload, the crushing dread of stress and deadlines and expectations. So Adora changes the angle. She goes into the vast details of her health history.

"I can heal quickly. You could stab me right now on this stand, and by the time we're finished it would be like nothing happened." She sits up, straightening herself out. Mostly she's trying to find Shadow Weaver's masked face for the next set of words. "But that's not the issue. I feel the pain, that's the issue. Every stab, every punch, every kick and scratch and bruise. You can refer to the footage of my first altercation with Prime. Catra clawed my skin—not enough times to match the amount of scars I do have across my body—and I was in bed all day. Everything hurt, and everything was sore. After my second altercation with Prime, after I was thrown off the building, I needed injections to help my healing process. I still needed to be on temporary leave."

The courtroom is silent, shocked, still. Shadow Weaver tries to contain herself, but Adora knows for a fact she's sweating behind her mask. Adora's eyes meet Catra's, who motions her to go on. Keep telling her story. Keep talking until it's too much for the lot of them.

"It's always been like this, and for the most part Shadow Weaver is present for every doctor's visit. You can check those notes. Go ahead, go through my entire medical record—I don't care. I had a mountain of complaints every weekly visit, and every weekly visit

almost nothing would be done about anything. I have intense growing pains when I maintain She-Ra's form for too long. My joints ache into the night sometimes. I've had tinnitus since my early twenties and no one has ever made an effort to treat it. I'm not certain they were ever authorized to. I'm not sure they were even notified I was a normal human. See, they never treated Adora. They always treated She-Ra. I was required to enter and exit the room as She-Ra, and I was told never to mention this to any living soul. She-Ra wasn't the one who needed to be treated. Adora was. She-Ra's not even a real person, we've answered this already!"

Turns out Adora was not the last person, though the news headlines have been raving all about her. There really only is one other person out there more recognizable and more important than her: Prime. He does not reveal his true name, other than saying he uses the name which best fits him. He details what he calls the "Horde", his perfect army of "perfectly adjusted humans", better known as the gangs around town, all around winning him zero points. Adora watches everything from her penthouse, though she isn't alone. She doesn't think she ever will be ever again. Her lifelong allies are in here with her, including Bow and including Catra. No one else has ever really been in here before. The feeling is bizarre. The feeling is wonderful.

Prime tells everyone his master plan, clearly more than happy to have an audience who wants to record his each and every word. He wanted to show them what a perfect society looked like. He wanted to show them the truth, how caged they've all become underneath the current governing rule. How pathetic society is to chain down someone like She-Ra, rather than let her run free. Society is afraid of powered people, so they've forced them into small corners and poverty and decisions of whose matters matter and whose don't.

Ultimately, in the end, he did get what he wanted. He got the common man and the powered man to question the one thing they should've been questioning and demolishing from the start:

government officials too hungry for power to actually care about them.

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News journalists and amateur vloggers experience a goldmine for the next few days, cutting quickly into weeks. At every corner is a new piece of information, and at every corner is a race for who gets the story first. Some articles are messy, others take the time for quality over hits. Either way, they're all busy, and they're all more involved than ever before. Adora can't help but feel joy at something other than this week's trend from this week's Princess interview. She'll never forget the beauty store brawl she had to break up because everyone wanted to look like Glimmer.

Things are quiet in the castle. In the open. Behind many, many closed doors are frantic conversations and arguments. Glimmer is the first person to get any sort of news about her future, solely because of her aunt's help. It gets the ball rolling for everyone else, on the bright side. Glimmer's new contract settles first. Fair work hours. Actual time off. Her choice where to live. Her ability to opt out of jobs she doesn't want to get involved in. Perfuma and Frosta retire completely, and the government compensates them with free rent for life and anything else they might need. Perfuma isn't really interested. Mostly she just wants to go home and start her own farm. Frosta wants to grow up with an actual education and actually learn how to use her powers beyond what's needed. Mermista is more interested in reforming her town's finances. Glimmer wants to sort out crime in Bright Moon further, with people who actually care in charge. The concept is a long shot, but everyone has to start somewhere.

The greatest start to it all is knowing Shadow Weaver will be serving a sentence she can't reduce or dispute. Maybe she can hang out with Prime and get philosophical.

Adora stands alone in the fancy new penthouse the government has provided her with, possibly kissing her ass hardest out of the rest of them. She's taking a break, just for now. She received a

series of messages telling her *Just let us know if you need anything! We'll be at your command when needed!* She sends a letter to Catra and waits around for her to show up in person, with an answer to her question.

Unfortunately she enters the penthouse at just the wrong time, a perfect opportunity to watch Adora struggle with the thing she'll be focusing on while she has all this time off, the thing that'll hopefully help her latch onto normalcy and learn how to sit back and relax:

"You did not adopt that dog from the marketplace."

The dog breaks from Adora's grasp as she attempts to put his collar on, losing miserably to his high energy and overall joy. He does a couple laps around the packed furniture—courtesy of those at the office!—and knocks over smaller boxes before coming to a crashing halt at Catra's legs, who stares him down rather than petting him. So he barks, panting wildly and begging for some sort of attention. Catra would never give it to him.

"I did!" Adora gestures to the dog, just in case Catra managed to miss him. Somehow. "His name is Swift Wind! He can fly, too!"

"Great. Good thing you have such good experience with dogs." Finally Catra closes the door behind her, and finally she takes a real look at the new living space for Bright Moon's most famous face. Swift Wind runs over to the door to the patio and starts staring at a bird who's decided to land on the handrail outside.

Catra notes the shined tile floor, a soft brown against the light gray paint on the walls. The walls in the giant kitchen are a darker tone of gray, with a glass tile pattern behind the stove's wall, extending in both ways outward to the rest of the granite counters. She peeks down the hall and sees an even bigger library, bookshelves already installed. A perfect feature for Adora, who could read the world around itself and then read it again.

"This is a really nice place, Adora."

She remains in the middle of the room, standing awkwardly. Her body leans one way, like she's debating against taking a step forward, which she doesn't do at all. Just stands there, grinning strangely at Catra. Waiting for Catra's real answer to her real question, probably.

So Catra asks her, "Do you really think it's a good idea? You've been alone for a long time. I mean, all around this is a slam dunk for me. But does that idea really make you happy, Adora?"

"Yes." She doesn't wait to answer, doesn't think it over. But then again, knowing Adora, this idea's probably been in her head for years now, with lists and lists and lists stretching from one end of the room to the other. "But it's up to you. Obviously. It's been a long time, Catra. I've missed you. As fun as the secret hookups were."

"I've missed you, too." The words make Catra go red in the face. Gross. "My answer is yes. I've thought about it. Yes, I want to move in with you, Adora."

Whether or not it's because of the penthouse, Adora couldn't care less. She just wants some time with Catra, and if things between them blow up and don't work out, at least they can both say they tried. But she has a good feeling.

Over the next couple days the pair spend their time moving things around. They do it the traditional way, packing boxes into a small trailer on the back of the motorcycle, and Adora helps haul each of them onto an elevator and into the apartment with her bare hands. No fancy tricks. No launching the trailer on top of the roof, no matter how tempting. It's a normal people activity, and the both of them are more than excited to experience it. The feeling is strange, so slow, so boring, so dull, and it's the richest feeling Adora's ever experienced in her life. The last time she lived with Catra, neither of them had their own clothes to carry, never mind an entire motorcycle and a bed.

Best part: Melog and Swift Wind become best friends at an instant.

Time continues to pass them, and slowly the boxes are unpacked. New furniture is put together, sometimes poorly before it's taken apart and redone correctly with some laughs. They fall into a designated meal situation, and every night dinner is on the table. Decorations hang on the wall, old photos from the foster home are found and strung up. News stories slow, but they don't quit. Adora doesn't think they'll ever shut up about the events here, and it might be for the best interest of everyone's futures.

She gets an offer from a trusted source asking her and Catra to come down and do an interview. Take some pictures. An aftermath article for Bright Moon's biggest star and the differences her actions made. She turns them down. Then Catra changes her mind.

Most importantly: they asked for Adora, not She-Ra. They asked for the person within, not the hero on the billboards and the photoshopped action poses.

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"Hey, before we go, Glimmer told me something today. Something about you. It's nothing bad. It's great, actually. It's a—it's a job offer, Catra. For a big job. Like a *big* fucking job."

She's in the middle of throwing on her leather jacket from the rack by the door, all around ready to head out for the interview. It's taken Catra all week to mentally prepare for something like this, and now Adora's done her the pleasure of a huge curveball to shake her nerves all over the place. "What kind of big fucking job?"

"Glimmer nominated you. She's more involved with management type things. Anyway, it's a leadership position in a huge restoration project."

"What kind?" Catra crosses her arms, feeling impatient.

"It has to do with 'powered people in the aftermath of government bias'—those are Glimmer's words, not mine—and basically you would make sure projects are actually helping people instead of making good PR. She thinks you're perfect because you're upfront and honest and you don't take anyone's nonsense." Adora throws a grin Catra's way now when she adds, "My words, not hers."

Project manager was never on Catra's list, or anywhere within her radar. Especially with the people she hates the most: the Bright Moon government.

"You would be the highest rank on the project. Even over me and my role. You really only have to report to Glimmer, and even then Glimmer is easy. The project is basically yours. If you want it."

The response is short, in a strange fashion. Like Catra suddenly forgot how to say no. "I'll think about it. Ready to go?"

"What if I finally took you out to a nice dinner? Would that change your mind at all?"

Catra grins, dropping her reach for the door handle. "I have barely gotten the chance to think it over to begin with."

"I know, I'm just impatient."

"How about we race to the photoshoot and if you win, I'll consider the offer."

"Deal. You're so on. One, two, three, go!"

Adora blasts through the open door to the patio, giving Catra no chance to race downstairs for the motorcycle. She almost considers staying up here just to trick Adora, maybe hide somewhere in the apartment and jumpscare the life out of her, but she doesn't. She can't. She has a race to win.

Within a week the pair gets an advance copy of the publication. Adora and Catra on the cover, dressed in formal wear and smiling

like they don't have a care in the world. They've placed Adora in a long white gown, a golden tiara on her head with golden accents around the ends of the dress. Catra wears a contrasting red button-up with dark black pants. A long gold stripe runs down the sides of the legs, and she's given other golden attire for the shirt, such as a pin to cinch it closed. Over one shoulder sits a white and gold half-cape which drapes down her torso. The front cover features them both, slow dancing with her foreheads touching.

The article within is smartly written, as well. A complete and honest feature about who Adora really is, and what really matters to her. It's the interview She-Ra was never given beyond how much she can deadlift and which celebrities she likes. Adora is asked intellectual questions, namely politics, and it gives her a huge breath of relief. Things really are changing, if this is the direction the news is going. At least one publication out there is going the right direction, and that's enough for her.

Catra flips through more pages and finds more images of Adora. Not She-Ra. It's Adora in those photos, taking action shots with weights and showing off her human physique. All sorts of inspirational praise is written in these pages, but the words slip past her. She can't believe they actually care about *her,* and not the other version of her. Catra sits with her on the couch, grinning widely at the images. She sets the copy down on the table in front of them both, leaning backward against the chair.

"I'll take you up on dinner. Tonight. Somewhere fancy and expensive but close by, so I can get handsy as hell. My current answer is leaning towards no, but I can be influenced."

Adora laughs, "You're such a liar. You want that job so bad."

"Sure I do. But no is always on the table. Also, I was promised free dinner. It's a concept I learned from my roommate growing up: always go for the food."

"Hey, it's not my fault my metabolism is so crazy. But fine. Where would you like to go, potential business partner?"

“Up to you. Like I said, something expensive, something close by.”

“Can we wear the photoshoot outfits? They’re so pretty.”

“Duh, dummy. I’m not wearing my jeans or anything.”

It doesn’t take long to get ready, though they do it separately in an attempt to surprise one another. Mostly, Catra takes herself to Scorpia to talk the new job over. She already knows Scorpia will tell her to choose what makes her happy—which she totally does—but the effort of asking for the advice is enough. When the words hit the air, Catra considers she already has her answer set in stone. She feels a longing for the words, a twinge of anxiety at the prospect of Scorpia telling her it’s the dumbest idea on the planet. But she doesn’t, and Catra’s gut goes back to normal.

Stupid Adora. She was right.

Adora shows up at Scorpia’s door, almost as familiar as the empty apartment next to it, grinning wide. She’s red in the face. Nervous. A giant bouquet of flowers are tucked behind her and she presents them, nearly dropping them. Neither she or Catra has done this sort of thing before. The idea is terrifying, but the idea of never doing it scares Catra even more.

The motorcycle awaits them both, cooling in the night air against the road. Adora is more intact than she was before, and Catra finds all those words she’s fantasized about to come true. Adora tells her how awesome the bike is, how cool it is she has it at all. The wind blasts through both of their hair, thoroughly messing up the work they’ve both put into their looks tonight, but not a worry is thrown towards it. Catra takes things slowly, expanding their trip through town. Underneath the neon city lights they travel, patiently going light to light until the restaurant meets them.

Together they enter, sitting somewhere far off in the corner where no one can bother them. A few people look their way, but Adora politely waves them off. She’s here for something else tonight. Catra stares at her from across the table, talking about nothing.

It’s something she’d never imagined for either of them, nothing. A boring conversation about where to move that extra shelf. If the TV is in the best spot it should be in. Then they talk about that silly TV show they watched the other day, how funny the characters were. An hour passes them and neither has left the table. No phones have buzzed throughout the night, and no reports of half the town screaming and exploding falls into either of their radars.

Catra and Adora sit together, enjoying their meal. Then they leave, returning to their own home, silence and togetherness following them further. Tomorrow they’ll do it all over again, and the next day they’ll wake in bed to each other once more.

Chapter End Notes

> This was a fun one to power through, and by power through I mean it’s probably the fastest I’ve ever put a story together. It was a fun one and I thought it really reflected Adora as a person as well as her relationship with Catra. Thank you so much for reading this story, it really means a lot to me!
>
> I still have a few SPOP stories left in me, but to be honest my muse is screaming and screaming in my ears for me to chase the Locked Tomb series, and Arcane down the line after that, so chase I shall. I’m not really sure when I’m popping back into SPOP just yet, but I for sure have a couple left in me. These characters are awesome and they make me go fucking insane man

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!